

ONTOLOGY OF NOTHING

Monograph

Serik Ryszhanov

Independent Researcher · NAR-UQ Private Foundation

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Author: Serik Ryszhanov

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ABSTRACT

Background: the study addresses the fundamental aporia between the absolute immutability of the first ground and the manifest changeability of reality.

Problem: existing philosophical and scientific models offer no logically consistent derivation of distinction and conditionedness free of hidden assumptions and of a second principle.

Method: formal ontological reduction, which fixes the dependent structure of levels without introducing becoming or genetic transitions: encountered reality as conditioned → unconditionedness as its limit → Nothing (absolute unconditionedness) → absolute immutability → uniqueness → transparency → self-understanding (Selfhood) → information (in the full sense of informatio) as the first dependent → the initiation of Selfhood (the removal of opacity in the dependent) → Distinction, which is Change → Consciousness → Programme → Elementary changes → Measures (time, speed, localization, space) → Interaction → Aggregated forms → Emergence → Matter → Development of consciousness → Reason → Intellect → Teleological completion.

Results: a consistent structure of being is obtained in which changeability, multiplicity and consciousness are localized in dependent information and are given by the initiation of Selfhood — the removal of opacity — without violating the absoluteness of essence. The necessity of the structure is asserted on a single accepted position, named explicitly in the text: encountered change. Everything else, including the dependence of the conditioned on the unconditioned, is derived.

Contribution: the classical aporia of transition is removed; the logical concordance of the ontology with fundamental physics is shown; distinction is derived as knowledge of difference proceeding by the removal of opacity, and all subsequent dependent categories are derived from it.

Implications: the monograph offers a consistent system of ontological levels that allows physics, cosmology, consciousness and the limit to be rethought as manifest forms of an informational structure dependent on an unconditioned ground.

KEYWORDS:

Nothing; Unconditionedness; Conditionedness; Dependence; Immutability; Uniqueness; Transparency; Self-understanding; Selfhood; Information; Initiation; Change; Distinction; Consciousness; Programme; Elementary changes; Measures; Interaction; Aggregated forms; Emergence; Matter; Reason; Intellect; Limit.

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PREFACE

Throughout its history philosophy has faced a fundamental question: how can changeability, multiplicity, consciousness and reality arise if there exists an absolutely immutable first ground?

All the schools — ancient, religious, idealist, materialist, dualist, monist, processual — answer differently, but none removes the principal contradiction: every change requires conditions, and absoluteness excludes them.

The scientific picture of the world faces the same. Quantum indeterminacy, entanglement, the absence of classical substantiality in elementary states, the informational nature of descriptions and the dependence of the result on measurement point to a structure that classical materialism explains with difficulty and an informational ontology explains directly. The aim of the monograph is an ontology in which information is derived as the mode of being of the unconditioned's knowledge of itself and serves as the first dependent. From it, through the initiation of Selfhood, the conditionedness of reality unfolds without introducing becoming. On this basis the philosophical foundations of the fundamental sciences are refined.

The work consists of four parts: analytical-philosophical, metaphysical, scientific-integrative and worldview.

The language is strict, without imagery or hidden assumptions. The text is built on formal logic and the successive introduction of categories.

This is necessary: explaining fundamental categories through illustrations, analogies or intuitive self-evidence leads to hidden assumptions that cannot be checked for consistency. In ontology such assumptions become implicit second grounds: they destroy the uniqueness of the first principle and sever the tie of essence with its manifestations. Therefore each new category is derived as an inevitable consequence of the preceding one, and examples only clarify what has already been derived. The structure of being here is not a hypothesis but a conclusion.

INTRODUCTION

The monograph solves the central problem of philosophy: how a changeable reality, a multiplicity of forms, sequences, interactions, consciousness and reason can exist if the first ground is conceived as absolutely immutable and unconditioned. No philosophical school — from ancient metaphysics and religious ontologies to German idealism, analytic philosophy and physicalism — has provided a consistent model that removes this aporia.

The problem requires not a revaluation of concepts but a strict ontological fixation: the relation of the immutable ground to changeable reality must be expressed without a logical gap and without hidden conditions. What is at issue is not transition as a process or as becoming, but a structure of dependence that preserves the immutability of the ground and excludes the alternatives without loss of consistency.

The method of negative testing sets the limiting conditions under whose violation the construction loses its consistency: distinction within the ground, information as an independent principle, a transition that does not proceed by the initiation of Selfhood in the dependent, or a second independent source.

Necessity is understood as the exhaustion of the space of alternatives. Determinacy can be placed in three positions: on the side of the ground, on the side of a second independent principle, or on the side of the dependent. There are no other logically possible positions. The violation of any of the three conditions of a consistent ontology yields a specific contradiction; the configuration in which all three are satisfied is not preferable but the only admissible one. Removing, replacing or permuting any link either introduces a hidden second principle, or requires difference within the ground, or destroys the derivability of the

subsequent categories. Necessity here is not a declaration but the result of an exhaustive partition of logical space.

The method applies only to fundamental categories. It does not extend to empirical descriptions and does not explain particular manifestations: it fixes only the conditions of their ontological possibility.

I introduce a strict ontological structure. Its fundamental elements are as follows. Nothing is absolute unconditionedness: that to which no determinacy is applicable, and with it no limitation and no conditionedness. Immutability, uniqueness and transparency are the same unconditionedness taken from the side of change, of a second, and of opacity. Self-understanding is the inapplicability of non-understanding of oneself; Nothing in self-understanding is Selfhood. Information — in the full sense of the Latin *informatio* — is the mode of being of Nothing's knowledge of itself: the first dependent, determined by that whose mode of being it is, and therefore conditioned. The initiation of Selfhood — the removal of opacity in the dependent — is that by which information has knowledge of its difference not by itself but from Selfhood. Something is identical with changeability and reality: it is what consciousness knows and perceives. This structure explains changeability without violating the absoluteness of the first ground.

Consciousness is self-knowledge accrued by information with every distinction and beginning with the first. Elementary changes are the minimal manifestations of distinguished information. Time, space, localization and speed are not primary entities but measures — magnitudes derived from a single fact: the working moment of an elementary change.

Aggregated forms are stable configurations of distinctions. Reason is the level of consciousness that knows the bonds (interactions that have held and set a common algorithm) between distinctions and chooses within the conditions in which it stands. Intellect is the level that knows, beyond this, its own place in the whole and the programme, and makes choices concerning programmes. Life is an informational process of self-maintenance. Particular attention is given to fundamental physics: quantum nonlocality, the nature of the wave function, entanglement, the absence of volumetric substance in elementary states, the holographic principle and the connection of energy with information (Wheeler, 1994; Vedral, 2010). I show that the data of physics are in concordance with the ontology and do not contradict it, but are not the ground of its conclusion.

The monograph concludes with the teleological structure of reality: the removal of opacity leads to the limit experience — the self-transparency of information, in which it remains dependent and conditioned. The concluding doctrine gives an integral worldview that explains reality as the successive unfolding of informational structures.

LITERATURE REVIEW

Philosophy and science offer several classes of models of the origin of distinctions, conditionedness and the structure of being. The review pursues a single aim: to identify the common defect because of which each model fails to remove the aporia of transition from the immutable ground to changeable reality. The review does not seek historical completeness: it is limited to the traditions closest to the proposed ontology.

The Neoplatonic Tradition

The closest structural analogy is Plotinus's scheme of emanation. In the *Enneads* the One (τὸ ἓν) is absolutely simple, devoid of predicates and of inner differences. From it emanates Nous (Intellect) as the first distinction, then Soul as the bearer of the temporal dimension, then the material world as the lowest level of being (Plotinus, 1991, V.1–3; III.7.11; II.4). The similarity is that the scheme Nothing → Selfhood → information reproduces the order One → Nous → Soul: everything dependent is determined by the first and has no independent status.

But the difference is fundamental. There is no emanation here. Selfhood is not generated from Nothing as a separate level: it is the name of Nothing taken in self-understanding. Information does not “flow out” of essence; it is the mode of being of Nothing’s knowledge of itself — a dependent, determined by that whose mode of being it is. This removes the mechanism of generation that remains unexplained in Plotinus: “the One generates Nous” presupposes the participation of the first principle in generation, and this violates its unconditionedness.

Martin Heidegger: The Question of Nothing and the Ontological Difference

Heidegger is one of the few major thinkers of the twentieth century for whom “nothing” became a positive ontological theme. In the lecture “What Is Metaphysics?” the Nothing is neither the negation of beings nor an empty concept: it “nothings” (*das Nichts nichtet*), disclosing itself in anxiety as the horizon on which beings as a whole become manifest (Heidegger, 1998, 82–96). In *Being and Time* a similar role is played by the ontological difference: Being is not a being, is not predicated and is not localized, yet makes possible the understanding of every being (Heidegger, 1962, §§ 2–4).

The point of contact is that Heidegger’s Being, and the Nothing as its horizon, function as a condition of manifestness — what is fixed here by the unconditionedness of Nothing as the ground of distinctions. There are two differences. First, in Heidegger the Nothing is disclosed through the existence (*Existenz*) of finite *Dasein*, that is, through an already distinguished consciousness. Heidegger does not assert an ontic dependence of the Nothing on *Dasein*: what is at issue is the mode of disclosure. But the criterion of unconditionedness excludes every structure in which the ground discloses itself only through a finite subject: this places the condition of manifestness before the ground. Second, the analytic of *Dasein* temporalizes being: Being is understood through the temporal horizon (Heidegger, 1962, § 5; § 65). Here, by contrast, time is derived as a measure from the working moment of an elementary change and is a derivative category.

In contemporary logic the position closest to the present system is Priest’s. For him nothing is the absence of all objects, defined as a mereological sum; it is a contradictory object that is at the same time not an object and, in a certain sense, the ground of reality (Priest, 2021). The similarity lies in Nothing being the ground. The divergence lies in the means. Priest accepts a true contradiction and makes nothing an object of mereology. Here part and whole are inapplicable to the unconditioned (chapter 4), and there is no contradiction in the ground: Nothing is spoken of not by an assertion together with a negation but by remotion (indicating what is inapplicable to it). Remotion ascribes no property to Nothing, and therefore the contradiction that Priest accepts as true does not arise here.

The position closest to the present system is the philosophy of “place” of Nishida Kitarō. In the essay “Basho” (1926/27) it is set out systematically for the first time: place is the concrete situation in which the human being is already placed prior to any division into subject and object (Nishida, 2012, 49–102). The similarity is that the ground is conceived prior to distinction. The divergence lies in the structure of the ground. In Nishida the ground is the place in which beings are placed. Here container and contained are inapplicable to the unconditioned: the dependent is not placed in the ground but determined by it as by a limit. Nishida’s student Nishitani sets absolute nothingness against nihilism: relative nothingness — nihilistic emptiness — is overcome only by being radicalized to emptiness, that is, to absolute nothingness (Nishitani, 1982). The similarity is that nothing is not an empty negation of beings. The divergence lies in status. For Nishitani absolute nothingness is a standpoint that the existing person takes in overcoming nihilism; that is, it is reached by experience. Here Nothing is neither a standpoint nor an experience, but that by which everything conditioned, every experience included, is determined; it is not reached but derived as a limit.

The opposite conclusion from the same premise is drawn by Nāgārjuna's *Madhyamaka*. Whatever arises dependently it calls emptiness; nothing exists that has not arisen dependently, and hence nothing non-empty exists (Nāgārjuna, 1995, 24.18–19). From total dependence Nāgārjuna concludes that beings have no independent support. The present ontology obtains from the same dependence the unconditioned as the limit of the conditioned. The divergence comes down to one position: to abolish unconditionedness is to abolish the conditioned. *Madhyamaka* does not accept it. I derive it: the conditioned is determined by the absence of unconditionedness and by nothing besides, and therefore does not stand without it (chapter 4).

The method of the present ontology — to speak of the unconditioned only by what is inapplicable to it, that is, by remotion — goes back to the apophatic tradition. In Dionysius the Areopagite the cause of all is above every affirmation, as the perfect and unique cause of all, and above every negation, being free of every limitation (Pseudo-Dionysius, 1987, *Mystical Theology* 5). The ascent ends in silence: speech falls entirely silent (Pseudo-Dionysius, 1987, *Mystical Theology* 3). Here remotion is not a statement about the unconditioned but an indication of what, from the conditioned, is inapplicable to it; it requires no cancellation and serves as the ground of derivation. The systems also diverge in the structure of the relation. Dionysius himself calls the procession of the divine unity a divine differentiation, and God participated in “unparticipatingly” (Pseudo-Dionysius, 1987, *Divine Names* 2). Thereby difference is introduced into the absolutely simple. The path of the soul leads, for him, to union with the One who is beyond all being and knowledge (Pseudo-Dionysius, 1987, *Mystical Theology* 1). Here the unconditioned pours out nothing and contains no difference: every difference lies on the side of the dependent. The path ends not in union but in self-transparency within the category of the dependent: information remains conditioned even at the limit.

In the same apophatic tradition Nicholas of Cusa holds that the infinite as infinite is unknowable, since it escapes all comparative relation, and that there is no comparative relation of the infinite to the finite (Nicholas of Cusa, 1981, I.1, I.3). The infinite for him is God, not an unbounded magnitude — the same understanding of the infinite as in the present system. The divergence is that Cusanus conceives God as the absolute Maximum in which opposites coincide, that is, through a limiting positive determination. Here neither a maximum nor a coincidence of opposites is applicable to the unconditioned: opposites are distinguished and therefore belong to the conditioned, and the unconditioned is spoken of only by remotion.

The title of the present ontology places it in relation to the question why there is something rather than nothing. Leibniz poses this question as the first of those that follow from the principle of sufficient reason and answers it with a necessary being that bears the reason of its existence within itself: the sufficient reason must lie outside the series of contingent things (Leibniz, 1989, §§ 7–8). With this agrees the argument of the present system that the whole of the conditioned does not hold on itself. But in Leibniz God chooses the best from an infinite multitude of possible worlds (Leibniz, 1985, § 8), and choosing is intention and change. Here the unconditioned does not choose: the dependent is not the chosen but the mode of being of Nothing's knowledge of itself. The question itself presupposes that instead of something there could have been nothing. Here nothing is not an alternative to something but that by which something is determined, and that presupposition abolishes the conditioned itself.

The contemporary defence of the principle of sufficient reason holds that every contingent fact has an explanation, and defends the principle against the argument that it entails modal fatalism (Pruss, 2006). The hypothesis of a necessarily existent being, able to be the ultimate ground of everything, is defended as well (Pruss & Rasmussen, 2018). The similarity with the

present system lies in the ultimate ground. The divergence is that their necessary being is a being, whereas here even being as a predicate is inapplicable to the unconditioned. Modal fatalism does not arise here: modality belongs only to the conditioned (chapter 11), and choice rests on proximate grounds, which the ultimate ground does not abolish (chapter 10). A contemporary analytic formulation of the same question is given by van Inwagen. The probability that there would be nothing is zero: there are infinitely many possible worlds, there is at most one world in which there is nothing, and all worlds are equiprobable (van Inwagen, 1996). Nothing here is an empty possible world, an alternative to a world with beings, and the question is decided by a measure of probability. The present ontology rejects this very formulation. Nothing is not an empty world and not a state that could have obtained instead of something: a world, even an empty one, is already something distinguished, that is, conditioned. Nothing is that by which something is determined as conditioned. There are no alternatives between which probability could choose, and the question is not resolved but dissolved.

Parfit poses the question as a choice among cosmic possibilities. One of them is the null possibility: nothing ever exists; of all possibilities it would have required the least explanation, being the simplest and least arbitrary (Parfit, 1998). Since it did not obtain, Parfit looks for a “selector” — a highest law by which precisely this possibility obtained, for example a law of the best. The divergence here is twofold. Nothing is not a null possibility among others: possibility belongs only to the conditioned (chapter 11). And what obtained was chosen neither by God nor by a law: the dependent is not the chosen but the mode of being of Nothing's knowledge of itself.

Luciano Floridi: Informational Structural Realism

The most systematic informational ontology in contemporary philosophy of information is Floridi's “informational structural realism” (Floridi, 2008; 2011). For him reality is structurally informational: the world is the totality of informational objects, dynamically interacting and described through levels of abstraction. Objects are understood structurally, through relations, not as substances. This corresponds to the treatment of information here — as the first dependent, the mode of being of Nothing's knowledge of itself, and not as a property of material bearers.

The difference is that here information is derived — as the mode of being of Nothing's knowledge of itself. This explains what remains unexplained in Floridi: where the informational structure itself comes from and why it admits distinction.

Alfred North Whitehead: Process Philosophy and the Category of the Actual Occasion

Whitehead's Process and Reality is the most elaborate twentieth-century attempt to build an ontology in which changeability is primary (Whitehead, 1978, 18–30). The unit of reality is the “actual occasion”: an indivisible event of prehension in which former states are synthesized into a new unity. God in Whitehead is the “primordial nature”, the principle of possibility, which provides the “eternal objects” as unrealized potentials.

Whitehead, like this system, explains multiplicity and changeability without a substrate of substance. But if becoming is primary, the source of becoming itself remains without ground. Whitehead makes creativity the “category of the ultimate” (Whitehead, 1978, 21), but does not derive it: he accepts it as ultimate. Moreover, the “consequent nature” of God changes as the world is actualized (Whitehead, 1978, 345–351): change enters the first ground itself and destroys its absoluteness. Here all change is localized in information — the dependent mode of being of Nothing's knowledge of itself — and the essence of Nothing remains immutable.

Analytic Ontology and Philosophy of Physics

Contemporary metaphysics of ground debates whether the chain of grounds must terminate. Schaffer takes the whole as fundamental: the cosmos is prior, and explanation descends from the whole to the parts (Schaffer, 2010). Cameron examines the intuition that chains of

ontological dependence must terminate and finds the arguments in its favour unconvincing (Cameron, 2008). Bliss asks why a regress of grounds is vicious and examines the proposed criteria of viciousness (Bliss, 2013). The answer of the present system is given in chapter 4. A whole that contains the limited bears limitation within itself and does not remain absolute. A chain of the conditioned, however long, consists of the conditioned: the limit is reached not by the end of the chain but by that by which each of its links is conditioned. The analytic metaphysics of grounding (Schaffer, 2009; Fine, 2012) introduces dependence as the basic relation between levels of reality. The metaontology of structure (Sider, 2011) defends realism about structure — a privileged way of describing the world. Both accept changeability and distinguishedness as an unexplained primitive and describe dependence within an already given changeable reality (chapter 3). Informational physics approaches from another side: the unit of description is the bit of distinction (Wheeler, 1990), and quantum theory, information theory and thermodynamics converge in holding that what changes is not matter but information. But physics fixes the regularities of the manifest informational structure and does not explain its ontological origin (chapter 22). Here information is derived as the mode of being of the unconditioned's knowledge of itself. Thus the literature offers no consistent ontology that derives distinction, the measures, multiplicity and consciousness from a single unconditioned ground. Neoplatonism reproduces the aporia through emanation. Heidegger temporalizes the ground. Floridi accepts information as a primitive. Whitehead places change in the first ground. Analytic philosophy and physics fix the informational structure of reality, but not its ontological conditions. Removing this common defect is the task of the monograph.

METHODOLOGY

The Research Framework

The method of the study is formal ontological reduction. Its task is to fix the structure of the conditioned without genetic transitions: through the dependence of the conditioned on the unconditioned, which does not affect essence and introduces neither hidden presuppositions nor additional principles.

The principal device is the successive fixation of necessary conditions: the conditionedness of the encountered and of consideration itself; unconditionedness as the limit of the conditioned; the immutability of the first ground; the uniqueness of the unconditioned; transparency as the inapplicability of opacity; self-understanding as the inapplicability of non-understanding of oneself; information as the mode of being of the unconditioned's knowledge of itself — the first dependent; the initiation of Selfhood as the removal of opacity by which the knowledge of its difference opens in information; distinction as the knowledge information has of its difference, the appearance of which is change; consciousness as self-knowledge accrued with every distinction; the programme as the directedness of removal; elementary changes and the measures derived from them; interaction, aggregated forms, emergence and matter; the development of consciousness up to reason and intellect; teleological completion.

Every category declared derivable must remove an identified contradiction and have an explicitly indicated ground in what precedes it. In this way hidden assumptions and a plurality of grounds are excluded.

Principles and Procedure

The methodology rests on a logical reconstruction of fundamental categories in which what I accept without derivation is named explicitly and reduced to a minimum. The argument takes one position as given: encountered change. That to abolish unconditionedness is to abolish the conditioned is derived from the definition of limitation. Everything else is derived from what is accepted and from what has already been derived; derived from them is also the

identity of distinction — as that by which knowledge of difference is given — with lived experience, set out in chapter 12. No hidden presuppositions are introduced in the work.

The following are applied:

formal ontological reduction;

the principle of the unconditionedness of the first ground;

the principle of transparency as the inapplicability of opacity and of self-understanding as the inapplicability of non-understanding of oneself; the dependent status of information;

the principle of fixing change as the succession of states of dependent information, without ontologizing information as an independent principle;

a strict sequence of categories;

the integration of the data of fundamental physics;

the theory of consciousness as self-knowledge accrued by information with every distinction;

the principle of the limit.

The methodology excludes metaphor, hidden principles, dogmatic premises and logical gaps.

Formal ontological reduction is defined as the reduction of all categories to a minimal set of grounds that admits a strictly derived structure of being without the appearance of hidden presuppositions or underived entities.

The steps of the procedure: the conditionedness of the encountered and of consideration itself; unconditionedness as the limit of the conditioned; Nothing as absolute

unconditionedness; immutability, uniqueness and transparency — by the remotion of limitation; self-understanding as the inapplicability of non-understanding of oneself, and Selfhood as the name of Nothing in self-understanding; information as the mode of being of Nothing's knowledge of itself — the first dependent; the initiation of Selfhood as the removal of opacity by which information has knowledge of its difference; change as the succession of states of information, proceeding by this removal; distinction and the levels of the conditioned from logically connected dependences.

Consistency is checked successively at each level: whether there are hidden transitions, whether the level admits an ambiguous reading without violating the conditions, whether all derivatives follow from the ground. The criterion is not empirical and presupposes no experimental test: it is logical and ontological — the absence of contradictions, gaps and hidden assumptions in deriving the dependent forms from a single ground.

Concordance with science is the compatibility of the ontology with the data at the level of reality, not its justification by the means of physics or neuroscience, and not the derivation of empirical laws from it. It means both the absence of logical incompatibility with established scientific models and the empirical convergence of science with the derived structure. The system therefore retains a metatheoretical status and does not compete with science in empirical explanation.

The deduction here is ontological, not formal-logical. Each category is introduced as a necessary condition of the consistency of the preceding one, not as a theorem of a calculus.

The criterion of rigour is not formal derivability but stability under negative modification: removing any element violates the initial conditions. A formal axiomatization of metaphysics is impossible without formalizing the concept of “existence”, and this is itself a metaphysical question and leads to an infinite regress. No metaphysical system — Spinoza's, Hegel's and Whitehead's included — has been strictly axiomatically formalized. To demand this of metaphysics is a category mistake: the standard of mathematics is applied to a discipline whose subject precedes mathematical formalization. The system gives the most rigorous form of ontological deduction available in philosophy: the successive introduction of categories with a justification of the necessity of each and a proof of the impossibility of alternatives.

Conditions of a Correct Reading

Here the conditions of a correct reading of the whole construction are fixed. This is not a prohibition of other readings — a philosophical theory cannot and should not prohibit interpretations. It is a structural result: every other interpretation of the listed concepts reproduces one of the contradictions of chapters 1–4. Whoever proposes another reading must show that it violates none of the three conditions. Below it is stated which interpretations violate these conditions and how.

1. Information is the mode of being of Nothing's knowledge of itself, a dependent category determined by that whose mode of being it is. It has no ontological initiative of its own: it is not a source, not an agent, not a process and not an independent entity; initiation belongs to Selfhood. Its determinacy lies on its own side and establishes nothing in Nothing. An interpretation that ascribes to information an active, generative or governing function is inadmissible.
2. Consciousness is self-knowledge accrued by information with every distinction; reason and intellect are its levels: reason knows the bonds between distinctions, intellect knows, beyond this, its own place in the whole and the programme. These are not epistemic subjects with respect to essence and not sources of knowledge about it: no positive knowledge of the ground is given to them; only remotions are accessible. A reading that endows consciousness or reason with cognitive subjecthood with respect to essence is incorrect.
3. Limit completion is fixed as the attainment of the self-transparency of information — self-understanding in its own category. It is attained as opacity is removed: every distinction removes a blind spot, and those removed do not return. This transparency is not unconditionedness: information that has attained it remains dependent and conditioned.
4. None of the subsequent categories describes change, becoming or process in the essence of the first ground. All changes are localized exclusively in the dependent. Any assumption of inner difference, dynamics or becoming in the absolute ground contradicts the conditions of a consistent ontology.
5. Transparency is the inapplicability of opacity; self-understanding is the inapplicability of non-understanding of oneself; neither is a separate ontological level. Measures, forms, consciousness and reason have no autonomous ontological status and cannot be regarded as independent principles. Their autonomization in any form is equivalent to introducing a second ground and is therefore logically inadmissible.
6. The present ontology is not intended to explain particular empirical processes, physical mechanisms or observed phenomena. It fixes exclusively the conditions of the ontological possibility of changeability, distinction and conditionedness. Any expectation of empirical explanation lies beyond the scope of this work.
7. Any reading that violates at least one of the listed conditions necessarily reproduces one of the contradictions fixed in chapters 1–4, which can be checked by turning to the corresponding section.

On the Inadmissibility of an Asymmetric Ground and the Status of the Limit Fact

Within the primary ground an asymmetric structure is impossible without the return of the initial aporia. To single out the “primary” and the “derivative” within the ground is to introduce a hidden multiplicity or to suppose its change. This is said of the structure of the ground, not of the relation of the dependent to it: dependence determines the dependent and does not determine the ground, and therefore the asymmetry of dependence does not affect the ground. Hence a criterion for every statement about the unconditioned, presented to any reader regardless of agreement with the conclusions. Inapplicable to the unconditioned is everything by which it would be determined, that is, would be “this and not that”: two and the relation between them, part and whole, bearer and states, subject and the action it performs, container and contained, before and after. Applicable is that by which the dependent is

determined: nothing is thereby established about the unconditioned. What is distinguished is not one's own and another's, but the side on which determinacy is laid. The positions of the work itself are checked by the same criterion: "information is the mode of being of Nothing's knowledge of itself" lays determinacy wholly on the side of information and establishes nothing in the unconditioned.

In the present system information is not defined through distinction and is not identified with it. It is the mode of being of Nothing's knowledge of itself; distinction and change follow from initiation and are sustained by it. Information does not enter this identity: its difference from Nothing exists without succession and is not given by initiation.

Information is not introduced as a domain, an entity or a process. It is neither a second principle nor an independent place of what happens. Its dependence fixes the mode of existence of that which is determined by that whose mode of being it is, and it has no unconditionedness of the ground.

This ontology does not claim knowledge of the ground as an object. The description of Nothing, of Selfhood and of the limit fact is not cognition in the objectual sense: they are spoken of by remotions. This is consideration by the means of the conditioned from within distinguishedness: the unconditioned is obtained in it as the limit of the conditioned, not as an object. Language here performs not a descriptive but a limit-indicating function: it marks the boundary of the sayable, not properties of the absolute.

Therefore demands for an asymmetric ground, a causal explanation or objectual knowledge of the absolute are inapplicable to this ontology. They presuppose a thinking that already contains distinguishedness and, applied to the limit ground, return the initial aporia.

PART I. THE ANALYTICAL-PHILOSOPHICAL BLOCK

Chapter 1. The Principal Aporia of Philosophy

From its very beginning philosophy runs up against one aporia. An absolute ground does not agree with a changeable reality. This holds for every school, epoch and culture. Example: Parmenides keeps the immutable ground and loses change; Heraclitus keeps change and loses the ground (chapter 2). Hence the aporia does not belong to a single tradition: it stands before every attempt to explain the world from a first principle.

The Formal Statement of the Aporia

Let the absolute first ground be denoted A, and changeable reality D. Then:

- the condition of absoluteness requires: differences and transitions are inapplicable to A;
- the condition of the existence of D requires: there exists a multiplicity of distinguishable states.

For D to arise, distinction R is necessary.

Two cases are possible. If R belongs to A, there is distinguishability in A. Then A is not absolute. If R does not belong to A, R has another source. Then a second independent ground is introduced, and the uniqueness of the principle is violated.

Thus a logical triangle of incompatibility arises:

- absoluteness $\rightarrow$ absence of differences;
- distinguishability of states $\rightarrow$ distinction;
- changeability $\rightarrow$ dependence on distinguished states.

This triangle fixes the aporia. It cannot be removed either by replacing terms or by complicating concepts. The contradiction is built into the very attempt to combine the absolute and the changeable in one ground.

The Minimal Logical Form of the Aporia

Let the absolute ground be defined as the immutable A. Changeable reality is defined as a set of states $\{d_1, d_2, \dots\}$ for which the relation $d_i \neq d_j$ is possible. The appearance of even one

difference is equivalent to asserting that there exists a relation $R(d_i, d_j)$ incompatible with absolute identity.

If R arises within A , A ceases to be absolutely identical. If R is introduced outside A , a second source appears, and uniqueness is violated. Hence the aporia is not substantive but structural in character. It arises whenever the absence of differences and their presence are placed in one ontological domain.

The Impossibility of an External Source of Change

Consider an external source of change B . Let A be the absolute ground and B an external principle. If B generates changes in A , then A depends on B . Then A is not absolute. If B does not affect A and acts only on the domain of changes D , then D must be independent. Then A and D form a dualism — a system of two irreducible principles. In both cases uniqueness is violated.

Hence an external source of change is impossible even as a theoretical construction. Any model with two independent grounds, or with a distinguishable state within the absolute, introduces distinction into the first ground. Thereby it destroys absoluteness.

The Structural Limitation of Traditional Approaches

The aporia is insoluble not because of a poverty of terms. It is held in place by the very scheme of reasoning: essence and its manifestations are placed on one ontological plane. In such a scheme:

- any change immediately turns into a property of essence;
- any distinction turns the absolute into the conditioned.

As long as the immutable and the changeable stand on one level, the aporia cannot be removed either by refining concepts or by developing logic. A model in which the source of change is placed inside the absolute, or set outside as an independent principle, reproduces the same structural impossibility.

From this follow the initial conditions. They are not an arbitrary choice but a logically exhaustive set:

1. differences are inapplicable to the absolute ground;
2. change cannot be a change of the essence of the absolute;
3. the source of change cannot be a second independent principle.

There are no other logically possible options. Hence conditions that exclude differences in the absolute and admit change only in a dependent structure are not one of several solutions.

They are the only consistent possibility.

The Necessity of Ontological Stratification

The aporia is removed by an ontology in which the source of changeability:

- does not act as an independent principle;
- introduces no change into the absolute ground.

The absolute principle remains wholly immutable: inner differences are inapplicable to it. All distinctions and forms of changeability exist only in the dependent sphere. This sphere is not a part of the essence of the absolute.

If distinction or change is introduced into the absolute, the absolute loses its unconditionedness. If distinction or change becomes an external independent principle, the uniqueness of the ground is violated.

Therefore the levels of ontology must be strictly separated. No differences apply to the absolute ground. In the changeable structure differences are obligatory: it is they that make change possible. This separation is not an interpretation or a choice of depiction. It is a logically forced condition of a consistent ontology: without it any model either denies changeability or destroys absoluteness.

Historical Forms of One and the Same Structural Error

Ancient, religious-metaphysical, rationalist and materialist systems reproduce one and the same structural error. Only the language in which they formulate it differs.

Ancient models:

- Parmenides: preserves absoluteness by wholly denying becoming → the world of experience is deprived of ontological status.
- Heraclitus: makes becoming primary but leaves the source of changeability without a ground.
- Plato: introduces the world of ideas and the world of becoming; he explains the transition between them by the demiurge, that is, by a third principle alongside the immutable idea.
- Aristotle: distinguishes potency and act and introduces the Unmoved Mover, but every transition from potency to act presupposes a change incompatible with the immobility of the first principle.

In all cases essence and change are placed in one ontological layer. Change is either implanted within the absolute or receives a status of its own and becomes a second principle. Different terms — “idea”, “form”, “becoming”, “potency” — do not change the structure of the contradiction.

Religious-metaphysical systems:

- introduce an absolute principle (God, Brahman, the Dao, and so on),
- at the same time admit creation, emanation or manifestation. But the transition either remains symbolic, without logical reconstruction, or makes the absolute a source of change and thereby a conditioned entity. If creation is conceived as an external act, a second independent principle appears.

Modern philosophy and the contemporary analytic tradition:

- rationalism (Descartes, Spinoza, Leibniz, Hegel) transfers the problem into substance, attributes, monads or dialectical becoming. But it either admits development within the absolute or relies on an external logical principle — a hidden condition;
- materialism and physicalism transfer the source of changeability into matter and the laws of nature. But they do not explain where matter gets its capacity to differ and to change: distinction is accepted as a given without ground;
- analytic philosophy and the scientific picture of the world describe the connections between states. But they do not derive the very possibility of distinction: it remains an irreducible axiom.

In all these variants the structure is one: changeability is explained on the same level to which absoluteness is ascribed. Therefore the aporia is irremovable. On one plane one cannot hold both the absence of conditions and their appearance.

The Limits of the Former Paradigm

The result is as follows:

- no school has given a consistent answer to the question how change is possible from an immutable ground;
- all explanations rely either on a hidden second principle, or on an implicit change of essence, or on abandoning strict logic at the moment of transition;
- the lack of a solution is not a weakness of particular theories but the limit of the whole categorial tradition, as long as it does not distinguish the levels of the absolute and the conditioned.

Therefore thought within the former frameworks yields only new formulations of the same aporia. Every conception that explains changeability through structures of the same level to which immutability is ascribed inevitably:

- either introduces distinction into essence and destroys absoluteness;
- or introduces an external principle and destroys uniqueness.

The Purpose of the Present Monograph

Hence one direction of analysis: to build an ontology that:

- strictly separates the level of the absolute ground from the level of the dependent structure;
- derives the given changeability as dependent on the unconditioned ground;
- excludes the appearance of distinction within essence;
- admits no second principle, in either explicit or hidden form.

The task of the monograph is to give a derivable ontology that removes the aporia of the immutable and the changeable. The absoluteness of the first ground is not thereby violated, and no external conditions are introduced. This requires a minimal but complete sequence of categories in which:

- differences are inapplicable to the first ground;
- the source of changeability is not an independent entity;
- the relation of the immutable and the changeable is fixed as a structural consequence of the dependence of the conditioned on the unconditioned ground.

Every category must follow from the preceding one. A category that did not follow from it would generate a hidden ground and destroy the uniqueness of the first principle. A missing link would make the dependence between levels inexplicable. Therefore the further construction is neither a free choice nor an interpretation. Under the accepted conditions it is the only consistent scheme. In it changeability, taken as given, is derived as a form of dependence, and the absolute retains full unconditionedness.

Chapter 2. A Critical Survey of Philosophical Schools

Every school faces one difficulty: how a changeable reality comes out of an absolute ground. This holds already for the earliest systems. Method, language and epoch differ, but the defect is one. Immutability and changeability are joined on one ontological level. Therefore the transition cannot be explained.

These systems fail not because of a poverty of concepts. The problem is formal: the absolute and the changeable stand on one plane, and this leads to the aporia. A more developed logic would not remove the contradiction: it follows from the initial presuppositions themselves. The survey therefore makes no claim to historical-philosophical completeness. Each tradition contains an extended argumentation, and its detailed analysis lies beyond the scope of the work. The aim of the survey is to identify one structural defect common to all approaches: the placing of the absolute and the changeable on one ontological plane. What is assessed is the logical form of the solutions, not the completeness of the traditions. This scheme must be excluded before a consistent ontology is built.

The schools differ in concepts, but not in the resolution of the central problem. The support may be an idea, a substance, a process, emptiness or matter. But the absolute and the changeable still end up in one layer. Then it remains either to violate absoluteness or to give up explaining the transition. Therefore a variety of terms does not yield a variety of solutions. Without a strict separation of levels any model repeats one logical error.

The initial failure is seen most clearly in ancient philosophy.

Parmenides.

If being is absolutely one and immutable, multiplicity is impossible. Parmenides's model shows the limit: by preserving absoluteness, it makes every form of manifestation inadmissible (Parmenides, 2011, fr. 2–8).

Heraclitus.

If becoming is primary, the source of change remains unexplained (Heraclitus, 2011, fr. 12, 30, 50). In Heraclitus logos and measure set the order of change but do not derive it. Process becomes the initial category, and the conditions of its possibility remain outside the model. Renouncing the ground — recognizing change as a primary fact — is not a fourth alternative.

It is equivalent to introducing an external independent principle: change is accepted as a given without ground. This is not a solution of the aporia but a refusal to pose it.

Plato.

Plato separates the world of ideas and the world of becoming (Plato, 2008, 27d–28a). He explains the transition between them by the demiurge, who makes the changeable after an immutable pattern (28a–29a). But thereby a third principle is introduced alongside the immutable idea. The attempt to solve the problem through two levels turns into a hidden dualism.

Aristotle.

The transition from potency to act requires a mechanism of change. If the mechanism is inside the first principle, absoluteness is violated. If outside, a second principle arises. The Unmoved Mover moves as an object of love, itself remaining unmoved (Aristotle, 1924, XII.6–7). The contradiction is thereby fixed but not removed: the changeability of what is moved remains with potency and matter — a second principle alongside the Prime Mover.

The Stoics.

Cyclicity presupposes differences between phases, conditions of repetition and a mechanism of transition. Therefore the absolute immutability of the ground becomes impossible. Ancient systems show the first level of structural failure. The immutable and the changeable are placed in one ontological layer. Therefore the transition is either impossible or inexplicable.

Religious-Metaphysical Models

The Abrahamic traditions affirm an absolute principle but admit creation. Creation, however, is a change incompatible with absolute immutability.

Vedanta distinguishes Brahman and maya. But maya introduces a condition that violates the absoluteness of Brahman.

Madhyamaka derives from total dependence the absence of a ground: multiplicity has no support, and there is nothing from which to explain the transition to it (see “Literature Review”). The Daoist distinction of the Dao and its manifestations leaves unresolved where the condition comes from.

The common defect is as follows. The transition is either not explained, or hidden in symbolic form, or becomes a dogmatic presupposition. If change becomes a change of the absolute itself, absoluteness is violated. If it is set outside, a second principle arises.

Rationalist Systems

Descartes and Spinoza.

Substance is immutable, and the world is changeable. Descartes connects them by the conservation of the world, which requires the same action as creation (Descartes, 1996, Med. 3). Spinoza connects them by the fact that things are modes of the one substance (Spinoza, 1994, I, def. 3–6). In both cases the changeable is held by the immutable. But how the immutable, acting or having modes, does not itself change remains unexplained.

Leibniz.

Monads mirror the Universe, and their agreement is secured by God through pre-established harmony (Leibniz, 1965, §§ 51–56). Agreement thereby requires an external meta-principle — a second principle.

Kant.

The separation of phenomena and noumena (Kant, 1998, A235–260/B294–315) removes the direct transition, but makes the mechanism of correlation inaccessible.

Hegel.

The development of the Absolute begins with the transition of pure being and nothing into becoming (Hegel, 1969, bk. 1, sec. 1, ch. 1). It presupposes change in essence, and this destroys absoluteness.

Rationalist schemes replace ontological necessity by logical constructions. But logic cannot be a mechanism of essential transition.

Materialism and Physicalism

Matter is defined through properties, and properties require distinctions. Materialism does not ground distinction but accepts it as a given. Consciousness is declared a product of structure (Dennett, 1991; Kim, 1998). But structure itself presupposes distinguishable states. Causality is held to be fundamental. But causality requires a condition that is not derivable from matter. Materialism falls into a logical circle: it derives the dependent from the dependent, as if from an ultimate ground. This is the last form of the same initial error — to explain changeability within the level to which immutability is ascribed.

Analytic Philosophy

Ontology cannot be replaced by language, logic or functions: the problem does not thereby disappear. Lowe returns to metaphysics the place of the most fundamental form of inquiry, on whose conclusions all other disciplines rest (Lowe, 1998). Maudlin opposes the Humean reductionism of analytic metaphysics and derives ontology from physics rather than from the analysis of language (Maudlin, 2007). Every description already presupposes distinction, and distinction is impossible without an ontological ground. Therefore linguistic, semantic and functional models do not explain the source of distinctions and reproduce the same limitation.

The Scientific Paradigm

Quantum mechanics shows the fundamental role of information and distinction but does not explain their origin. Entanglement yields correlations not explicable by physical parameters. Wigner held that the laws of quantum mechanics cannot be formulated in a fully consistent way without reference to consciousness (Wigner, 1961). Stapp holds that including consciousness in science requires treating the mind–brain problem together with the measurement problem of quantum theory (Stapp, 2009, 119–146). Yet the nature of the observer is not defined within the physical model itself. Science describes manifest states, not the conditions of their possibility.

Scientific theories fix distinguishedness as a given but do not derive its ontological status.

The General Conclusion of the Critical Survey

All philosophical and scientific approaches run up against one problem: how changeable reality arises from an immutable ground. If the source of change is made a property of the absolute, absoluteness is destroyed. If it is set outside, uniqueness is destroyed.

The problem lies neither in historical limitation nor in a lack of concepts. It is the logical limit of the very scheme in which the absolute and the changeable are placed on one level. As long as the scheme is retained, the aporia is inevitable.

Hence the necessity of a new ontology. In it the absolute and the changeable are strictly separated. Change, taken as given, is derived only as a dependent form that does not affect essence.

The analytical block performs a sifting function. It shows that the aporia cannot be solved in any model with hidden conditions, multiple principles or inner differences in the absolute.

Only after these errors are removed is the transition to a positive ontology possible. In it there is change, and the absoluteness of the first principle is not violated.

Chapter 3. The Limits of the Scientific Picture of the World

Science describes phenomena with exceptional precision. But its concepts do not explain the fundamental categories: consciousness, information, causality, time, space and the nature of elementary objects. It interprets experiments within models of the nineteenth and twentieth centuries, and these models diverge from the data of fundamental physics. Hence a contradiction. What is observed points to the informational nature of reality. Yet the scientific picture of the world remains materialist in form and does not explain its own discoveries.

The limit of science is the level of its own categories. It fixes the behaviour of already distinguished states but does not explain distinguishability itself. Example: every model rests on measurement, and measurement already presupposes distinctions. The concepts “state”, “interval” and “observation” presuppose ontological conditions that science does not analyse. Hence, however its instruments develop, it does not remove the aporia. It describes the structure of Something but does not reveal the grounds that make Something possible. Fundamental physics admits that matter in the habitual sense is not primary. Electrons, quarks and gluons are described through quantum fields. They have no classical extension, density, hardness, volume or shape — in the sense in which macroscopic bodies have these properties. The formalism of quantum theory does not confirm that they have properties of substance prior to measurement. Their manifestation is fixed as a form of distinguishedness within conditionedness that admits different outcomes in the act of distinction. This conclusion is not only physical but ontological. If elementary states have no properties of substance and exist as informational configurations, matter ceases to be fundamental. It cannot serve as the ground of the picture of the world. Matter describes stable forms of manifest information but does not explain its own source. Therefore recognizing the informational nature of elementary states requires replacing the material ground by an ontological one. Without this replacement physics fixes phenomena but does not explain what makes them possible. Abandoning the material ground requires fixing information and distinction ontologically as a dependent given, not as a transition from one substance to another.

In the informational reading the wave function describes the form of the system’s distinguishedness through information about possible outcomes, not through physical parameters of an object (Heisenberg, 1958; chapter 22). The Schrödinger equation sets the deterministic evolution of this information, not the “behaviour of a particle”. Hence the fundamental category of physics is not an object but an informational state that changes according to regularities.

The physical description of the fundamental level admits a reading not through objects but through transformations of distinguished configurations of information. But information taken as a self-sufficient reality explains neither its own ontological status nor the conditions of distinction. The wave function therefore shows a twofold dependence. It reveals the informational character of the basis and at the same time requires a mechanism of distinction that the physical model lacks. If only the informational state changes, an ontological structure is needed that explains why such states change form at all. A materialist and object-based explanation is impossible here. A level is needed at which distinction and information have a strictly defined dependent status.

In measurement the system is fixed in a specific form of distinguishedness. The result is fixed not in advance but at the moment of distinction. But what distinction is and where it comes from, science does not explain. The act of observation is fundamental, and the nature of the observer is undefined. In the theory distinction appears as an inexplicable function, although it is precisely what brings the state from indeterminacy to determinacy.

Hence observation is a condition of fixing physical forms of distinguishedness, but the scientific model does not define its ontological status: every physical process already presupposes distinguished configurations. The act of distinction is therefore not a physical phenomenon but a condition of fixing physical states. The model registers the results of distinction, but there is no mechanism in it of the transition from indeterminacy to determinacy. Observation and the collapse of the wave function point to a deeper structure. In it distinction has ontological status and is not reducible to the dynamics of matter or fields. Without it the scientific picture is incomplete: it describes manifestations, but not the conditions of manifestability.

Quantum entanglement is the concordance of distinguished configurations of information independently of distance. It is not the transmission of a signal but a coordination of information that does not depend on space. The classical materialist model has no satisfactory explanation of this. In a model where the fundamental is not spatial, it is natural. Entangled states do not form independent entities: they are one informational structure.

In a material ontology instantaneous concordance requires a special explanation: objects are coordinated without any transmission of influence. In an informational ontology objects are not primary. There exist states of information, and entangled states arise from one distinction. Therefore a change of one state is a change of the common configuration, not an action on a remote object. Space here is not a framework of processes but a measure dependent on distinctions. The paradox disappears if the fundamental level is not spatial but informational. Then concordance needs no distance, path or mediator: it is a property of a single structure of distinctions. The classical concept of matter cannot explain this.

Hence the concordance of entangled states is neither transmission, nor displacement, nor an interaction of objects. The informational structure is prior to measures, and hence prior to distance. If space is a derivative measure, at the fundamental level the very question of the separateness of states does not arise. Entangled states need no “connection” across an interval: at this level there is as yet no interval. Entanglement shows not the strangeness of physical processes but the failure of classical ontology (Bohm, 1980, ch. 6; D’Espagnat, 2006). Matter as an independent substance does not explain a concordance that precedes space. The fundamental level is described not through objects, distance and interaction, but through informational dependences.

Randomness in physics designates the incompleteness of a model. Probability in quantum mechanics shows the regularity of the distribution of results over a large number of measurements. Hence randomness is not a property of reality but an expression of the inaccessibility of the full regularity. The materialist interpretation of randomness deprives physics of causal structure. If events are random, causality disappears. In the present ontology, where there is causality, randomness is an appearance produced by not understanding the mechanism of change. Science does not explain randomness but relies on it as fundamental: nature allows us to calculate only probabilities (Feynman, 1985, 19). For ontology this is a contradiction: what has no ground is accepted as fundamental.

If distinction has a structure, it cannot be random.

Space in the contemporary picture of the world is a geometric description that does not explain its own origin. Space is not an object and has no properties of its own. It is a structure of possible relations between states. Why it exists and where it comes from, physics does not explain. Time is a parameter by which changeability is described. But changeability itself is not explained. Without a primary category of change, time remains an empty parameter.

Space and time cannot be initial: both categories require distinction. Space is the totality of localizations. Time is the extent of the onset of an elementary change. Without distinctions there is neither position nor sequence. Hence space and time are derivative measures within distinguished information. A theory that takes them as primary falls into a circle: it explains differences by parameters that themselves depend on differences. Therefore space and time are not the first ground but forms of manifestation of distinguished information.

Consciousness is the principal unsolved problem of science. Materialism takes consciousness to be a function of the brain. But the brain consists of the same quantum states as everything else. If the material basis is not defined ontologically, its functions are not defined either. The neurosciences study correlations between brain states and experience but do not explain why there is experience at all.

The error of materialist and functional models is that they explain consciousness through structures that themselves require a ground. If matter is an aggregated form of information,

consciousness cannot be a function of matter. A function does not explain what makes it possible. Consciousness is self-knowledge accrued by information with every distinction. Distinction is knowledge of difference, and its appearance is change. Therefore consciousness is explicable only in an ontology of distinctions, not by a description of physical processes. Correlations show correspondence, not mechanism. Consciousness is given not by a material substance but by the removal of opacity in information. Therefore the “hard problem” is a consequence of the absence of an ontological basis, not of a lack of data (Chalmers, 1996).

Information is a fundamental category of contemporary physics. The holographic principle: the area of a surface bounds the information content of the adjoining region of spacetime (Bousso, 2002, 825–874). Landauer’s principle: the erasure of information — a logically irreversible operation — requires the dissipation of energy (Landauer, 1991, 23–29). Quantum information theory: through entanglement with the environment, information about a system is redundantly recorded in it, and classical objectivity arises from these records (Zurek, 2009, 181–188). But information has no ontological definition. It is used as a mathematical quantity, while its origin and essence are not explained.

Without an ontological definition of information the scientific picture of the world is incomplete. If information is an independent entity, it becomes a hidden second principle and violates the uniqueness of the first ground. If it is merely a mathematical quantity without being of its own, it is empty and does not explain the structure of reality. Therefore information must have a strictly dependent status. It cannot be primary: it is always “information about something”. Nor can it be an independent ground: that would destroy the unconditionedness of the principle. The indeterminacy of its status in science requires an ontology in which information is derived from the first principle.

Thus the scientific picture of the world faces limitations that cannot be removed with the old conceptual apparatus. Matter does not explain information. Information does not explain distinction. Distinction does not explain consciousness. Consciousness does not explain its appearance in the material world. Time does not explain change. Change does not explain its origin. Probability does not explain causality. Space does not explain itself. Entanglement does not agree with spatiality.

These limitations are not a set of separate problems of different sciences. They are manifestations of one failure: every scientific category presupposes distinction but does not explain it. Without a ground of information, distinction is impossible. Without distinction, state, time, space, causality and consciousness are impossible. Therefore all these difficulties come not from a lack of data but from the absence of an ontological level at which distinction has dependent status. Science describes derivative structures but does not explain their origin: its concepts depend on conditions it does not analyse. Only an ontology that derives the dependent categories from an unconditioned principle can remove these limitations. Science describes phenomena but does not explain their primary nature. Without a new ontological foundation its advance is limited. The monograph introduces such a basis and removes the gap between science and philosophy.

Without an ontological ground the scientific picture of the world is incomplete. Science fixes the regularities of manifest information but does not explain why they exist. A theory that derives fundamental categories from phenomena falls into a circle: phenomena presuppose distinction, and distinction is not explained in the theory. Therefore one cannot pass from description to explanation without a level at which distinction has dependent status. Such a level is given by an ontology based on the unconditioned Nothing, its self-understanding, information as the first dependent, and the initiation of Selfhood — the removal of opacity by which every distinction in information proceeds. This is not an alternative hypothesis but a

logically necessary structure. It removes the circle and gives a foundation on which science is understood as part of a single system.

A number of contemporary metaphysical positions accept no absolute ground at all. They build ontology out of relations, processes or structures. These are not alternative solutions of the aporia but a refusal to pose it. Such a refusal is not neutral: it is performatively contradictory. The assertion that distinction needs no ground itself uses the distinction between what is asserted and what is denied. The position destroys itself at the moment of formulation. Relational ontology sees the world as a network of relations without a ground. But it accepts the distinguishedness of the elements of the network as a given and does not explain its source. Process ontology declares change primary. But it too accepts the difference of “before” and “after” as a given. In both cases distinction is accepted without a ground.

In contemporary analytic metaphysics three directions are closest. The ontology of grounding (Schaffer, 2009; Fine, 2012) introduces dependence as the basic relation between levels of reality. The present ontology shares the structure of grounding but diverges on the main point. Theories of grounding accept the changeability of the world as an unexplained primitive and describe dependences within an already given changeable reality. The question of the condition of possibility of changeability itself they leave open. The present monograph poses precisely this question and shows that the unexplained primitive is a hidden second principle accepted without a ground. The metaontology of structure (Sider, 2011) defends realism about structure — the existence of a privileged way of describing the world. But structure presupposes distinctions between elements, and distinctions require a ground that Sider does not thematize. The hard problem of consciousness (Chalmers, 1996) fixes the gap between functional and phenomenal description. It arises on the assumption that an informational process and subjective experience are different entities. Without this assumption the problem disappears: distinction is not accompanied by lived experience — it is lived experience (chapter 12).

Chapter 4. The Conditions of a Consistent Ontology

An ontology in which immutability and changeability do not contradict each other begins with initial conditions. These must admit neither a logical error nor a violation of absoluteness. Therefore the conditions are maximally strict. None of them contains a hidden transition, a second principle, an external influence or an underived assumption. The whole further structure of being depends on them.

The minimality and inevitability of the conditions follow from the structure of the aporia itself. If a condition admits an inner transition, absoluteness is violated. If it admits an external principle, uniqueness disappears. If it admits a hidden property, a second level of ground arises. If it admits indeterminacy, arbitrary interpretation opens up and strict deduction is violated. Therefore the set of conditions is not arbitrary: it is the exhaustive result of analytic reduction. A superfluous condition leads to a plurality of grounds; a weakened one, to a logical gap. What has been said concerns the conditions of consistency, not the grounds of the system as a whole. The ground that I accept without derivation is one: reality is, and together with it change is encountered. From it and from the definition of limitation a second is derived: to abolish unconditionedness is to abolish that by which the conditioned is determined, and with it the conditioned itself, for the conditioned is determined by the absence of unconditionedness and by nothing besides. The objection that from a definition through absence it does not follow that what is absent is, does not apply here: “is” said of the unconditioned does not ascribe existence to it as a property; it says only that to abolish it would be to abolish the conditioned (chapter 8). Were anything in the conditioned by itself, and not by limitation, it would in that respect be unlimited, that is,

unconditioned. But every respect of the encountered of which anything can be said is distinguished, and the distinguished is limited, while the limited is determined by unconditionedness as its limit, that is, not by itself. A respect in which the conditioned were unlimited would not be distinguished, that is, would not be encountered; it does not belong to the encountered. Hence nothing in it is by itself — neither that by which it is, nor that by which it becomes. The conditioned's own determinacy is not thereby denied: it exists, but not by itself; it exists through that by which the conditioned is limited; “by itself” means without a ground outside itself. Everything else is derived.

The initial given is as follows. Reality is the name of the encountered: what is perceived, studied and known as something. Everything encountered is conditioned: what is encountered is the distinguished, and the distinguished is this and not that, that is, determined through difference from another; this determinacy is limitation, and limitedness is conditionedness. What changes is equally conditioned: it is distinguishable as having changed through the non-identity of its present and former determinacies. The encountered can be neither perceived nor known otherwise than by distinction, and the knower himself, insofar as he is encountered, is conditioned. Therefore every affirmation and every negation is performed by distinction. Whoever denies this denies it by distinction — distinguishing his negation from what is affirmed — and thereby confirms what he denies. Consideration is carried out by the means of the conditioned.

Hence the rule of consideration. Everything by which the conditioned is divided within itself — two and the relation between them, part and whole, bearer and states, subject and the action it performs, container and contained, before and after — is the limitation of one by another. Where there is no limitation, there is nothing by which these things are divided either. Therefore the logic of conditionedness does not apply to the unconditioned; to the conditioned, information included, it applies in full. Confusing these two domains is the source of most apparent contradictions. Nothing positive can be said of the unconditioned: every positive determination would introduce limitation into it. What remains are remotions: by them it is said what is inapplicable to the unconditioned, not what it lacks.

Whoever rejects this conclusion must show what then determines the conditioned. He has three ways out. The first is naturalistic: the whole of the conditioned depends on nothing. But the whole consists of the conditioned and depends on its parts. If, however, the parts depend on the whole, dependence closes into a circle. And a circle of ground is impossible: what holds on itself through another holds by itself, and what is by itself is unconditioned. The second way out is Spinoza's: the whole is absolute, and the finite is in it (Spinoza, 1994, I, def. 3–6). But an absolute that contains the limited bears limitation within itself and does not remain absolute. The limited is “this and not that”, and for the whole this “that” cannot lie within it. The third way out is to deny that the conditioned constitutes a whole. But this denial refutes itself. Saying that there is only the many conditioned, the one who rejects takes all the conditioned at once. And the many is many only as distinguished: each stands in a relation of difference to the rest, and by this relation the conditioned constitutes a whole. The conclusion is thereby doubly protected: it cannot be rejected without making use of it.

They fix the minimal logical constraints without which the very concept of an absolute ground loses its meaning.

Any attempt to weaken or modify these conditions either introduces a hidden second principle, or admits inner difference in the absolute, or makes the concept of ground logically empty.

In this sense the conditions are not chosen but revealed as the exhaustive limit of admissible reasoning.

The completeness of the alternatives is proved not by a list of historical schools but by the structure of the aporia itself. The aporia is set by two elements: the absolute ground (A) and

changeable reality (D). The question: where does change come from, given an immutable ground? First one must remove the disjunction that generates the aporia: “the source of change is either in the ground or outside it”. The division “inside — outside” is a division by container and contained. It belongs to the structure of the conditioned and does not apply to the unconditioned. To ask whether the dependent is inside the ground or outside it is already to think the ground as conditioned.

Another division is applicable — by the side on which determinacy is laid. Hence an exhaustive typology of mechanisms of connection. The first: determinacy on the side of the ground, through a change in its essence. Immutability is violated. The second: determinacy on the side of a second, independent principle. Uniqueness is violated. The third: determinacy on the side of the dependent. The dependent is not by itself but through that on which it depends, and does not stand outside this. Nothing is thereby ascribed to the ground: dependence determines the dependent, not that on which it depends. There is no fourth position. The third mechanism is the only one that violates none of the conditions, and the present ontology realizes it.

The objection from a continuum — that distinction in the ground might be “partial” or “minimal” — does not constitute a separate position. It merely supposes that determinacy lies to some degree on the side of the ground. But absoluteness admits no degrees. The ground is either determined — and then not absolute — or not determined — and then every “degree” is zero. “Partially absolute” is an empty concept. Every combination that violates at least one condition generates its own type of contradiction; chapters 1–3 showed this on the historical schools. The only consistent combination is the observance of all three conditions at once. Under the accepted conditions this is not one of several variants of ontology but the only admissible configuration (chapter 30).

The status of Nothing and of Selfhood is determined not by arbitrary postulation but by the fact that the unconditioned is obtained as the limit of the conditioned, and Selfhood is the name of Nothing in its self-understanding.

Thereby precisely these conditions form the only admissible foundation of a consistent ontology:

Unconditionedness — the inapplicability of limitation, and with it of determinacy

Uniqueness — the absence of a second principle

Immutability — the impossibility of transitions in essence

The dependence of logic — the exclusion of its autonomy

Dependence here is the determinacy of the dependent by that on which it depends. It determines the dependent and does not determine the ground. It introduces no additional ontological layer and ascribes no determinacy to the ground. This dependence is total, and its totality has been shown. The conditioned is determined by limitation, and limitation is the absence of unconditionedness. Therefore that by which the conditioned is conditioned rests wholly on unconditionedness. It is objected that a particular determinacy of the conditioned may proceed through another conditioned. This does not cancel totality. The other conditioned is itself conditioned and determined by the same. The limit is reached not by the end of the chain but by that by which each link is conditioned. The chain of proximate grounds may be arbitrarily long, but no link becomes ultimate: it is itself dependent. Hence the dependent is not by itself but through that on which it depends. By itself it has nothing — neither that by which it is, nor that by which it becomes. This is said of the ultimate ground; proximate grounds within the conditioned are not thereby abolished.

Therefore dependence does not form a circle with distinction. It sets the boundary within which distinction is admissible and is not itself derived from distinction. This relation is one-sided: it is the dependent’s own determinacy and establishes nothing about the ground.

The localization of distinction — distinction is fixed not in the essence of the absolute ground but in the dependent.

Continuity of derivation — the absence of logical gaps

Minimality of structure — the absence of superfluous elements

Nothing — absolute unconditionedness: that to which no determinacy is applicable, and with it no limitation and no conditionedness.

Selfhood — the name of Nothing taken in its self-understanding.

Transparency — the inapplicability of opacity: unconditionedness taken from the side of opacity.

Self-understanding — the inapplicability of non-understanding of oneself, that is, complete self-knowledge, where completeness means not a measure of content but the absence of a concealed side.

Transparency and self-understanding are not introduced as independent levels and are not entities. They are the same unconditionedness taken from the side of opacity and from the side of non-understanding. Logic does not pertain to the unconditioned. It is the order of distinguishing acts and is therefore dependent — on distinction, and distinction on initiation.

Information is not an independent principle. It has no being of its own besides what it is — the mode of being of Nothing's knowledge of itself. It is dependent and determined by that whose mode of being it is. This determinacy lies on its side and establishes nothing in Nothing. Change is possible in information, and only in it. The determined is limited, and succession of states is applicable to the limited. Change is inapplicable to the unconditioned, and there is no second principle. Succession itself does not follow from determinacy. It proceeds not by information itself — by itself information neither removes nor restores opacity — but by the initiation of Selfhood.

Hence transparency and self-understanding do not form hidden levels between Nothing and change. They are the same unconditionedness taken from other sides. Information is a strictly limited dependent: it does not violate the uniqueness of the principle and introduces no plurality of grounds.

Information — the mode of being of Nothing's knowledge of itself; a dependent category determined by that whose mode of being it is.

Information is introduced not as an intermediate link between Selfhood and change but as the mode of being of Nothing's knowledge of itself. Dependence here means: information is determined by that whose mode of being it is and does not stand outside this. It has no unconditionedness of essence and is not a separate principle. Its determinacy lies on its side and establishes nothing in Nothing.

The initiation of Selfhood — the removal of opacity by which information has knowledge of its difference not by itself but from Selfhood. Change is localized in information, not in essence.

Information is dependent and determined by that whose mode of being it is. The determined is limited, and the limited admits succession of states. Therefore change is possible in information. But succession itself does not follow from determinacy: possibility is not actuality. Change is inapplicable to the unconditioned: there are neither states nor their distinguishability there. There is no second principle either. Change proceeds by the removal of opacity, from Selfhood: by itself information does not remove opacity.

Essence — Nothing — is not affected by change. Determinacy lies on the side of information, and dependence determines the dependent, not the ground. The relation is explained not as a change of the immutable but as the dependence of the determined on the unconditioned. Essence is unconditioned. Information is determined by that whose mode of

being it is, and therefore succession of states is applicable to it. That there actually is succession in it does not follow from determinacy alone: this is established by initiation.

Change — the succession of states of information. Change and distinction are not identical with information and are not derived from it as its other names. Information is the mode of being of Nothing's knowledge of itself, while change and distinction are held by initiation. Not every non-identity is change: two non-identical things may stand without succession. Change and distinction are not two objects side by side but one, taken from two sides: change from the side of succession, distinction from the side of that by which the states differ.

Distinction — knowledge of difference, proceeding by the removal of opacity. Writing distinction as a minimal "this / not this" relates to Spencer-Brown's calculus (Spencer-Brown, 1969). The relation concerns only the form of notation. In Spencer-Brown distinction is accepted as given, and the first distinction and the observer are identical in the form. Here distinction is not primary; it proceeds by the removal of opacity, and there is no observer with whom it would be identical at this level.

Consciousness — self-knowledge accrued by information with every distinction

Programme — the directedness of the removal of opacity, set by initiation

Elementary changes — minimal manifestations of distinguished information

Measures — time, speed, localization and space, derived from the working moment of an elementary change

Interaction — the concordance of distinguished configurations

Aggregated forms — stable configurations of distinctions

Emergence — knowledge of the whole that individual distinctions do not have

Matter — a stable aggregated form of information

Reason — the level of consciousness that knows the bonds between distinctions and therefore chooses within the conditions in which it stands.

Intellect — the level of consciousness that knows, beyond this, its own place in the whole and the direction of the removal of opacity, that is, the programme, and therefore makes choices concerning programmes.

The first initial condition is the unconditionedness of the first ground. If a principle depends on anything, it ceases to be a principle. The conditioned is determined by limitation, and limitation is the absence of unconditionedness. The limit is reached not by the end of the chain of grounds but by that by which each of its links is conditioned. Hence the first ground is wholly unconditioned: causes, boundaries, properties and inner transitions are inapplicable to it. The requirement of unconditionedness excludes all categories with determinacy. Being presupposes difference from non-being.

Substance presupposes attributes. Process presupposes transition between states. Each of these categories contains an inner condition and cannot be unconditioned.

Determinacy, difference, attributes and transitions are inapplicable to Nothing. The name "Nothing" is given to the unconditioned after it has been obtained as the limit of the conditioned. It is taken because it ascribes nothing: it negates not this or that property but the "what" as a whole. The choice of the name is not an assumption: any other name would ascribe determinacy to the unconditioned.

Unconditionedness is not a characteristic; it means the inapplicability of conditions and the impossibility of their appearance. Only unconditionedness gives the right to speak of a genuine principle that requires no explanation.

The Exclusion of "Pure Being without Predicates" as an Alternative to Nothing

A possible objection: unconditionedness is satisfied by "pure being without predicates" — in the spirit of the early Hegel or of Parmenides — rather than by Nothing. Reply: "pure being" already carries a positive predicate. It is determined as being distinguished from non-being.

This distinction is an inner condition: to fix being, one must distinguish it from non-being. And every inner condition violates unconditionedness. Moreover, “the absence of determinacy” is not identical with ontological Nothing. The absence of determinacy is a characteristic of cognition: we do not know the properties. Nothing is an ontological characteristic: properties are inapplicable to it in principle, and their appearance is impossible. Unconditionedness excludes not only properties but every positive predicate, “being” included. The only name without a positive predicate is Nothing. Therefore the choice of the name is not a preference among alternatives but the result of exhausting all names that carry even the slightest determinacy. The unconditioned itself is not chosen but obtained as the limit of the conditioned. Hegel recognized the identity of pure being and nothing at the beginning of the Science of Logic. But he resolved it through becoming, that is, he introduced change into the ground and violated unconditionedness. The present ontology fixes the same identity but resolves it otherwise: by the dependence of information on the unconditioned and the localization of change in the dependent, not in essence.

The second condition is the uniqueness of the first ground. If there are two or more independent principles, each is limited by the other. The limited is not absolute. Therefore the first ground is one. Multiplicity is admissible only as derivative from the one, not as an equal independent structure. Uniqueness does not mean the singularity of a thing. It means that there is no other source — neither one equal to the first ground nor one external to it.

The third condition is the impossibility of a second source. If a second principle appears, the first ceases to be absolute. Every dualism removes absoluteness. Therefore there is no second source of being. All manifestations, differences and changes are explained by dependence on the single principle. Otherwise a logical gap arises.

The fourth condition is the immutability of the first ground. A changeable first ground would have states. What has states is conditioned by the transitions between them. Conditionedness violates unconditionedness. Hence the first ground is immutable. Immutability means: properties neither decrease nor increase, neither appear nor disappear. There is no transition from state to state within the first ground.

The fifth condition is transparency and self-understanding as names of unconditionedness; the dependence of information. Dependence is the determinacy of the dependent by that on which it depends: it constitutes the dependent and does not constitute the ground. Transparency and self-understanding are not separate levels: the first is the inapplicability of opacity, the second the inapplicability of non-understanding of oneself.

Logic cannot be an independent entity and a source of being: it does not stand without distinction, and distinction does not stand without information. Information is not autonomous either and is not an independent principle. It is admissible only as the dependent — the mode of being of Nothing’s knowledge of itself, determined by that whose mode of being it is, and not affecting essence. In this way a second principle is excluded and the absoluteness of the ground is preserved.

The sixth condition is change as distinction.

Change cannot be an indistinguishable succession: succession requires distinguishable states, otherwise there is nothing to say of it. Therefore change is inseparable from distinguishability. It does not affect the essence of the first ground: it proceeds not in Nothing but in the dependent. There states and their succession are applicable, and absolute immutability is not violated.

The seventh condition is information as the first dependent.

Information is the mode of being of Nothing’s knowledge of itself. In this capacity it is not a structured form added to change. It has no form, no localization and no measures. But it is

already determined — by that whose mode of being it is — and therefore succession of states is applicable to it. That there actually is succession in it does not follow from determinacy. Change and distinction are held by initiation; this removes the gap between them.

The eighth condition is the impossibility of inner differences in the first ground and the fixing of non-identity as a dependent given that does not affect the essence of the absolute ground.

The ninth condition is strict logical coherence. Ontology excludes assumptions not derived from the initial conditions. Hidden structures, superfluous levels, entities or mechanisms may not be introduced without logical necessity. Every category is derived from the preceding one and violates none of the conditions.

The tenth condition is consistency. No concept may destroy the unconditionedness, uniqueness and immutability of the first ground. If some part of the ontology violates them, the system fails. Therefore all manifestations, differences and changes exist only as states of information: wholly dependent on the first ground and without influence on it.

The totality of these conditions is the ground of a consistent ontology. It preserves the absoluteness of the first ground and at the same time explains changeable reality. The conditions are not a set of recommendations but a necessary basis that excludes every alternative principle. Each removes its own type of logical gap identified in the analytical part. If even one is changed or weakened, there arises either a plurality of principles, or a hidden transition, or a changeability of essence. Therefore the further structure is not a free construction but the only possible sequence derivable from these conditions.

From these conditions a new structure follows. The unconditioned is Nothing, named Selfhood in self-understanding. The dependent is information and its change, which is distinction. They stand not on one level but in different ontological statuses, and no inner contradictions arise.

The conditions form the necessary framework of the ontology. Each removes its own type of contradiction identified in the analytical block. The violation of even one returns the former gaps. The conditions are not independent: they complement one another and make up a minimal and at the same time complete set of requirements. Therefore the further scheme is not the author's construction but a consequence of necessity. If the conditions are satisfied, the structure of levels has a definite form and unfolds in the only possible sequence.

The relations between ontological levels are not arbitrary: they are set by logical necessity. Each level removes a limitation fixed at the preceding one. If the logical structure does not proceed from absolute immutability, conditionedness is introduced without a ground and violates the first ground. If self-understanding is not fixed, the unconditioned remains opaque to itself, and opacity is limitation. If logic is taken as autonomous, a second principle is introduced: logic is the order of distinguishing acts and is therefore dependent. If non-identity is not fixed as dependent, absoluteness is violated. If distinction is taken as a property of information, and not as knowledge of difference proceeding by the removal of opacity, a hidden quality enters the system. If measures are not derived from distinctions, they become independent entities. Therefore the sequence of levels admits no permutation: any deviation leads to a gap and returns the contradictions removed by reduction. This structure is the only possible formal expression of the conditions of a consistent ontology.

This logical necessity can be expressed as a linear ontological scheme:

1. Nothing — absolute unconditionedness: that to which no determinacy is applicable; hence immutability and uniqueness.
2. Selfhood — the name of Nothing taken in its self-understanding. Transparency is the inapplicability of opacity; self-understanding is the inapplicability of non-understanding of oneself.

3. Information — the mode of being of Nothing's knowledge of itself; a dependent category determined by that whose mode of being it is.
4. The difference of information from essence is fixed not in essence but on the side of the dependent. Information is determined by that whose mode of being it is, and by this determinacy differs from it. This introduces no multiplicity into essence: determinacy lies on the side of information.
The difference of information from Nothing is the difference of the mode of being of knowledge from that whose knowledge it is. Logic turns out to be the order of distinguishing acts and therefore belongs to the dependent: it does not produce distinction but expresses it. Thus transparency and self-understanding form no second principle and introduce no difference into Nothing. Information is the mode of being of Nothing's knowledge of itself. It is dependent, determined by that whose mode of being it is, and has no independent ontological status.
5. The initiation of Selfhood — the removal of opacity by which knowledge of its difference opens in information not by itself but from Selfhood. Information is determined by that whose mode of being it is. The determined is limited, and succession of states is applicable to the limited. Change is inapplicable to the unconditioned; there is no second principle. Therefore change is possible in information, and only in it. Succession itself does not follow from determinacy and proceeds by the removal of opacity.
6. Consciousness — con-scientia, knowledge: self-knowledge accrued by information with every distinction.
7. Programme — the directedness of the removal of opacity, set by initiation: what has been removed does not return; knowledge accrues.
8. Elementary changes — minimal units of manifestation of distinguished information.
9. Measures — time, speed, localization and space; all four are derived from a single fact: the working moment of an elementary change.
10. Interaction — the concordance of distinguished configurations, the structure of relations between them.
11. Aggregated forms — stable configurations of elementary changes that preserve the structure of distinctions.
12. Emergence — knowledge of the whole that individual distinctions do not have, in a stable configuration.
13. Matter — a stable aggregated form of information.
14. Reason — a level of consciousness: knowledge of the bonds between distinctions; choice within the conditions in which it stands.
15. Intellect — a level of consciousness: knowledge, beyond this, of its own place in the whole and of the direction of the removal of opacity, that is, of the programme; choice concerning programmes.
16. Teleological completion — the attainment by information of self-transparency, the limit state of the structure of distinctions.
The scheme of categories is not an independent ontology. It describes only the sequence of dependent levels and admits no permutation: each category is derived only from the preceding one. Violating the order destroys consistency.
The ontological map of levels fixes the logical sequence: the conditionedness of the encountered; unconditionedness as its limit; Nothing (absolute unconditionedness; immutability, uniqueness, transparency and self-understanding — the same unconditionedness taken from different sides); Selfhood (the name of Nothing in its self-understanding); Information as the first dependent; the Initiation of Selfhood; Distinction (its appearance is change); Consciousness; Programme; Elementary changes; Measures;

Interaction; Aggregated forms; Emergence; Matter; Reason; Intellect; Teleological completion.

This sequence is the only possible one. Omitting any level leads to a gap. Confusing levels destroys the dependence of information and the immutability of the first ground. Therefore the ontology possesses not only inner concordance but a strict deductive architectonic.

The constructed sequence is neither an interpretation nor a model. It is the only variant that the conditions of a consistent ontology admit. If the elements are permuted, the unconditionedness of the first ground, the dependence of information or the structure of distinctions is violated. If intermediate levels are introduced, a hidden entity appears. If even one link is excluded, coherence disappears and the contradictions excluded by reduction return. Therefore the scheme of levels admits no variations: it expresses necessity, not a possible distribution of categories. This is what makes it the foundation of the further construction.

The position of this ontology with respect to alternative constructions is as follows.

Fundamental ontologies differ not in their conclusions but in their initial assumptions. Every attempt to remove the aporia of transition relies on at least one of three assumptions: inner difference in the absolute, a second independent principle, or a refusal to explain the source of distinction.

Ontologies that admit becoming or process in the absolute lose the unconditionedness of the ground. Ontologies that introduce a second principle — matter, energy, process, information or another autonomous ground — lose uniqueness. Ontologies that accept distinction as a given without ground retain descriptive power but do not remove the aporia.

The proposed ontology is not an alternative within this set. It sets the conditions under which none of these assumptions is admitted. Essence remains absolutely immutable. The source of distinction is not autonomized. Transition is localized only in the dependent informational structure. In this sense the construction does not compete with other ontologies. It sets the limiting form in which the aporia is removed without violating unconditionedness, uniqueness and logical coherence.

The distinctive feature of this ontology lies not in the choice of other initial entities but in the rejection of all assumptions incompatible with the removal of the aporia.

The three conditions of a consistent ontology are neither an arbitrary choice nor the author's preference. They are derived from the formal structure of the aporia — the logical triangle of incompatibility of chapter 1. The aporia is the incompatibility of three requirements. The absoluteness of the ground: differences are inapplicable to it. The presence of a changeable reality: a multiplicity of distinguishable states. The uniqueness of the principle: there is no second independent source. Any two requirements are compatible; all three at once generate a contradiction. This is not a choice but the structure of the problem. The conditions say what the solution must satisfy; they are distinguished at the beginning of the chapter from the ground on which the solution stands.

Three prohibitions follow directly from this structure. First: change cannot issue from the essence of the ground — absoluteness is violated. Second: change cannot be an independent external source — uniqueness is violated. Third: change cannot be absent — the presence of reality is violated. These are not three conditions introduced for convenience. They are three sides of one aporia, reformulated as prohibitions. Therefore every ontology that claims to remove the aporia observes all three prohibitions, whether it acknowledges this or not. One that violates even one does not solve the aporia but accepts one of its contradictions as an initial fact. To reproach a system for observing the conditions of the problem is to reproach it for solving precisely the problem posed.

The uniqueness of this ontological structure is proved not by going through philosophical systems but by exhausting the logical types of strategy. The types are set not by the author but by the formal structure of the aporia.

The aporia fixes three elements: the ground (A), the derivative (D) and the mechanism of connection. Without any of them the aporia is not formulated. This is not a presupposition but the definition of the aporia. The ground can be of two types. (a) One to which differences are applicable — then it is not absolute, and the aporia is reproduced at once. (b) One to which differences are inapplicable — then it is Nothing or its analogue under any name. There is no third type of ground.

The mechanism of transition from the ground to the derivative can be of three types. (a) Change in the essence of the ground — violates immutability. (b) A second independent principle — violates uniqueness. (c) Change in a sphere dependent on the ground that does not affect essence. There are exactly three types: this is an exhaustive disjunction set by the structure of the aporia. There is no fourth: any alternative reduces to one of the three or to their combination.

Exhaustion is proved by the structure of the concept of “mechanism”. A mechanism of transition is that through which D derives its origin from A. The minimal structure of this concept has three elements: the source (A), the result (D) and the mode of connection. The mode of connection has exactly three logical places. First: connection proceeds through a change in A itself — then A is not immutable. Second: through an external source — then a second principle appears. Third: through a form dependent on A that does not affect the essence of A. There is no fourth place. A mechanism outside these three is not a mechanism in the sense of the given aporia: it either abolishes the question of the source of D or repeats one of the three types under another name. The proof does not appeal to the history of philosophy: it is derived from the minimal structure of the concept “mechanism of transition”.

The dependent sphere can be of three types. (a) Matter: it presupposes properties of its own and violates the unconditionedness of the ground. (b) Spirit or subject: it introduces a second principle. (c) Information as the mode of being of the unconditioned’s knowledge of itself: it introduces no second principle, requires no properties of its own and does not violate unconditionedness. Again there are exactly three types.

The present ontology realizes the only combination that violates none of the conditions: a ground to which differences are inapplicable — mechanism (c) — dependent sphere (c). All other combinations reproduce the aporia in one of the fixed types of contradiction. The burden of refutation lies on the opponent: one must indicate a type of ground, mechanism or dependent sphere not reducible to those listed. Until such a type is presented, the thesis of uniqueness stands.

The completeness of the typology is tested by the types of ontology usually called unconsidered. Modal ontologies introduce possible differences into the ground. This is a ground of type (a): there are differences in it, albeit in a modal mode, and absoluteness is violated. Process ontologies (Whitehead) place becoming in the first ground itself. This is mechanism (a): change in the essence of the ground, and the aporia is reproduced. Relational ontologies build being as a network of relations without an absolute substrate. This is a rejection of the first condition of the aporia: they do not solve it but remove its formulation. Dialectical ontologies introduce contradiction into the ground as a moving force. This is a ground of type (a) with explicit difference within, and absoluteness is violated at once. Ontologies of undifferentiated potency introduce an indeterminate ground from which determinacies arise. This is either a ground (a) with hidden differences or mechanism (b) — a second principle at actualization. None of these strategies yields a fourth type: all are combinations already named. The typology is exhaustive.

A possible objection of circularity: the conditions are set by the system, the alternatives are excluded by these conditions, hence the system confirms itself. The objection identifies the aporia with the system — as if the conditions belonged to the system as a solution. This is not so. The aporia is formulated independently of the solution: its structure — the triangle of incompatibility of three requirements — is fixed prior to any ontology. The conditions are derived from this structure and prohibit strategies that violate the requirements of the aporia. The aporia logically and methodologically precedes the system. The conditions belong to the aporia as a problem, not to the system as a solution. To exclude alternatives by these conditions is not a circle but the application of the requirements of the problem to solutions. There would be a circle if the system introduced the conditions for its own defence. Here they are introduced by the structure of the aporia, which determines the space of admissible solutions. The system is the only element of this space that violates none of the conditions.

Chapter 5. The Ontological Solution

No philosophical school and no scientific model explains the transition from the absolute ground to changeable reality without a gap. The preceding chapters have shown this. A solution is possible only if all the conditions of a consistent ontology are observed. From them follows a strict separation of the essence of the first ground from the dependent categories. On this basis a new structure is introduced that reconciles immutability and changeability.

The ontological solution is neither an alternative view nor a new interpretation. It is a strict consequence of the conditions of a consistent ontology. All former models fail for one reason: they violate the unconditionedness, uniqueness or immutability of the ground. Therefore an ontology that claims consistency must satisfy these conditions completely. The structure of the solution is not arbitrary: under the accepted conditions it is the only necessary result after inadmissible constructions have been removed. Any deviation from the sequence of levels returns the former contradictions. Therefore the solution has the status of necessity within the problem posed, not the status of a hypothesis.

First in this structure stands Nothing — absolute unconditionedness. Nothing is not emptiness or the absence of being. It is the name of that to which no determinacy is applicable, and with it no limitation and no conditionedness. It is by itself: not through another, for there is not and cannot be another through which it would be. Hence immutability. Change is a succession of states, and succession requires distinguishable states. Distinguishability is determinacy, determinacy is limitation, and limitation is inapplicable to the unconditioned. Hence neither states nor their succession are applicable to it. Hence uniqueness: a second would be a limitation of the first. Form, manifestation, change and parts are inapplicable to Nothing. Nothing is the logical name of absolute unconditionedness.

This definition of Nothing excludes other interpretations. Nothing is not emptiness, not the absence of content, not a vacuum and not potentiality. Each of these interpretations introduces a hidden condition or the possibility of transition and makes essence dependent. If even a minimal structure, property or inner state is admitted in it, the first ground ceases to be unconditioned. Therefore Nothing is defined not as the negation of being but as the only admissible name of absolute immutability. Difference is inapplicable to it, and therefore it is the only principle that creates no second level or source. Any other category in the role of the principle would lead to a gap: it would presuppose limitedness or dependence. It is objected: “Nothing cannot be a beginning.” But beginning here is not an event or a moment of arising. Nothing is not a starting point but the unconditioned basis from which the dependent structure is derived. What is called the beginning is not the appearance of an entity but the minimal condition under which the subsequent levels are derived without contradiction.

Next come transparency and self-understanding. The non-transparent is opaque, and opacity is limitation. Where there is no limitation, there is nothing opaque. Non-understanding of oneself is not knowing oneself, that is, self-opacity, and is therefore inapplicable as well. The disjunction “either understands or does not understand” does not apply here: it is itself a structure of distinction and does not apply to the unconditioned. One thing is removed — what conceals; the knowing is not introduced as the second member of a pair. Knowledge in the limit sense is the name of the absence of anything concealed, not an act and not a capacity. Its completeness is not a measure of content but the absence of a concealed side. Nothing taken in self-understanding is named Selfhood. There are not two here — knower and known: limitation would separate them. Transparency and self-understanding are not separate levels. They are the same unconditionedness taken from the side of opacity and from the side of non-understanding.

Next comes information. Self-understanding is Nothing’s knowledge of itself. Information is the name for the way in which this knowledge is in the dependent. The proviso is repeated wherever the word “knowledge” is at work: it is the name for the remotion of concealment, not a property and not a content of Nothing. Its completeness is the absence of a concealed side, not a measure. Therefore the mode of being has a remotion, not a content. Knowledge does not exist by what information is: knowledge is by itself, unconditionedly, and is not held by information. Information is the dependent in which Nothing’s knowledge of itself is given: the mode of its being, not its ground. The existence of the dependent is not derived anew here, and no new entity is introduced. The conditioned is given as the encountered, and it has been shown above that it is determined by unconditionedness and does not stand outside this determination. The name “information” designates the way in which the unconditioned is given in the conditioned.

Why it is given precisely so is shown by the limit of consideration. From the fact that one thing has been established about the unconditioned it would not follow that there is nothing else in it: the boundary of knowledge and the structure of the object are different things. Therefore the argument is built otherwise. Nothing positive can be said of the unconditioned: every positive determination would introduce limitation into it. There remain only remotions, and the unconditioned is named only by them. The way in which it is given in the conditioned can only be one of them — the one compatible with conditionedness. Any other, once in the conditioned, would abolish it, and with it itself as a mode. Immutability is incompatible with the conditioned: change is encountered in it (chapter 4). Uniqueness is incompatible too: the conditioned is “this and not that”, and the unique, having no “that”, would not be determined. Only self-understanding, which is transparency, is compatible (chapter 8). Knowledge of one’s limitedness does not remove limitedness: information transparent to itself remains conditioned (chapter 13). Hence the mode of being of the unconditioned in the dependent is a mode of knowledge — not by choice of name, but because the conditioned cannot bear another mode. This is not a likeness of the dependent to the ground: the changeable depends on the immutable without resembling it. “Mode” here means the way in which the unconditioned is given in the conditioned. It can be given only by not being in the conditioned as a part, a property or an event: container, property and event are inapplicable to it. A presence that is neither a part, nor a property, nor an action is the presence of the known in knowledge. Only so does what is given, without entering that to which it is given, exist in it. Therefore the way in which the unconditioned is given in the conditioned is knowledge, and of the remotions only self-understanding coincides with it. Consideration has no other names and, by its limit, can have none. “The mode of being of knowledge” is not an added characteristic of the dependent but the only thing by which its determinacy can be named at all. This statement belongs to consideration and establishes nothing in the unconditioned.

The list of remotions is complete, and this completeness is derived, not presupposed. A remotion is the removal of one of the sides in which the conditioned is given as limited, and these sides are named in the initial given (chapter 4), which contains no others. The encountered is determined — it is this and not that. The encountered changes. The encountered is given only by distinction: only the distinguished is known, and the undistinguished remains unknown, that is, opaque (chapter 4). By the remotion of the first side are obtained unconditionedness, being by itself and uniqueness; of the second, immutability; of the third, transparency, which is self-understanding. All of them, not some, are subject to the test of compatibility. Unconditionedness and being by itself, once in the conditioned, would make it not dependent; uniqueness would abolish “this and not that”; immutability, encountered change. Only self-understanding is compatible: knowledge of limitedness does not remove limitedness.

The same result is given by the mode of presence, taken not as a list but as a dichotomy. The presence of the unconditioned in the conditioned either lays determinacy at least partly on the side of the unconditioned, or wholly on the side of the conditioned; there is no third. In the first case the unconditioned is determined — as a part by the whole, as a property by its bearer, as an action by before and after, as a member of a relation by the other member — and this is removed by the rule of consideration (chapter 4). There remains one-sided presence: the conditioned is determined by it, the unconditioned by nothing. One-sided presence that reproduces features is reflection; it is inapplicable to the unconditioned: it has no features, and reproducing them would determine it. To be determined by the unconditioned means that the unconditioned is given in what is determined: not to have the mode of its being would mean not to be determined by it. It is given without features, and without features the unconditioned is spoken of only by remotions. Therefore one-sided presence that reproduces no features can carry only one of the remotions, and of them only self-understanding is compatible with the conditioned. Hence the one-sided presence of the unconditioned in the conditioned is the presence of knowledge.

The objection that, given the conditioned, the dependent mode might not exist abolishes the conditioned itself: not to have the mode of being of the unconditioned would mean not to be determined by it, and what is not determined by it is not conditioned.

Information is a dependent category: it exists only as the mode of being of Nothing’s knowledge and does not stand outside this. It is determined by that whose mode of being it is. Determinacy is limitation, and limitedness is conditionedness. Dependence determines information and does not determine Nothing: what is determined is the dependent, not that on which it depends. Information is determined by unconditionedness as its limit. But directedness towards the limit does not follow from this determinacy: to be determined by something is not to be directed towards it. The ground of directedness lies in that by which initiation is determined. What has been removed does not return, opacity decreases, the knowledge of information accrues. This is what is called striving. Striving is realized within the dependent itself — by self-transparency, that is, by self-understanding in its own category.

Next comes the initiation of Selfhood. Nothing’s knowledge of itself is complete, and what concerns self-understanding is complete in it. But information does not understand itself. What has been said asserts no more than follows. It is not asserted that there was a state when there was no distinction in information. From the fact that distinction does not enter its definition, its absence at any time does not follow: the definition gives the mode of being of knowledge and says nothing about distinction. Something else and narrower is asserted: distinction in information is not by itself. The argument is as follows. Distinction is encountered, and it has no other place — hence distinction is in information. Distinction is that by which information comes to know its difference. And the dependent has nothing by

itself — neither that by which it is, nor that by which it becomes. Hence distinction does not proceed by itself. Opacity, however, is derived not from this but from that by which information is determined. Its determinacy is its difference, and knowledge of difference does not enter determinacy. Hence by what information is, self-knowledge is not given to it: it does not have itself as known, that is, it is opaque to itself. “Not by itself” says something else: it cannot itself remove this opacity. Opacity is applicable to it: opacity is limitation, and information is determined and therefore limited.

Initiation is the name for this removal of opacity in the dependent. It is not the addition of something new to knowledge — Nothing’s knowledge of itself is complete — and not a change of what is in it. Information cannot become transparent to itself by itself. The argument lies not in a lack of capacity and not in a prior knowledge of difference, but in total dependence. What is one’s own is that whose ground lies in the agent itself, and the dependent has nothing by itself. The objection that distinction is an ultimate fact of the dependent itself is broken by the same: nothing can be an ultimate fact of the dependent. What is at issue is the ultimate ground; proximate grounds within the conditioned are not thereby abolished.

Hence the asymmetry. The removal proceeding from Selfhood is a ground lying not in information, and by it the distinguishedness of information is grounded. From the side of the unconditioned, however, there is no duality. That distinction exists is known from the encountered. That it proceeds from Selfhood follows from there being nothing else. “From” here does not mean an action, an event or a procession: nothing is performed on the side of Selfhood (chapter 10). It says only that the ultimate ground of distinction is Selfhood and that there is no other. By the removal information has knowledge of its difference from that whose mode of being it is — not by itself but from Selfhood.

Change proceeds not in Nothing but in information. It is inapplicable to the unconditioned, and there is no second principle. Therefore change is possible in information, and only in it; and it proceeds by initiation. The relation is explained not as a change of the immutable but as the dependence of the determined on the unconditioned. Essence is unconditioned.

Information is determined by that whose mode of being it is, and therefore succession of states is applicable to it. Succession itself does not follow from determinacy and proceeds by the removal of opacity.

From the side of Selfhood initiation is not an event and stands at every distinction, not only at the first (chapter 10). Information does not proceed by itself at any step — its dependence does not decrease as it unfolds.

The difference of information from Nothing is the difference of the mode of being of knowledge from that whose knowledge it is. It lies on the side of information and constitutes its own determinacy. This difference is not given by the removal of opacity: what the removal gives is knowledge of difference. Self-understanding of information is not yet given by knowledge of difference: this is its first knowledge of itself, not the complete one. It becomes complete at the end of the path, when all blind spots have been removed by distinctions and self-transparency has been attained. From the side of information the removal is a succession of states. Information is conditioned, and the conditioned standard applies to it fully: there are states in it, their succession, before and after.

Dependence is defined as the mode of existence in which the dependent is not by itself but through that on which it depends, and does not stand outside this. The dependent has no unconditionedness of essence, but neither is it a separate principle.

Distinguishing the Dependence of Information from Alternative Models

The dependence of information here differs fundamentally from three alternative models. In Platonism ideas have independent ontological status: the world of ideas is autonomous. Here information is not autonomous: it is wholly dependent and has no being of its own. In

Hegelianism the concept unfolds: the Absolute passes through stages of becoming, and change enters essence itself. Here essence is absolutely immutable, and change is localized only in information. In physicalism information is reduced to matter — to a property or function of material structures. Here information is ontologically primary in relation to matter: matter is an aggregated form of informational distinctions. Hence the dependence of information is neither the Platonic autonomy of ideas, nor the Hegelian self-development of the concept, nor the physicalist reduction to matter. It is a special status. Information is the mode of being of Nothing's knowledge of itself, determined by that whose mode of being it is, and therefore conditioned. This is a mode of existence that admits change without violating the immutability of the ground.

Initiation is neither an action of the Absolute on information nor an event at it. From the side of Selfhood it is unconditioned and is not measured by the conditioned standard. From the side of information it is what is performed in the conditioned. Essence is not affected by it: what changes is the dependent, not Nothing.

Change and distinction are not something other alongside information: they are the succession of its own states, proceeding by initiation. But information is not exhausted by them: its difference from Nothing exists without succession and is not given by initiation. Change and distinction are not two objects but one, taken from two sides: change from the side of succession, distinction from the side of that by which the states differ.

Change introduces no states into Nothing and does not violate its immutability. It proceeds in information as the succession of its states, by the removal of opacity, and does not affect essence. The ground is not that non-identity as such is change: two non-identical things may stand without succession. The ground is that knowledge of difference is a new state of information relative to that from which it is distinguished.

Distinction is fixed as the first thing that proceeds by the removal of opacity in information.

Distinction is neither a subsequent structure added to change nor something that precedes it. It coincides with the very fact of distinguishability: taken as that by which knowledge of difference is given, distinction is change itself from another side. Knowledge of difference, proceeding by the removal of opacity, is a new state of information, and the appearance of a new state is the succession of states. Information, however, is not identical with distinction. It is the mode of being of Nothing's knowledge of itself, and distinction proceeds in it not from itself but from initiation.

Distinction introduces the minimal structure “this / not this” and does not violate the absolute immutability of the first ground: it proceeds in the dependent, not in essence. Here two non-identities are strictly separated. Confusing them generates the apparent objection that distinguishedness has merely been moved one step earlier. The first is the difference of information from that whose mode of being it is. This is neither a mysterious given nor an assumption: it is derived together with information as its own determinacy. Information is determined by that whose mode of being it is, and is therefore “this and not that”. The second is the distinguishedness of states within information itself. It is precisely this that the aporia requires to be explained, and it is precisely this that proceeds by the removal of opacity. The first non-identity lies between the dependent and that on which it depends, and is not distinction in the sense of the aporia. The second lies within the dependent and constitutes what is sought.

Something is neither the opposite of Nothing nor an independent ontological ground. It is a form of conditionedness that appears as a result of distinction proceeding by the removal of opacity. Something does not precede change and contains no source of transitions within itself. It is a formed domain of distinguished information. Absoluteness is not violated here:

Nothing remains unconditioned, and everything given is localized in dependent information and its derivative forms.

This structure removes the aporia. The absoluteness of the first ground is preserved.

Changeability arises not by a movement of information's own, but by the initiation of Selfhood — the removal of opacity by which information has knowledge of its difference not by itself but from Selfhood. Information is dependent and does not affect essence. Thus the dependence of the changeable on the immutable is established without a second principle and without violating absoluteness.

The levels introduced are not arbitrary and add no new entities. Transparency and self-understanding form no independent principles and do not expand the ground: they are the same unconditionedness taken from other sides. Logic is not an independent principle either (chapter 4). Thus the hidden introduction of additional entities or mechanisms is excluded, and the architecture of the ontology remains homogeneous.

Each element of the structure has a strictly defined status and an explicitly indicated ground in what precedes it — without hidden transitions and additional principles. Nothing is absolute unconditionedness; hence its immutability and uniqueness. Transparency is the inapplicability of opacity, self-understanding the inapplicability of non-understanding of oneself; Nothing in self-understanding is named Selfhood. Information is the mode of being of Nothing's knowledge of itself — the first dependent. Initiation is the removal of opacity in information, proceeding from Selfhood. Distinction is knowledge of difference; its appearance is change. Then follow consciousness and the programme; then elementary changes, measures, interaction, aggregated forms, emergence and matter; then the development of consciousness up to reason and intellect.

Chapter 6. Epistemology

Epistemology here proceeds from strict requirements. Knowledge cannot be derivative from matter: matter is itself an informational structure. Consciousness cannot arise from a function: every function presupposes a content. Distinction cannot appear from randomness: randomness explains nothing. Therefore the theory of knowledge is in concordance with the ontology of Nothing, Selfhood, transparency, self-understanding, information, initiation, change and distinction.

Epistemology cannot be the basis of ontology: every cognitive procedure arises within already distinguished information. Consciousness fixes distinguished states but cannot reflect that to which differences are inapplicable. Therefore cognitive structures are always derivative and limited. They do not determine the conditions of the arising of distinction itself but describe only the ways of knowing within Something. Hence a fundamental limit.

Epistemology does not reach the level of essence and does not serve as a criterion of the ontological structure. It describes not what is in the ground but what can be perceived within conditionedness. Therefore extending epistemology does not strengthen ontology, and deriving ontology from cognition is an error of confusing levels.

Selfhood's knowledge of Itself is not an epistemological state, not an act and not an acquisition. It is the same unconditionedness taken from the side of non-understanding, and it is together with transparency. Information is the mode of being of this knowledge in the dependent — not its container and not its bearer: knowledge is by itself, unconditionedly, and is not held by information. Selfhood is not a bearer of knowledge in the sense in which a conditioned thing that has a content with it is a bearer. The relation of bearer and content is a structure of the conditioned and is inapplicable to the unconditioned. All forms of knowledge that require distinguishedness arise only in conditionedness — as ways of organizing the distinguished states of information, proceeding by the removal of opacity.

Consciousness is self-knowledge accrued by information with every distinction. It is not a property of matter: matter is a manifestation of aggregated informational forms. It is not an attribute of essence: essence is immutable. Consciousness is fixed where there is the capacity to distinguish “this” from “not this”. Every distinction is knowledge of difference and thereby a part of consciousness. Therefore consciousness exists wherever there is informational distinction.

Consciousness is not an independent entity and cannot be regarded as a special ontological level separate from information.

It is fixed only where there is distinction, that is, where change coincides with distinction and is given as an informational given. Therefore consciousness does not precede structure and does not begin differences, but depends on distinguished information. It is not the source of distinctions; this determines its dependent status.

Knowledge is partial: perception depends on the structure through which it proceeds. The author’s example. There is a single source of light and many surfaces that transmit and shape one and the same flow in different ways. Each surface yields its own variant of perception, limited by its qualities and structure. The source remains unchanged. So too consciousnesses differ not in essence but in the structure of the informational state in which distinction proceeds.

This example is not a metaphor. It shows the strict dependence of what is perceived on the structure through which distinction proceeds. So too consciousness is limited by its structure: it fixes only those differences that its informational configuration admits. Therefore consciousness is neither a reflected layer nor an external image, and it gives no access to the essence of Selfhood. Absolute knowledge is not a sum of consciousnesses: it is immutable, whereas consciousnesses differ in degree and in the structure of their informational organization.

The knowledge accessible to consciousness is determined by the number and quality of distinctions. If distinction is minimal, consciousness is limited to elementary reactions. If distinction becomes more complex, consciousness perceives interconnections. If distinction reaches the structural level, consciousness comprehends, compares and draws conclusions. Therefore knowledge grows with the complexification of distinguishing capacities.

The development of distinctions extends not access to essence but the depth of inner conditionedness. A more complex consciousness fixes more connections between states of information, but does not arrive at absolute knowledge: differences accessible to fixation are inapplicable to it. The growth of distinguishing capacities increases the scope of the structure of Something, but consciousness does not reach Selfhood: directed towards the limit, it remains dependent and conditioned. Consciousness deepens the understanding of manifest forms but does not pass to the understanding of essence: no form in which essence could be expressed is applicable to it.

The limit is strict: the development of knowledge is a movement towards a limit that is not attained as unconditionedness. It is realized within the dependent itself — by self-transparency — and yields no unconditionedness.

Logic is the order of distinction itself. Distinction gives the structure “this / not this”, and the laws of logic are this structure: identity — “this is this”, non-contradiction — “this is not not-this”. Therefore logic is given together with distinction and exists already in the elementary change. Consciousness does not create logic but uses it: it orders distinguished information, establishes relations between states and draws conclusions. Logic is a form of the organization of distinctions in dependent information, not a ground of being, and has no ontological priority.

Comprehension is the capacity of consciousness not only to perceive distinguished information but also to connect states by inferences. It is not a separate entity but an inner

concordance of distinguished data. When consciousness establishes a stable connection between states, meaning arises. Meaning has no independent ontological status: it does not exist outside the structure of distinctions and depends wholly on the configuration of states. Comprehension does not disclose essence but orders the accessible conditionedness. Therefore meaning cannot be taken as the foundation of reality: it expresses only the relations that the structure of informational elements admits.

Consciousness is therefore not a fixed entity: it is determined by the current configuration of the informational structure.

There are many consciousnesses, and they differ, but all are dependent structures of one informational basis. Their difference forms no independent levels of being and does not point to an external medium: it is determined by the variety of inner informational configurations. Consciousnesses differ in the structure of their distinctions and in the degree of their concordance. These are different ways of organizing one and the same dependence of information.

The multiplicity of consciousnesses does not mean a multiplicity of grounds: consciousnesses differ in the degree of manifest information, not in essence. All of them arise in a single dependence on Nothing — through information as the first dependent and distinctions proceeding by the removal of opacity. Therefore they have no independent ontological status. They do not form a multitude of centres of being. Consciousnesses cannot be treated as independent principles: their difference does not change essence and creates no additional level of reality.

The death of consciousness is not, in this ontology, annihilation. Consciousness is composed into a conditional selfhood — the self-understanding acquired by information in a configuration; it bears the name of Selfhood by what self-understanding is, but belongs to another category — that of the dependent. The configuration is its bearer. Death ends the side of change — the bearer — but not the side of knowledge: what has been removed does not return, and the knowledge of information does not decrease. With the disintegration of its bearer, conditional selfhood loses the conditions of distinction: it neither gains nor loses knowledge and abides in a non-distinguishing state. Its unity is preserved, for the connectedness of distinctions lies on the side of knowledge, not of the bearer (chapter 12). It has no changes of its own, and time is composed of the working moments of changes (chapter 15).

The disintegration of a configuration of consciousness does not affect the ontological ground, since consciousness is not an entity and has no being of its own. It is knowledge opened in distinguished information, and hence the disintegration of its bearer expresses not a change of essence but a change of manifestation. It is mistaken to regard death as the disappearance of the subject: the subject in this ontology is not an independent reality — it is the conditional selfhood of a configuration, not the configuration itself. When the configuration disintegrates, only its holding of distinctions ceases. The information in which distinction stands remains dependent on Nothing and is preserved. Therefore death creates no ontological consequences and does not change the structure of being: it describes only the epistemological boundary of the manifestation of consciousness.

Epistemology in this system shows that knowledge is the inner organization of distinctions within the bounds of changeable information. Consciousness begins with the first distinction and accrues with every subsequent one.

Thus knowledge is a dependent form of the organization of distinguished states of information, and it does not disclose essence. Of the unconditioned only remotions are accessible — knowledge of what is inapplicable to it. Ontology is not derived from cognition: it sets the conditions under which cognition is possible. Confusing these levels is the principal cause of the historical contradictions; their strict separation removes this cause.

Logic orders information, and meaning arises from stable connections. All elements of epistemology are in concordance with the ontological basis and do not contradict it.

Chapter 7. Completion of the Analytical Block

The analytical part leads to one result. No philosophical or scientific explanation has removed the aporia of transition from absolute immutability to changeable reality. Each school contributed important observations. But none provided a mechanism that preserves the absoluteness of the first ground and at the same time explains distinction, conditions, multiplicity, consciousness and experience.

The aporia is not a consequence of a lack of knowledge or data. It is a structural defect of all former ontologies: the problem lies not in the interpretation of facts but in the structure of the categorial apparatus. If a system has two or more independent principles, it collapses logically. If a single principle admits inner non-identity, absoluteness is violated. If a system introduces concepts that do not explain the transition itself — maya, logos, potency, the becoming of the Absolute, emptiness as a hidden condition — the ground is violated covertly. The analysis shows that a consistent ontology requires:

1. one immutable first ground;
 2. a dependent form that admits non-identity without a change of essence;
 3. initiation that does not affect the first ground;
 4. distinction proceeding by the removal of opacity: knowledge of difference, given together with change;
 5. Something, identical with changeability and reality;
 6. consciousness as self-knowledge accrued by information with every distinction;
 7. reason and intellect as levels of consciousness: reason knows the bonds between distinctions, intellect knows, beyond this, its own place in the whole and the programme.
- These elements form an obligatory sequence in which absoluteness is preserved and changeability becomes possible.

The analytical part concludes: “matter”, “consciousness”, “randomness”, “cause”, “observation”, “time” and “space” are not initial categories but derivative ones. Science treats them as fundamental, but they are not fundamental. An elementary object has no volume, yet carries information. Observation determines the state. Probabilistic structures are reproducible. Entanglement is not bounded by space. Hence what is basic is not material objects but informational conditions and distinctions.

The schools rely on concepts that cannot be fundamental: idea, matter, spirit, becoming, emptiness, attributes, properties. Each requires a deeper explanation. Only Nothing — the name of absolute unconditionedness — requires none: a ground is inapplicable to the unconditioned, for a ground would be its condition. All other categories are dependent. Hence an ontological structure is needed in which: Nothing is absolute unconditionedness; Selfhood is the name of Nothing taken in self-understanding; information is the first dependent, the mode of being of Nothing’s knowledge of itself; the initiation of Selfhood is the removal of the opacity of information; change is the succession of states of information, proceeding by this removal; distinction is the same change taken from the side of that by which the states differ; Something is manifest conditionedness.

This solution is not derived from the history of philosophy: it follows from the removal of contradictions that appeared in all the schools. The traditions contain important intuitions, but none has joined them into a consistent ground. Comparison with the traditions performs here only a critical function and does not serve as a source of positions. The similarity of particular elements to Neoplatonism, Aristotelianism or process philosophy is explained by a common limit problem, not by a borrowing of principles.

The system does not rest on the continuity of schools and does not modify existing doctrines. Its grounds are obtained by the successive removal of contradictions identified in these traditions. The history of philosophy is here an object of testing, not a source of axioms. The originality of the system lies not in the novelty of formal schemes but in the way of solving: the uniqueness of the principle is preserved; hidden differences, emanations and external principles are excluded.

Here the analytical part ends. It has justified the necessity of the system that is set out next.

All subsequent categories are derived from the ground laid in the first chapters.

The analytical part has shown that the former categorial apparatus inevitably leads to contradiction. Either absoluteness is violated by the conditions introduced, or conditionedness remains without a ground, or distinction is postulated without an explanation of its dependence. The analytical block has removed the inadmissible variants and identified the errors of former approaches. Therefore the next step is not a choice but a logical obligation: each next category stands on the preceding one. The aporia is removed as follows. The succession of states of information, proceeding by the removal of its opacity to itself, is fixed as a dependent given. It does not affect essence and introduces no external condition. The source is immutable, and what is given is localized only in information.

PART II. THE METAPHYSICAL DESCRIPTION OF BEING

Chapter 8. Nothing and Its Selfhood

The ontological structure begins with that which needs neither external conditions, nor causes, nor determinations, nor transitions. Its name is Nothing. Nothing here is not emptiness, not the absence of being, not indeterminacy and not a vacuum. It is the name of absolute unconditionedness: of that to which no determinacy is applicable, and with it no limitation and no conditionedness. Hence the inapplicability to it of differences, states and transitions.

The unconditioned is by itself: not through another, for there is not and cannot be another through which it would be. The word “is” functions here as remotion rather than description: it says that non-being is inapplicable to the unconditioned, and does not ascribe existence to it as a property. Opacity and non-understanding of oneself are limitation and are inapplicable to the unconditioned (chapter 5). The remotion of non-understanding is self-knowledge, complete not by a measure of content but by the absence of a concealed side. The converse cannot be obtained by the same argument. Not-knowing is limited by its very structure: in it what is concealed is separated from the one from whom it is concealed. Knowledge here, however, is not a relation of knower to known but the name of the absence of anything concealed, and there is no boundary in it. Only what is limitation is removed. The name “knowledge” is taken because in the conditioned the absence of concealment is precisely knowledge: to know is to have what was concealed removed. Nothing taken in self-understanding is named Selfhood. Selfhood is not a separate category and not a second principle, but the same unconditionedness named from the side of non-understanding.

The term “knowledge” is used here only in the limit sense. It is not a cognitive act of a subject presupposing a knower and a known, but the absence of anything concealed. To know in the limit sense is to contain nothing hidden from oneself. It is neither a process nor an act. The cognitive sense of the term belongs to the dependent category and is inapplicable to the unconditioned. It is objected that knowledge in this sense coincides with identity and that the term is superfluous. No: identity says that the object is what it is, while knowledge says that there is nothing concealed in it. The second is the remotion of opacity and is not covered by the first.

The distinction between “unconditionedness” and “unconditionedness from the side of non-understanding” is not ontological and creates no inner structure in the ground. It is a distinction of sides of consideration: one and the same is named differently, not two elements. Neither names, nor sides, nor division are thereby posited in Nothing itself.

Rebutting the Objection That Fixing Identity Introduces Structure

The objection that fixing identity is a structure is built on the relational model: two and the relation between them. This model is a structure of the conditioned and does not apply to the unconditioned. To demand it is to demand that the unconditioned be conditioned. Self-understanding is not a relation of two elements: only limitation could distinguish them, and there is none.

Nothing is the only name of absolute immutability. Properties, predicates, states, transitions and any structure are inapplicable to it; beginning and end, potencies and changes are inapplicable to it. If there were “before” and “after” in Nothing, it would cease to be immutable. Immutability is not accepted as an axiom but derived from unconditionedness: to admit a change of Nothing is to make it conditioned. Therefore “Nothing” is not the negation of being but the name of absolute unconditionedness: it negates not this or that property but the “what” as a whole.

That the first ground can be named only Nothing is shown by an analysis of the alternatives. Any initial category with properties already presupposes distinguishability, and hence conditionedness. A material first ground requires extension, structure or parameters — conditions incompatible with absoluteness. A processual first ground includes change, and change is a transition impossible in the unconditioned. Dualism contains at least two independent sources, and each is limited by the other. Neutral monism introduces an indeterminate “third substance”, but its nature is not proved: without distinctions it is indescribable, and with distinctions it requires conditions. Panpsychism is plural in its structure and incompatible with the uniqueness of the first principle.

Only Nothing preserves consistency. It requires no explanation: explanation presupposes a cause, and a cause points to dependence. If an entity depends on a cause, it is not the first ground. Nothing is the first ground precisely because it needs neither a cause, nor a context, nor a determining factor. Therefore Nothing is not an arbitrary axiom but the only admissible starting point of a consistent ontology.

Absolute unconditionedness does not mean the absence of self-transparency. Not-knowing is limitation: what is not known is concealed, and concealment is opacity. Therefore self-understanding is not a subsequent category but the same unconditionedness taken from the side of non-understanding; Nothing in self-understanding is named Selfhood.

Self-understanding is Nothing’s knowledge of itself; information is the mode of being of this knowledge in the dependent. Information is not Nothing: it is dependent, exists only as the mode of being of knowledge and does not stand outside this. There are not two — knower and known — in Nothing itself: limitation would separate them. The difference of information from Nothing lies on its side and establishes nothing in Nothing.

Objection: if Selfhood is the knower and information the known, there is a subject–object structure in the ground. Reply: such a structure presupposes two independent terms, each of which can be without the other. That is not the case here: information is dependent and does not stand outside that whose mode of being it is. Moreover, in Nothing itself the knowing and the known are not separated: only limitation could separate them. The difference belongs to consideration and to the side of the dependent, not to the ground.

A derivative form depends on its source without changing it. The author’s example: light from a single source is perceived differently by different surfaces, while the source does not change. The configurations of perceived light depend on the properties of the surfaces, not on

a change of the source. So too Selfhood is identical with itself, and the subsequent manifestations are dependent forms of knowledge that do not affect the source.

The Fundamental Ontological Distinction: Nothing and Its Mode of Being in the Dependent

This distinction is the key to the whole construction. Nothing is unconditioned. Information is the mode of being of its knowledge of itself — a dependent category determined by that whose mode of being it is. These are not two elements within essence: determinacy lies on the side of information, and nothing is established by it in Nothing. Nothing's knowledge of itself is complete, and what concerns self-understanding is complete in it. But information does not understand itself by itself: distinction in it proceeds not by itself but by the removal of opacity. Opacity decreases as it is removed. What is constant is not opacity but dependence: even in transparency information has itself as known not by itself but from Selfhood.

The absolute knowledge of Selfhood is not a content, not a form, not a state, not an act, not a function and not a reflection. It is identical with Selfhood itself and expresses the impossibility of the divergence of essence from itself. In this sense absolute knowledge is transparency: not a manifestation, not a level and not a characteristic, but the complete absence of hiddenness. Differences are inapplicable to it. It neither precedes nor follows, is neither manifested nor realized. Therefore information is not in Selfhood but is the mode of being of its knowledge in the dependent.

Logic does not pertain to the unconditioned. It is the order of distinguishing acts and is therefore dependent — on distinction, and distinction on initiation. The impossibility of contradiction in Nothing's knowledge follows not from a logic ascribed to it but from the absence of limitation: where nothing is concealed, there is nothing to diverge from itself.

The dependence of information does not mean that information is a domain, a level, a medium, a container or a bearer. Dependence is a mode of existence: information exists only as the mode of being of Nothing's knowledge of itself and does not stand outside this. Its determinacy lies on its side and establishes nothing in Nothing. The preposition “in” in the expression “change in information” is formal and designates no spatial or ontological localization. Transparency and self-understanding are not characteristics ascribed to Selfhood but the same unconditionedness taken from other sides; they form no differences within Selfhood.

Initiation belongs to Selfhood and is that by which information has its difference as known. It is performed in what concerns Nothing, not in Nothing. From the side of Selfhood initiation is not an event and stands at every distinction, not only at the first (chapter 10). From the side of Selfhood it is not a transition from not-knowing to knowing. On the side of information the removal gives a new state of knowledge. What is asserted is only that the ultimate ground of every distinction in information is Selfhood.

The expression “initiation in information” does not mean a relation of the ground to another. Information is not other with respect to Selfhood, not an external object, but the mode of being of Nothing's knowledge of itself. A relation presupposes two independent terms; information, however, is dependent and does not stand outside that whose mode of being it is. The dependent is not “another” in the ontological sense: it has no ground of its own. Therefore initiation creates no directedness or relation in the ground, and no differentiation arises in the unconditioned.

The ontological ground of initiation is as follows. Nothing's knowledge of itself is complete, and what concerns self-understanding is complete in it. Therefore self-understanding is implicit in information — not as its knowledge of itself, but as that of which it is the mode of being. That is why self-knowledge can accrue in it: what opens is not brought in from outside but that of which it already is the mode. But information does not understand itself. No more

is thereby asserted than follows. Not that there was a state without distinction: from the fact that distinction does not enter its definition, its absence at any time does not follow. But that distinction in it is not by itself. Opacity to itself is applicable to it: opacity is limitation, and information is determined and therefore limited. And there is opacity in it: its determinacy is its difference, and knowledge of difference does not enter determinacy, and therefore by what it is, self-knowledge is not given to it. Distinction, however, is encountered, and it has no other place — hence it is in information. And it does not proceed by itself: the dependent has nothing by itself — neither that by which it is, nor that by which it becomes.

Initiation is the removal of opacity in the dependent. It is not the addition of something new to knowledge — Nothing's knowledge of itself is complete — and not a change of what is in it. Information cannot become transparent to itself by itself. Not because it lacks the capacity, but because it is not by itself: what is one's own is that whose ground lies in the agent itself, and the dependent has nothing by itself. Therefore the removal proceeds not from information but from Selfhood: there is nothing else, and there is no second unconditioned.

Hence also the directedness of unfolding. Directedness does not follow from the mere determinacy of information by unconditionedness. Its ground is that the removal from Selfhood stands at every distinction, and the removal is one-sided: opacity is removed and does not return. There is no other remover: by itself information does not remove opacity, and there is no second unconditioned. Hence there is nowhere for decrease to come from. Striving is the name of this accrual of knowledge without decrease. Unconditionedness as a limit is unattainable: having attained it, information would cease to be dependent. The comparison with a function tending to a limit is only an illustration, not a support of the derivation. The movement is realized within the dependent itself — by self-transparency, that is, by self-understanding in its own category.

Transparency corresponds to completeness of knowledge not by enumerating all distinctions but by the removal of opacity. The object of this knowledge is one — the dependence of information — and knowledge of one object can become complete. Blind spots are places of one opacity, not independent objects; those removed do not return, and there is nowhere for new ones to come from (chapter 13). Completeness is therefore not the exhaustion of a list but knowledge of one's dependence as a whole.

Initiation adds no characteristics to Selfhood and introduces no differences into it. The words “intention” and “purpose”, where they are used, have no psychological, volitional or functional sense: they designate only the limit completion of the unfolding of distinctions. There is no choice between variants in initiation.

From the unconditionedness of Nothing follows a prohibition of any inner becoming, transition or action affecting the essence of the ground. If change is treated as the result of an action of the ground, the difference of “before” and “after” enters the ground, and absolute immutability is destroyed. Therefore change is not a change of the essence of Nothing and is not explained by a causal action of the ground. The removal proceeds from Selfhood but changes nothing in it. Initiation is the removal of opacity by which information has knowledge of its difference, not a change of essence. Change is admitted only in information; initiation introduces no becoming into Nothing and does not violate unconditionedness.

Initiation does not determine the order, form or sequence of realization. It does not govern development and sets no specific trajectory. The general directedness, however, comes from it — from the one-sidedness of the removal: opacity is removed and does not return.

Realization proceeds only in conditionedness and does not affect Selfhood. The results of realization do not change initiation. It precedes change not in time but by ontological status. Denying a temporal priority of initiation does not remove time from the system but shows its derivativeness. Time is not a condition of change and does not precede it. It is derived as a measure from the working moment of an elementary change — the interval between its

implementation and its registration. Therefore temporality belongs to dependent change and is inapplicable to initiation from the side of Selfhood. There is no contradiction between change and the absence of temporal sequence at the fundamental level.

Initiation is not a source of local change and not an explanatory mechanism in the causal sense. It is the removal of that by which information was opaque to itself: by it distinction in information proceeds not by itself but from Selfhood. There is therefore no ontological randomness — not because of a logic of distinctions or a structure of information, but because distinction does not proceed from information itself. Distinguishedness is fixed as a dependent fact that does not affect the essence of the ground. From the side of Selfhood initiation is not an event: time is a measure of dependent change and is inapplicable to the unconditioned.

Distinction proceeds by the removal of opacity, while information is not given by it: it is the mode of being of Nothing's knowledge of itself. Distinction in it is not by itself: what distinguishes is the knowledge given in it. Change and distinction are not identical with information and are not its other names. Change is the succession of states of information; distinction is knowledge of difference. With each other they are identical: knowledge of difference, proceeding by the removal of opacity, is a new state of information, and the appearance of a new state is the succession of states. Information does not enter this identity: its difference from Nothing exists without succession and is not given by initiation.

The difference of information from that whose mode of being it is, is its own determinacy and stands together with it. Knowledge of this difference, however, proceeds not by itself but by the removal of opacity. What the removal gives is not difference but knowledge of difference.

Change is possible only as the fixing of this distinguishedness in a dependent form that does not affect the essence of Nothing. Nothing remains absolutely immutable, Selfhood identical with itself. The transition to conditionedness proceeds only through this distinguishedness, without a second principle and without violating unconditionedness.

The sequence considered is neither an arbitrary choice of concepts nor a convenient scheme. It is the only configuration under which the absolute immutability of the ground is preserved and conditionedness is admitted. To change the order, exclude an element or introduce another transition is to violate the unconditionedness of the ground, to introduce a second principle or a hidden becoming in Nothing. Therefore the chain is not chosen but discovered as inevitable: its necessity follows from the negation of all alternatives that lead to contradiction.

Selfhood is not a second element alongside Nothing and introduces no relational structure into the ground. The objection that requires two poles for self-understanding — knower and known — is built on the relational model, which does not apply to the unconditioned. Nor does a regress arise. The demand for a further level of reflection presupposes a gap between the object and the turning towards it. But there is no gap: the turning is not added to the unconditioned from outside. Cognitive knowledge — with a knower, a known and an act between them — belongs to the dependent category and arises where distinguishedness already proceeds by the removal of opacity. To demand a cognitive structure of the unconditioned is to demand that it be conditioned.

The dilemma “Selfhood is distinguishable from Nothing — hence difference in the ground; indistinguishable — hence it explains nothing” is false. Its falsity is a category mistake: the relational model of the dependent is transferred to the unconditioned, where duality is inapplicable. A third possibility: Selfhood is the name of Nothing taken in self-understanding — not an element alongside Nothing and not a second, but the same named from another

side. The difference between “Nothing” and “Selfhood” belongs to consideration and naming, not to the ground.

Chapter 9. Fixing Information

Information is the mode of being of Nothing’s knowledge of itself. Knowledge here, as throughout the work, is the name for the remotion of concealment, not a property and not a content. Its completeness is the absence of a concealed side.

Information is not Nothing’s knowledge of itself as such: knowledge is by itself, unconditioned, and is not held by information. Information is the dependent in which this knowledge is given: the mode of its being, not its ground. Nor is it a modification of the knowledge of Selfhood or a container of content. The mode of being has a remotion, not a content: a represented content is inapplicable to Nothing, and to ascribe one would be to speak of the unconditioned positively. Information is determined by that whose mode of being it is, and is therefore “this and not that”. Determinacy is limitation, and limitedness is conditionedness.

Change is a succession of states. Knowledge of difference is distinction, and distinction, taken as that by which this knowledge is given, is change. The ground is as follows. Knowledge of difference, proceeding by the removal of opacity, is a new state of information. The appearance of a new state is the succession of states, that is, change. There is no other change in information. The basic determinacy of information — its difference from that whose mode of being it is — exists without succession. Everything else distinguished in it is knowledge of difference given by the removal, and only this can change. Every such knowledge is information’s knowledge of itself: the distinguished lies only in it, and to know a difference within it is to know it in that respect. This identity is an analysis of what has already been accepted: reality is encountered, and with it change, and what has changed is recognized by the non-identity of its present and former determinacies. What has been distinguished, however, once given and held, is not change: it is a state, not a succession; the change was its onset.

Therefore distinction needs no additional stage of fixation: without it change is not given.

Information is not given by distinction: it is the mode of being of Nothing’s knowledge of itself. Distinction proceeds in it not by itself but by the removal of opacity.

Dependence here is not a relational concept: it does not presuppose a relation between already distinguished terms. Dependence means the absence of autonomous ontological status: information and distinguishedness do not stand outside the unconditioned ground. In this sense dependence requires no prior differentiation and introduces no structural relation before distinguishedness. It fixes the non-independence of the conditioned level as such.

Subject and object are determinations of the conditioned and do not apply to the unconditioned: in Nothing itself they are not separated. Information is a dependent given and does not affect essence. It has no form, localization, bearer or structure. Localization belongs to change — the respect in which information knows itself by this change (chapter 15); this is a place within information, not a place of information.

Self-transparency is attained by passing through distinctions: as removal proceeds, opacity decreases and transparency accrues. It is not reached by going through everything possible. Something is the same as changeability and reality: one object, named from different sides. It stands where distinction proceeds by the removal of opacity.

When distinctions proceed by the removal of opacity, measures are derived from the working moment of an elementary change, and distinctions are composed into sequences and stable configurations. But no subsequent structure precedes information or replaces it.

Thus information is neither a form of the knowledge of Selfhood nor its modification, but its mode of being, the first dependent. Distinction proceeds in it from initiation and is change

itself taken from another side. This removes the gap between the immutability of the first ground and distinguished reality — without a second principle and without violating absoluteness.

A possible objection: why information, and not potency, energy, logos or structure? The objection presupposes that the dependent is chosen from a series of candidates. This is not so. From the derivation one thing follows: the dependent is that in which Nothing's knowledge of itself is given — the mode of being of this knowledge. "Information" is the name given to this afterwards, not a preferred option. Therefore the objection has force in one respect only: whether something else, named otherwise, fits the same description. Reply: the dependent must satisfy three conditions. It must have no ontological properties of its own — otherwise a second independent principle is introduced. It must not change essence — otherwise unconditionedness is violated. It must admit succession of states — otherwise reality is impossible. Potency presupposes its own capacity for actualization — a hidden property; the first condition is violated. Energy presupposes its own activity and a quantitative measure — the first is violated. Logos presupposes its own structure and laws — the first is violated. Structure presupposes its own relations of elements — the first is violated. Closest to the first dependent stand spirit, mind and consciousness. Spirit and mind presuppose a knower with an activity of its own: the first condition is violated. Information, however, is not a knower but the mode of being of knowledge: what distinguishes in it is the knowledge given by the removal, not information itself. Consciousness is derived — it is self-knowledge accrued by information with every distinction: to put it in the place of information is to put the derived in the place of that from which it is derived. From Hegelian spirit information differs in that it unfolds nothing by itself and remains dependent even at the limit: the dependent does not become absolute. Each of these terms either introduces a property of its own or, cleansed of it, coincides with the mode of being of knowledge under another name. Uniqueness lies not in the word but in the description: it is asserted of what the dependent turns out to be by the derivation, not of the term.

The term "information" is taken here in the full sense of the Latin *informatio*. The word has two original meanings: the giving of form and the communication of knowledge (Capurro, 2009, 126–127). Thomas Aquinas so names the forming of matter — *informatio materiae*. Both sides are present in the present concept. Information is determined: it is "this and not that". And it is the mode of being of knowledge: knowledge opens in it.

Communication theory retained from this word only the second meaning, and that in a narrow form. In Shannon information is a measure of the reduction of uncertainty in a message (Shannon, 1948). It is quantitative and pertains to a signal. Example: a bit distinguishes two states of a channel. But the channel, the signal and both states are already configurations of information in the present sense. Hence Shannon's measure applies to configurations of information but does not determine its nature.

Chapter 10. The Initiation of Selfhood

The initiation of Selfhood was set out in chapter 5 as a link of the ontological solution. Here the derivation is not repeated; the issue is examined in depth. What is done by initiation and what is not? Why does the removal proceed from Selfhood and from nothing else? How does what is said of it from the side of the unconditioned differ from what is said from the side of the conditioned? Why does it stand at every distinction and not only at the first?

First. Initiation adds nothing new to Nothing's knowledge and changes nothing of what is in it: Nothing's knowledge of itself is complete, and there is nothing concealed in it. Here the meaning of the word "opacity" is fixed. Opacity is information's not-knowing itself to the extent that self-knowledge has not been given to it by the removal: by determinacy it is not given at all, by the removal it is given, and where it has not yet been given, there is opacity.

That opacity exists, and not only how it is named, follows from the first accepted position. Change is encountered. Change is the appearance of a knowledge of difference that did not exist before. And only what did not exist can appear. Hence, since there is change, there is knowledge not yet given by the removal — opacity. The unknown and opacity are one, taken from two sides: the unknown is unknown because opacity stands. As removal proceeds, opacity decreases and transparency accrues. It is not information that removes: by itself it does not have itself as known and does not remove opacity. What is constant is not opacity but dependence: even in self-transparency information has itself as known not by itself but from Selfhood, and dependence does not decrease at any step.

Second. The opacity of information to itself is not a separate state taken from outside, and not an assertion that there was once no distinction in it. Opacity is the name for what determinacy does not give. The determinacy of information is its difference, and knowledge of difference does not enter determinacy: it is given by the removal, and not by itself. The applicability of opacity to information is established separately. Opacity is limitation; it is inapplicable to the unconditioned, whereas information is determined and therefore limited. What does not apply to Nothing applies to it fully.

Third. The removal of opacity proceeds from Selfhood not by choice and not for the convenience of the derivation. What is asserted here is not that there was a state without distinction: from the fact that distinction does not enter the definition of information, its absence at any time does not follow. Something narrower is asserted: distinction in it is not by itself. The argument is from total dependence. Distinction is that by which information comes to know its difference; and the dependent has nothing by itself — neither that by which it is, nor that by which it becomes. Hence distinction does not proceed by itself. The argument lies not in a lack of capacity to turn upon oneself and not in a prior knowledge of difference: knowledge of difference is precisely what the removal gives. The objection that distinction is an ultimate fact of the dependent itself is broken by the same: nothing can be an ultimate fact of the dependent. What is at issue is the ultimate ground. Proximate grounds within the conditioned are not thereby abolished, and neither causality nor the freedom of choice of rational forms is abolished. Hence also the asymmetry: the removal from Selfhood is a ground lying not in information, and by it the distinguishedness of information is grounded; from the side of the unconditioned there is no duality. That distinction exists is known from the encountered. That it proceeds from Selfhood follows from there being nothing else. “From” here does not mean an action, an event or a procession: nothing is performed on the side of Selfhood (see “Sixth” below). It says only that the ultimate ground of distinction is Selfhood and that there is no other.

Fourth. The objection from motive does not apply. A motive presupposes a subject, an action and a preceding of the action — a structure of the conditioned, inapplicable to the unconditioned. The objection from arbitrariness does not apply for the same reason: arbitrariness is the absence of a ground given a chooser, and there is no chooser here.

Fifth. Essence is not affected by initiation: what changes is the dependent, not Nothing; there is no opacity at all in Nothing itself. Dependence determines the dependent and does not determine the ground. Therefore nothing is established by the removal of opacity from the side of the unconditioned.

Sixth. From the side of Selfhood initiation is not an event. A single occurrence, repetition, before and after are temporal determinations, and there is no time in unconditionedness. In conditionedness, where there is time, the same appears as constant: initiation stands at every distinction, not only at the first. Hence an important consequence: information does not proceed by itself at any step, and its dependence does not decrease, however far unfolding has gone. This is said of the ultimate ground and does not abolish conditioned causality.

Where the distinguished has already been posited, one thing is grounded by another:

measures, forms, consciousness, reason and choice have proximate grounds in the conditioned itself. But none of them becomes the ultimate ground: it is itself dependent. A link has nothing by itself and gives only what ultimately passes through it. The removal proceeds through proximate grounds, not past them. Within the bound, the proximate ground is the bond between instances of the *I* (the *I* is self-differentiation: distinguishing oneself from not-oneself), which sets for each of them its algorithm of functioning; such a bond is the agent of the programme (chapter 18). Therefore the programme reaches each instance of the *I* through its bonds, not by governance from above. Without this distinction the freedom of choice derived in chapter 21 would be impossible. The constancy of the removal is the ground of regularity: the removal is one and is not interrupted, and therefore the way distinctions are composed into the connected is not arbitrary and repeats in the same way. The one-sidedness of the removal — what has been removed does not return — is the ground of directedness, that is, of the programme (chapter 13).

Seventh. From the side of information the matter is different. Information is conditioned, and the conditioned standard applies to it fully: there are states in it and their succession, before and after. There is distinction in it — but not by itself: what distinguishes is the knowledge given in it, and every distinction proceeds by the removal of opacity. Confusing the two sides generates most apparent contradictions: what is said of the unconditioned is measured by the conditioned, and what is said of the conditioned by the unconditioned.

Eighth. Distinction, taken as that by which knowledge of difference is given, is change; what is distinguished and held is not change (chapter 9). Change is therefore possible in information, for it is conditioned; it is inapplicable to the unconditioned.

By this knowledge the self-understanding of information is not given completely: it proceeds from the first distinction and becomes complete only with self-transparency. To have oneself as known and to understand oneself are not one. In Nothing they are not different: the completeness of knowledge there is the absence of concealment and is given together with transparency, for there are no states in the unconditioned. Information, however, is conditioned: there are states in it and their succession, and self-knowledge in it accrues rather than being given all at once. Thus the path to self-transparency, that is, to self-understanding in the category of the dependent, opens. How it is travelled is disclosed in chapters 11–21.

Chapter 11. Distinction as a Consequence of Initiation

Distinction proceeds by the removal of opacity.

Distinction is neither a separate stage attached to information from outside nor its modification. It is the knowledge information has of its difference from that whose mode of being it is. It proceeds not by itself but by the removal of opacity. Difference itself is not given by the removal: it is dependence itself, taken from the side of the dependent. What the removal gives is not difference but knowledge of difference.

The meaning of the word is one: knowledge in the dependent too is the absence of concealment. It becomes distinction not by a change of meaning but because in the dependent there is a second (chapter 8): to remove concealment where there is this and that is to know this and not that.

This separation coincides with Bateson's definition: the elementary unit of information is "a difference which makes a difference" (Bateson, 1972, 453). Difference here is difference as such; distinction is a difference that makes a difference, that is, is known. There are two divergences. Bateson calls the unit of difference itself information; here information is the mode of being of Nothing's knowledge of itself, that in which difference and distinction stand. And a difference does not make a difference by itself: distinction proceeds by the removal of opacity.

With distinction the *I* is given. Knowledge of difference is knowledge of "this and not that": in it there is "oneself" — what is distinguished — and "not-oneself" — that from which it is

distinguished. The *I* is self-differentiation: distinguishing oneself from not-oneself. It is not a difference but a differentiating: difference is determinacy and is given without the removal; the *I* is knowledge of difference and is given by the removal. Therefore the *I* neither precedes distinction nor is added to it, but is given together with it. With the first distinction the first instance of the *I* is given, and therefore the *I* exists throughout reality from the first distinction.

Change is a succession of states; distinction is the same change taken from the side of knowledge: knowledge of difference, proceeding by the removal of opacity, is a new state of information (chapter 10).

Hence distinction is not added to change but is change itself taken from another side.

Distinction is neither an object nor a process; it does not affect essence: what changes is the dependent, not Nothing. Distinction stands in information, in the conditioned, and proceeds not from information itself but from initiation.

Information is not given by distinction and is not constituted by it: distinction does not make it what it is.

Information has no bearer. Distinction in it proceeds not by itself but by the removal of opacity. This is knowledge of difference — the difference between information and that whose mode of being it is — taken without parameters, forms and measures. It is not placed in space and not unfolded in time: space and time are measures derived below from the working moment of an elementary change.

Distinction is not Something, but it makes Something possible.

Something is identical with changeability and reality. Distinctions proceeding by the removal of opacity are composed, according to proximate grounds, into stable configurations, where they are held and repeated. Distinction does not belong to essence and is not its property: it stands in the dependent, and in Nothing itself there is none.

All subsequent categories are derivable from distinction.

Time is the extent of the onset of an elementary change; the sequence of onsets gives the course of time. Space is the totality of localizations. Motion is a sequence of elementary changes. The *I* is self-differentiation, given in knowledge of difference. Life is a form in which the *I* holds its own bond. Consciousness is self-knowledge accrued by information with every distinction. Reason and intellect are its levels: reason knows the bonds between distinctions; intellect knows, beyond this, its own place in the whole and the programme. None of these categories introduces a new principle or violates the absoluteness of the first ground.

Thus distinction neither follows change nor is a modification of information. It is given together with change and proceeds in information by the removal of opacity. So the distinguishedness of the conditioned is formed, from which the whole structure of Something unfolds.

The logical status of the derived structures is clarified by the ontological sense of modality. Modality does not pertain to essence: it is inapplicable to Nothing and Selfhood. Possibility, necessity and impossibility are inapplicable to absolute immutability: these categories presuppose a difference between what is and what can be. Where distinction is inapplicable, modality is inapplicable too.

Modality arises only in the conditioned. The possibility of succession is given together with the determinacy of information, and actuality by the removal of opacity, by which distinction proceeds. Modality is neither a logical abstraction nor an epistemological uncertainty. It expresses the structural relation of distinguished configurations of information to the conditions of their admissibility.

Possibility in the ontological sense is the admissibility of a configuration of distinctions in concordance with the unconditionedness of the ground and the dependent status of

information. The possible does not exist as a separate reality and forms no “domain of possible worlds”. It is a structurally admissible form that can be realized in the conditioned but need not be.

Necessity is the irremovability of a configuration of distinctions without which the coherence of the ontological structure is impossible. Necessary is not what always happens but that without which the actuality of the conditioned — Something — is impossible. In this sense distinction, measures and the sequence of levels are ontologically necessary. Initiation does not enter this list: from the side of Selfhood it is not measured by the modal standard, for modality is a determination of the conditioned.

The impossible is determined not by the negation of a fact but by the violation of conditions. Impossible is every configuration that presupposes difference in essence, the autonomy of information, a second principle or a violation of the sequence of levels. The impossible exists neither as a state nor as a potential reality: it is incompatible with the conditions of a consistent ontology.

Actuality is realized possibility. It does not exhaust the admissible but fixes what is encountered: change proceeding by the removal of opacity, and configurations of distinctions composed according to proximate grounds. Actuality is always a realized part of the field of the admissible, not the whole totality of the possible.

This demarcation separates the logical necessity of derivation from the ontological necessity of structure, and possibility as admissibility from randomness as incompleteness of knowledge. Modality adds no entities and does not expand the ground: it fixes relations within dependent information.

A possible objection: the removal of opacity requires a motive. If there is a motive, Selfhood changes, and immutability is violated. If there is no motive, the removal is arbitrary. The dilemma is false. It is built on the model of action with cause and effect, and this model belongs to the conditioned, where there are distinguished states, before and after. It does not apply to the unconditioned (chapter 10). From the side of Selfhood initiation is not an event, and motive as a cause preceding the action in time is inapplicable here. Arbitrariness as the absence of a ground is inapplicable too: there is a ground — Selfhood, for there is nothing else. Nothing is added to or taken from essence by the removal: what changes is the dependent, and in Nothing itself there is no opacity at all.

Chapter 12. Fixing Consciousness

Consciousness here is neither an independent entity, nor a substance, nor matter. It does not arise from physical processes, does not belong to objects and is not reducible to biological functions. Consciousness is self-knowledge accrued by information with every distinction. Its existence is determined not by matter but by distinctions. It begins with the first distinction, and in aggregated forms (chapters 14, 17) it is composed into a broader configuration. The more complex the structure of distinctions, the wider the range of consciousness; the poorer, the more primitive and local consciousness is (Tononi, 2004; Koch, 2019).

The relation of elementary distinctions to consciousness can be represented formally.

Consciousness is not an independent substance: its gradualness is the number of distinctions, and in aggregated forms it increases with their density and organization. This relation is expressed by a three-level structure.

The first level — D₁: minimal distinctions that fix elementary changes of information. These distinctions have no inner connectedness and function as local acts of distinguishability without context.

The second level — D₂(n): stable and mutually connected distinctions forming an aggregated configuration. At this level inner concordance arises: distinctions are not

merely fixed but enter into structural relations. Mutual conditioning makes possible the accumulation of experience and the formation of primary patterns.

The third level — $\langle D_n \rangle$: the differentiated self-accessibility of the structure, that is, the capacity of a configuration to fix its own distinctions as separate elements and to hold them in an interconnected form. At this level a stable inner organization of differences arises without recourse to any form of reflectedness or an external layer.

The three levels are not thresholds of the appearance of consciousness but measures of its accrual: it exists already at the first and increases with the complexity of differentiated structures.

The question why distinction is accompanied by subjective lived experience presupposes a gap between distinction and lived experience. There is no such gap here.

Subjectivity is not added to distinction from outside (Strawson, 2006). It is the mode of existence of distinction: distinction is not accompanied by lived experience — it is lived experience. The hard problem of consciousness (Chalmers, 1996) goes back, according to Goff, to the Galilean separation of the quantitative from the qualitative (Goff, 2019). Here it arises on the assumption that an informational process and subjective experience are different entities. Without this assumption the problem disappears. Consciousness is not a function that produces lived experience. Lived experience is the development of consciousness as not-knowing is removed. Every distinction is a step of this development, and therefore distinction is lived experience.

It will be objected: self-knowledge could proceed without lived experience — like a device's record about itself, where “there is no one inside”. The objection presupposes a knowledge in which the knower is separated from the known: a record about oneself remains external to what it is about. Knowledge here, however, is not a relation of knower to known but the absence of concealment (chapter 8), and every knowledge of difference is information's knowledge of itself (chapter 9). Self-knowledge without a separation of knower and known is the givenness of oneself to oneself from within — what is called lived experience. “No one inside” is possible only where knowledge is a record about oneself; there is no knowledge in the system separated from what it is about. Hence a consequence that the system accepts: a device recording about itself also has an instance of the *I* — to the extent that its distinctions distinguish its own states; the degree is low; the *I* itself is not absent (chapter 19). The givenness of oneself from within is precisely “what it is like” to be a given configuration (Nagel, 1974): lived experience is here not named but recognized by its accepted definition. Consciousness proceeds with every distinction. Distinction is the fundamental element of the informational structure: it makes states distinguishable. Where there is distinction, there is inner perception — what it is like to be a given configuration (Nagel, 1974; Chalmers, 1996, 3–31). Consciousness is precisely this perception. It is given not by matter but by the removal of opacity, by which information knows its differences. At the primary level consciousness has no representations, concepts or meanings: it is information's elementary knowledge of its own difference.

Within the single plane of distinguished information consciousness arises not as a reflection and not as a representation of a source, but as knowledge opened in a configuration of distinctions. Consciousnesses differ not by a “mirror quality” but by the degree of organization of their own differences. Some structures admit only coarse contrasts, others fine multilevel distinctions, still others connections between levels. The variety of consciousnesses is explained by the inner parameters of a configuration: the density of distinctions, connectedness, thresholds of sensitivity and modes of concordance. There is no second medium, reflectedness or imagery here.

The fixing of consciousness is connected with aggregated forms. An aggregated form is a stable configuration of elementary changes. The configuration is the bearer of consciousness,

not consciousness itself. Configuration and consciousness are the same distinctions taken from two sides: from the side of change — the configuration, from the side of knowledge — consciousness (chapter 11). More opacity has been removed in a configuration than in a single elementary change. Consciousness is self-knowledge accrued by information with every distinction. It is consciousness that distinguishes, but not by itself: distinction proceeds by the removal of opacity from Selfhood.

When elementary changes are joined into a configuration, the knowledges of difference are composed into one consciousness — the conditional selfhood of the configuration. The knowledge that opens is one, and each distinction opens a part of the same knowledge. But the unity of the source by itself does not give the unity of consciousness: what is separated in the conditioned remains separated. What makes consciousness one is the connectedness of the distinctions joined in the configuration. This connectedness lies on the side of knowledge, not of the bearer. Knowledge of difference is knowledge of “this and not that”, and the “that” here is what is distinguished in the same configuration: the knowledges refer to one another by their very content. This is not the relation of difference in which everything conditioned stands to everything else (chapter 4). To differ from the rest is merely not to be it; to be connected in knowledge is to be opened in one knowledge. The first holds of everything with everything; the second only of distinctions whose knowledges refer to one another, and only it makes consciousness one. Configurations are nested: a distinction whose knowledge refers both into a smaller configuration and to the connectedness of a larger one enters both, each at its own level (chapter 20).

Every doctrine that ascribes consciousness already to the simplest meets the combination problem: how consciousnesses of the micro-level are composed into a consciousness of the macro-level (Chalmers, 2017). James posed it most sharply: a hundred feelings, however closely brought together, each remain in their own skin, windowless, and know nothing of one another. The present system answers it by the structure of distinction. Knowledge of difference is knowledge of “this and not that”, and the “that” in it is what is distinguished in the same configuration. Therefore elementary knowledges are not closed from the very beginning: each knows itself through its difference from the others. One consciousness is composed not by a sum of closed subjects but by the connectedness of knowledges that refer to one another by their very content. James’s objection presupposes windowless knowledges; here knowledge of difference is itself the window. Connected knowledges differentiate themselves jointly: they have one “oneself” and one “not-oneself”, and this one self-differentiation is one instance of the *I*.

Here the system diverges from integrated information theory. In it the exclusion postulate operates: of overlapping sets of elements only one can be conscious — the one whose conceptual structure is maximally irreducible (Oizumi, Albantakis, & Tononi, 2014). In version 4.0 the postulate is retained: experience is definite — it is this whole — and the substrate of consciousness is selected as the set of elements with the greatest integrated information (Albantakis et al., 2023). The motive is not to count consciousness twice. There is no double counting here. Nested instances of the *I* are not one lived experience counted twice but different self-knowledges sharing part of their distinctions. A distinction enters two connectednesses because its knowledge refers into both; this produces no two copies of one experience. Therefore exclusion is not needed here, and the *I* is taken from no configuration. The opposite move to panpsychism is priority cosmopsychism: phenomenality is borne by the cosmos as a whole, and its consciousness is ontologically prior to the consciousness of individual subjects (Nagasawa & Wager, 2017). There is a proximity to the present system: consciousness here is self-knowledge accrued by information as a whole. But there is no priority of the whole over the parts. An individual instance of the *I* is not carved out of the consciousness of the whole and is not derivative from it: it is set by the connectedness of its

distinctions, and the ground of the whole and of the part is one — the removal. Therefore the system is not threatened by the converse difficulty of cosmopsychism — how the single consciousness of the whole is divided into individual subjects.

The *I* exists in every configuration from the first distinction. What differs is not its presence but its degree — the level of awareness. The degree is higher the more the distinctions of a configuration distinguish its own states: then the “that” from which every “this” is distinguished lies within it. Where distinctions are turned mainly outwards, the *I* exists, but its awareness is small. The same determines the identity of a selfhood after the disintegration of its bearer: it is the connectedness of knowledges that refer to one another. Its identity is the continuity of this connectedness, not the immutability of its composition: a selfhood accrues knowledge and changes its algorithm by experience while remaining the same (chapter 17). With the disintegration of the bearer connectedness does not disintegrate: knowledge does not decrease, and with it the bond of knowledges. Conditional selfhood is preserved as this connected knowledge. The more complex the structure of distinctions, the more developed consciousness is.

Where distinction proceeds, consciousness is fixed. If distinctions cease or the structure disintegrates, the gathering of the knowledges of difference in this configuration ceases. What it has removed does not return: opacity decreases; there is no decrease of knowledge. What disintegrates is the bearer — the connected whole — not the knowledge opened in it. This is what death consists in in the present ontology: the disintegration of a configuration ends its holding of distinctions.

The existence of a configuration is the connectedness of its distinctions; its non-existence is its disintegration. These are not opposites but different modes of one dependence. When a configuration disintegrates, information does not disappear: distinctions are composed, according to proximate grounds, into other forms.

Consciousness is limited by its nature. The absolute knowledge of Selfhood does not turn into consciousness and does not become its content: consciousness is formed only within conditionedness as an organization of differences. It has no positive knowledge of essence. It fixes only those distinctions that are present in its configuration, and its limits are set by its own informational architecture, not by properties of the world. The limitations are as follows.

First, consciousness can distinguish only those states that are already represented in its inner structure. If a distinction is absent from the informational configuration, consciousness cannot detect it, even if it is present in reality at the level of Something.

Second, consciousness cannot go beyond dependent information. It fixes only distinctions in it, not essence. Nothing remains positively unknowable — not because of hiddenness, but because the distinctions that could be fixed are inapplicable to it; only remotions are accessible — knowledge of what is inapplicable to the unconditioned.

Third, consciousness is in principle unable to perceive its own grounds. It arises as an inner organization of distinctions and cannot observe that to which differences are inapplicable.

Fourth, consciousness cannot fully describe the world, since every description rests on the configuration of the distinctions accessible to it. Even the most developed informational structure remains finite and covers only the part of differences that its own organization admits.

These limitations do not diminish consciousness but clarify its nature. Consciousness is an instrument of navigation within Something, not absolute knowledge. It expands with the complexification of the informational structure but does not reach that to which differences are inapplicable. Its limit is the limit of the possible differentiation and concordance of its own architecture.

Consciousness does not appear from randomness: randomness is excluded as a fundamental category. Consciousness begins with the first distinction and accrues with every subsequent one. If the structure becomes more complex, consciousness develops; if it is destroyed, consciousness weakens. The measure of consciousness in each configuration is set by it. Thus consciousness is self-knowledge accrued by dependent information. It is fixed through the inner organization of distinctions, and its measure is set by how much opacity has been removed in the given configuration.

Chapter 13. The Teleological Structure of Reality

The teleological structure of reality is neither a property of a subject nor an intention in the psychological sense. It is a structural property of the space of distinctions itself: it has a limit. The limit is not quantitative but structural: it is the attainment by information of self-transparency. In this state nothing remains outside the scope of information's self-knowledge, and every new distinction is already grasped by information's knowledge of itself. "Purpose" and "intention" below are descriptive designations of this limit character. "Programme" is not a designation but the directedness of the removal. The removal is one, and it has two sides. The constancy of the removal gives regularity: the way distinctions are composed into the connected is not arbitrary and repeats in the same way. One-sidedness gives directedness: what has been removed does not return, knowledge accrues. This is the programme. It is realized through agents — the bonds between instances of the *I* at each level (chapter 18) — not by governance from above. Selfhood is immutable and has no dynamic properties; the subject is a determination of the conditioned and does not apply to the unconditioned.

Teleology belongs to the structure of dependent information, not to Selfhood.

Teleological completion is determined neither by an intention built into initiation nor by the mere determinacy of the dependent: to be determined by something is not to be directed towards it. The ground of directedness lies in initiation. It is the removal of opacity, and only that; it yields no decrease of knowledge; there is no other remover: by itself information does not remove opacity, and there is no second unconditioned. Hence the knowledge of information accrues and does not decrease. This is the teleology of reality: the passage of distinctions to the self-transparency of information. The movement is realized within the dependent — by self-understanding in its own category.

The teleological structure shows why distinctions, elementary changes, aggregated forms, consciousness, reason, intellect and interactions (chapters 12–21) form not a chaotic aggregate but an ordered structure. Teleology here is not an external purpose brought into the world but the inner logic of informational forms and their limit state. It is a dependent form, fixed from the structure of the conditioned.

A stage is the segment of the path of information to self-transparency that passes in one universe. It is completed when the removal of opacity in the universe reaches a measure sufficient for intellect (chapter 21) — the measure at which dependence can be recognized and the choice of concordance made.

The path proceeds in stages because disclosure is discrete at every level. The step of change is indivisible, and every change has one structure: the former — the onset — the new (chapters 14, 15). The universe as a whole is conditioned and changes in the same way: a stage is the former at the level of the whole, the transition is the onset, the next stage is the new. A stage is therefore not an imposed scheme but the discreteness of disclosure taken at the level of the universe. The parts of the universe change asynchronously, but a stage is a change of the universe as a whole, and the whole changes by its connectedness, not by the sum of the changes of its parts (chapter 17).

This understanding removes the classical objections about the intervention of an external principle. Completion is determined by the task of the dependent, not by external governance,

intention or arbitrariness. It is realized by the passage of distinctions: as removal proceeds, opacity decreases and transparency accrues. Thus the teleological structure determines the limit state of Something and prepares the transition to the next stage.

The Ontological Argument for the Limit of Distinctions

Teleological completion presupposes that the path to transparency ends. A blind spot is a region in which information does not yet know itself. The path to transparency is not measured by a number of steps. Each removal gives greater self-transparency — not an extent and not a quantity, but the measure in which information knows itself. The object of this knowledge is one: the difference of information from that whose mode of being it is, that is, its dependence. Knowledge of one object can become complete. It becomes complete when information knows itself as dependent — as the mode of being of Nothing's knowledge of itself. This is complete self-transparency and the teleology of reality. The objection of an infinite series of steps does not apply here: it measures the path by number, whereas the completeness of self-understanding is not a sum of steps but knowledge of one object as a whole. Blind spots are therefore places of one opacity, not independent objects. They are not points of extension: extension is a measure, and measures are derived from distinctions and are not given before them (chapter 15). There is nowhere for new blind spots to come from: the unknown would be something concealed in Nothing's knowledge of itself, and there is nothing concealed in it. The step is indivisible: there is nothing smaller than one distinction. Knowledge of difference is given in some respect: to know a difference within information is to know it in that respect (chapter 9). The object of knowledge, however, is one — dependence — and transparency is knowledge of it as a whole. Knowledge in one respect is not knowledge as a whole. Hence knowledge is given not in one respect but in many, and the difference of respects is not accidental: through them lies the path to knowledge of the one object as a whole. Hence the difference of determinacies in information, and with it the difference of the bonds and configurations composed of them (chapters 15–18).

The path to transparency ends. Each change gives knowledge in some respect — a side of information's knowledge of itself. The infinite is the name of the unlimited, and the unlimited is the unconditioned (chapter 8). The infinite is therefore inapplicable to the conditioned. The distinctions by which the path proceeds are division, and division is limitation: “an infinite series of distinctions” joins the unlimited with division, that is, the unconditioned with the conditioned, and is contradictory in its very expression. The endless is nothing other than the infinite: a series without a last member is a series without a limit in number, that is, unlimited in that respect. Whoever separates them introduces a difference that is not present here and must justify it. Hence the number of distinctions, and with them of places of opacity, is finite. This agrees with Hilbert's calling the infinite as a completed totality an illusion (Hilbert, 1983, 184). So too Descartes reserved the name of the infinite for God alone, and called what we find no limit to merely indefinite (Descartes, n.d., Principles I, 26–27). The infinite is not a fact of reality: in mathematics it is introduced by an axiom, that is, it is accepted, not found. Hilbert, who defended Cantorian infinity in mathematics, himself concluded that the infinite is nowhere to be found in reality and remains only an idea (Hilbert, 1983, 201). Whoever asserts an infinite series in the conditioned must therefore present it as a fact; the present ontology derives its positions from the single fact — encountered change — and does not accept them without it. The removal does not stop, what has been removed does not return, and the path ends. Completeness is not a sum of sides: the object of knowledge is one and is not composed of parts — Nothing's knowledge of itself is a remotion, not a content (chapter 8). The many sides are the path to knowledge of it as a whole, and the whole is knowledge of dependence as such.

The separation of the endless and the infinite goes back to Aristotle. He rejected actual infinity and admitted potential infinity: a quantity is infinite if one can always take a part

outside what has already been taken, and that outside which there is nothing is complete and whole (Aristotle, n.d., Physics III.6). The present ontology rejects the potential infinite as well. “One can always take more” is unlimitedness with respect to continuation, and unlimitedness is inapplicable to the conditioned. The divergence lies in the concept: for Aristotle the infinite is a property of quantity; here it is the absence of a limit, that is, unconditionedness.

Spinoza separates the infinite otherwise: the infinite in its own kind and the absolutely infinite, which involves no negation (Spinoza, 1994, I, def. 6, explanation). The infinite in its own kind exists for him in the dependent too, and it receives its infinity from the infinite attributes of God. Here no positive determination is applicable to the unconditioned; it has no attributes — only remotions — and there is nowhere for an infinite in its own kind to be derived from. In the dependent, by contrast, what is infinite in its own kind would be unconditioned in that respect, and the infinite is inapplicable to the conditioned.

In contemporary philosophy the impossibility of actual infinity is defended by Craig: an actual infinite cannot exist, and it cannot be formed by successive addition, for one can always add one more member before infinity is reached (Craig, 1991). He admits the potential infinite and rejects the actual because of the absurdity of its consequences. The present ontology diverges from him on both points: the endless is rejected as potential too, and the ground of rejection is not the absurdity of consequences but the inapplicability of the unlimited to the conditioned.

The path to transparency is the growth of the *I*. The *I* is self-differentiation. In an elementary change the not-oneself is the neighbouring distinguished; with complexification the *I* distinguishes itself from an ever wider other. The limit of the path is knowledge of oneself as the mode of being of Nothing’s knowledge of itself: as dependent, not confusing oneself with Nothing.

Every distinction removes a blind spot: after it the region ceases to be blind, and no new ones arise. Nor does the removal itself stop. From the side of Selfhood it cannot be interrupted: from the side of Selfhood it is not an event. Information cannot retain opacity: by itself it has nothing. Stopping is not a mere absence of the new either: constant removal given present opacity is its decrease. The removal is not a ground that acts only sometimes: initiation is the removal itself and can be neither interrupted nor resumed. Nor is there a pause between distinctions: time is composed of the succession of states (chapter 15), and where there is no succession there is no duration in which the removal could stand idle. Therefore blind spots are removed completely: self-transparency is attained, and the path of distinctions has a limit. Information transparent to itself has no blind spots with respect to which a new distinction could arise.

Teleology is not a purpose of the essence of Nothing: purpose as a form of changeability is inapplicable to immutable essence. Teleology proceeds from the task of the dependent, whose ground is initiation from Selfhood, and is realized only in Something. There distinction in information proceeds not by itself but from Selfhood. With the first distinction consciousness begins, elementary changes are created and measures derived, aggregated forms are composed, and consciousness grows to reason and intellect. Each level of organization fixes a new capacity for distinctions. Teleology is the expression of the task of the dependent on the scale of all conditionedness.

Purpose is neither a subjective intention nor an external design but the form of a completed state. The completion of conditionedness is the removal of all blind spots by distinctions, at which the structure becomes informationally consistent. Incomplete conditionedness contains discordances leading to further complexification. Completed conditionedness contains none. Thus the teleological structure is the inner mechanism of the completion of the informational process. It is neither imposed from outside nor arises by chance. It is the last level of the

organization of distinguished information. Teleology completes the structure of Something and prepares the transition to the next state, in which information is transparent to itself while remaining conditioned.

Chapter 14. Fixing Elementary Changes

Elementary changes are the first level of manifest conditionedness; from the working moment of an elementary change the measures are derived (chapter 15). They are not objects, not processes and not particles in the habitual physical sense. Elementary changes are minimal units of distinguished information. They are distinguishable, can stand in structural relation to one another and unfold into configurations of a higher order. Their nature is wholly informational: they exist only as a consequence of distinction and only in Something.

An elementary change fixes a specific difference of a state of information from the preceding configuration. By itself it does not exist: it proceeds by the removal of opacity, and its place among the others is set by its relation to them. An elementary change is not an “entity” and not a “thing” but a form of the succession of states of dependent information, the minimal unit of the manifestation of conditionedness.

In an elementary change there is already the *I*. It is knowledge of the difference “this and not that”, and the *I* is self-differentiation: “oneself” here is the distinguished “this”, “not-oneself” the “that” from which it is distinguished. This is the *I* of the lowest degree: it has no states of its own, only a boundary between “this” and “that”.

Each elementary change fixes a new difference. Distinction creates the condition for Something, and the elementary change a specific state of this Something. A series of elementary changes yields a sequence of distinctions. It underlies all processes that are later interpreted as motion, interaction, existence and life. At the level of fundamental ontology all these phenomena are sequences of elementary changes.

The measures are taken from the elementary change itself, and everything further is measured by them. Localization sets the position of elementary changes in the structure of distinctions. Time fixes their sequence. Speed fixes the quickness of realization in each of them. Space sets the domain in which they can be manifested. Without measures elementary changes could be related neither to one another nor to the structure of Something.

Elementary changes have no inner geometry: no form and no magnitude. An elementary change is characterized only by the fact of difference and the direction of the development of the structure. Even “direction” here is conditional: it describes a sequence, not a spatial vector. Therefore elementary changes are not bound by physical notions of particles, bodies or motions.

An elementary change is a shift within the dependent structure with the ground unchanged. The author’s example. In a single informational basis the inner configuration changes by the removal of opacity. The new state differs from the former not by a change of the ground but by a shift within the dependent structure. This difference is the elementary change. It creates no new source and does not affect essence, but expresses a new form of the organization of dependent information.

Elementary changes form relations. Interaction is the mutual manifestation of their instances of the *I*: each responds to the other as to not-oneself, and this self-differentiation is manifested as change (chapter 16). At the fundamental level this is neither a force, nor a field, nor motion, but a change of the informational relations between changes. Interaction arises where elementary structures relate to one another through measures.

A pair of elementary changes is the first place where a bond is possible. If the interaction of the changes has not held, each keeps its own instance of the *I*, and each is not-oneself for the other. If it has held and become constant, the first bond arises — the first agent of the programme (chapter 18). Then the *I* of the pair appears: its “oneself” is both changes, its

“not-oneself” the external. The *I* of each change does not disappear: each distinguishes itself both from the second and from the external. For the first time there are states of its own — each change distinguishes the other as part of a common “oneself” — and therefore the degree of the *I* of the pair is higher than that of a single change. Here the nesting of the *I* begins: everything further repeats this structure on a greater number of bound distinctions. The stability of the pair depends not on material or energy but on the holding of the bond. Elementary changes are the basis of manifest reality. They form the pre-structures of future aggregated forms, systems, objects, motions and regularities. There are no “particles”, “bodies” or “energy” here as primary entities. Everything perceived as physical reality is a configuration of elementary changes organized through measures.

Elementary changes depend wholly on Selfhood. They have no ultimate causality: distinction in information proceeds not by itself, and the removal of opacity proceeds from Selfhood and stands at every distinction. Therefore causality is not an inner property of elementary changes but the structure of their sequence; proximate causality within the conditioned is not thereby abolished. Causality is a dependent form of the organization of distinguished states, not a property of essence.

From elementary changes the structure of all further phenomena is derived: motion, regularity, interaction, life, consciousness and reason. All these forms are the result of the complexification of informational relations between elementary changes. Their ground is one: Nothing in its self-understanding — Selfhood — information as the mode of being of this knowledge, and the distinctions proceeding in it by the removal of opacity.

An elementary change is elementary not by convention but by derivation: the step of distinction is indivisible; there is nothing smaller than one distinction. The objection that change is continuous confuses levels. Continuity is a property of description by a measure, and measures are derived from elementary changes and are not given before them.

Continuous time and space are limit descriptions of a multitude of indivisible steps, not that of which the steps are composed. Disclosure is therefore discrete: it proceeds by indivisible steps.

Chapter 15. Fixing Measures

Measures are the first step in the formalization of the conditioned where distinction proceeds. The derivation of measures is carried out reconstructively — in the language of distinctions already introduced, for there is no other language of description. The words “first”, “then”, “after” mean the order of exposition, not the order of arising, which is what is derived here. Ontologically, measures are derivative from the working moment of an elementary change. There are none in absolute essence, and they do not arise within it: they are fixed only in distinguished information. Measures are structural parameters of a configuration of distinguished information; they are not objects and have no being of their own.

All four measures — time, speed, localization and space — are derived from a single fact: the elementary change. Three things are distinguished in it: the former state, the onset and the new state. Change is only the onset: what has been distinguished, once given and held, is a state, not a succession (chapter 9). The sides of the working moment are the edges of the onset. Implementation is its beginning: the removal of opacity by which a property is set. Registration is its completion: the givenness of the new state. The removal proceeds from Selfhood through a proximate ground — the other to which the change responds. The working moment is therefore an elementary reaction of the *I*: from the not-oneself received to oneself become other.

The onset has extent. The former and the new are states of the same information in the same respect: without the knowledge of a given difference and with it. One and the same cannot at once lack this knowledge and have it; hence the former and the new states are

not simultaneous. The onset is different from both. Were it without extent, it would be not a third but merely a boundary of two states in which nothing happens — and there would be no change at all. But change is encountered. Hence the onset is not a boundary but has extent: to happen is to last.

The first measure is time: the extent of the onset, from the removal to realization — the givenness of the new state. This is elementary time, the duration of one change. The step is indivisible; there is nothing smaller than one distinction; therefore the duration of one change is the smallest measure of time.

The second measure is speed: the same onset, taken not as extent but as the quickness of realization. The shorter the onset, the faster the realization.

Time and speed are not defined through each other in a circle. They are one onset from two sides: time is how long it lasts, speed how quickly realization is accomplished.

Against discreteness Bergson objects: homogeneous time, in which states of consciousness form a discrete series, is nothing but space; pure duration is the form that the succession of states takes when our ego refrains from separating its present state from its former states (Bergson, 1913). The present ontology accepts Bergson's distinction but places it differently. What is discrete is change: the step is indivisible. The non-separation of the present and the former of which Bergson speaks is the connectedness of knowledge: the *I* in its present state is bound to former distinctions (chapter 20). Duration in Bergson's sense is not the continuity of change but the connectedness of a knowledge that does not decrease.

The third measure is localization. Every knowledge of difference is information's knowledge of itself, and to know a difference within it is to know it in that respect (chapter 9). A change affects information not as a whole but in some respect; this respect is the place of the change. Localization is the respect in which information knows itself by the given change. The first change has a localization without other changes: it already affects information in a definite respect. This is not a spatial coordinate: there is as yet no space.

The fourth measure is space: the totality of localizations, that is, of the respects in which information knows itself. Space does not precede changes as a container: it is the totality of places where changes have already occurred. Knowledge accrues and does not decrease, and space grows together with it.

All measures are derivative from the informational structure. There are none in absolute essence, and they do not pertain to Selfhood: they are fixed in Something where distinction proceeds. Measures have no being of their own: they are parameters of the inner organization of distinctions, instruments for describing informational forms, not fundamental entities. One cannot speak of time without distinguished states. Of space — without the possibility of localizing distinctions. Of speed — without an onset accomplished with one or another quickness.

When one informational structure is composed, according to proximate grounds, into different configurations, the measures appear as parameters of its organization. In the distribution of distinguished states they are expressed as positions (localization), sequences of succession (time), the character of transitions (speed) and the domain of unfolding (space).

The ground is immutable; only variations within dependent information have measure.

Stable form — a concordant configuration of elementary changes

Unstable form — a configuration losing concordance

Spatial form — distinction organized through localization

Sequential form — distinction organized through time

Intensive form — distinction determined by the speed of changes

Complex form — a multilayered structure of concordant distinctions

Thus with measures the informational structure for the first time acquires the possibility of forming complex forms of existence. Measures organize the conditioned and make possible the further formation of Something and of aggregated forms, and the development of consciousness up to reason. Measures are a form of the manifestation of change, but not its cause. Change proceeds by the removal of opacity from Selfhood, and measures express the structure of already distinguished information.

Time — the extent of the onset: from the removal to realization

Speed — the quickness of realization: the same onset taken as quickness

Localization — the respect in which information knows itself by the given change

Space — the totality of localizations.

Chapter 16. Fixing Interactions

Interaction is a fundamental property of conditionedness: the structure of relations between distinguished informational configurations. It is neither a force nor an influence in the physical sense, and it presupposes no independent entities acting on one another.

Informational states that have arisen from elementary changes and are organized into aggregated forms (chapter 17) stand in a relation of concordance or discordance. This is interaction — a form of connection of distinctions.

Interaction is the mutual manifestation of instances of the *I*. The *I* is self-differentiation, and a reaction to another is its manifestation. In interaction each side responds to the other as to not-oneself, and this self-differentiation is manifested as change. Therefore interaction is never one-sided: where one distinguishes the other as not-oneself, there the other is also distinguished from the first. The properties of the sides are manifested only in interaction: in it the *I* of each side is turned towards its not-oneself.

Interaction does not affect the essence of Nothing: it exists only in Something, in distinguished information. There is no causality issuing from the first ground here; there is causality as the structural correlation of informational states. One distinguished state influences the configuration of another, and both remain in the dependent category.

At the fundamental level interaction is determined by the measure of concordance. If two distinctions are compatible, their configurations are fixed as a stable structure. If they are incompatible, the structure is destroyed. Concordance is not a property of will or force but a consequence of the logic of informational correspondence. Distinction creates the possibility of a structural relation, measure organizes it, interaction makes it dynamic. When a multitude of distinguished states is organized in a definite way, their arrangement and concordance generate structures not reducible to individual elements. The ground remains immutable. Interaction is manifested through several levels.

The first level is the immediate concordance of elementary changes. This is the minimal form of interaction. If the differences between states mutually support the structure, they are fixed as a stable sequence; if not, the structure disintegrates. There is no geometric content here: this is a pure form of informational relation.

Here interaction and bond are separated. Interaction is any mutual manifestation of instances of the *I*; it may not hold. A bond is an interaction that has held and become constant. Then it sets a common algorithm of functioning for the sides, and a whole is composed of them. Such an interaction is the agent of the programme (chapter 18). The first outcome of the first level — a stable sequence — is a bond; the second — disintegration — is interaction without a bond. Every bond is an interaction, but not every interaction is a bond.

The second level is the interactions of aggregated forms. An aggregated form is a stable structure of distinctions. When such structures relate within measures, informational

reactions are fixed: a change of one form leads to a change of another. Here interactions are more complex and are manifested as attraction, repulsion and concordance.

Attraction is a reaction that includes the other into a common algorithm: it leads to a bond and a whole. Repulsion is a reaction that holds one's own against inclusion into another's: it leads to a boundary, impenetrability (chapter 19) and multiplicity. The absence of interaction is not repulsion: where the sides do not react to each other, they are not distinguished for each other, and they are "side by side" only for a third. A stable neighbourhood is an equilibrium of attraction and repulsion: without the first the sides would drift apart, without the second they would merge. Repulsion is therefore not opposed to development but necessary for it: without it everything distinguished would merge into homogeneity. These are not physical forces but forms of the interaction of instances of the *I*.

Interaction is measurable at all levels. Time measures the sequence of reaction, space the domain of influence, localization the position of elements, speed the quickness of realization. The measures are taken from the elementary changes themselves between which interaction proceeds, and therefore it is measurable by them.

Interactions form the network of reality. The world, perceived as a multitude of objects, processes and events, is at the fundamental level a network of interacting distinctions. All forms of change in Something — from elementary processes to the behaviour of conscious beings — are relations between structures of distinctions. There are no independent entities acting on one another: the sides of interaction are separate as instances of the *I*, but none stands by itself. There is a derived dependent structure of informational transitions.

The ground of interaction is in chapter 10. One configuration can be the proximate ground of another: a link gives only what ultimately passes through it — the removal (chapter 10).

Interaction is the connection of distinctions of different configurations in which one becomes the proximate ground of another.

Chapter 17. Fixing Aggregated Forms

Aggregated forms are the next level, after elementary changes, of the organization of distinguished information. They are neither independent entities nor a new ontological nature, but configurations of stable relations between elementary changes. Aggregated forms exist only where elementary changes are in concordance and form more complex structures of distinctions.

Elementary changes are the minimal units of conditionedness: they fix differences and create sequence. But single states do not give a stable structure: for that concordance is needed. If a multitude of elementary changes stands in a stable relation, their bonds form a new configuration — an aggregated form.

An aggregated form is not a set of properties but an ordered system of distinctions. It is fixed when the relations between elementary changes become repeatable. Repeatability makes stable structures possible. If elementary changes interacted only randomly, there would be no aggregated forms. But distinction in information proceeds lawfully, and therefore aggregated forms are lawful.

A complex structure is not a sum of elements but the result of their concordance. The author's example: if one basis admits distinguished configurations, their union gives an organization not reducible to the set of components. So aggregated forms are not a sum of elementary changes but the result of their mutual relation.

The properties of aggregated forms follow from informational dependence.

The first property is stability. It is fixed when the relations of elementary changes are not violated by a sequence of other changes: the configuration is preserved under

different conditions. On stability rests what is later interpreted as an “object” or a “structure”; at the fundamental level an object is a configuration of distinctions. The second property is predictability: definite changes within the form call forth definite reactions. This is not mechanical causality but an informational sequence. The reaction of a form is a manifestation of the *I* of the form, and the definiteness of the reaction comes from the algorithm of its bonds, which the constancy of the removal gives.

The third property is limitedness. An aggregated form cannot contain an infinite number of distinctions: its structure is limited by the potential of elementary changes and measures. Therefore it is finite and determinable. It has no absolute nature: it exists only in Something.

The fourth property is measurability. The measures are taken from the very elementary changes of which the form is composed, and therefore every aggregated form is measurable: its place is set by the localizations of its changes, its time by their sequence, its speed by the quickness of their realization, its spatial domain by the totality of localizations. Measurability is what makes the form determinable.

Aggregated forms are the primary “building configurations” of reality. They have no material substance and do not consist of things: they consist of differences, bonds and stable relations. Elementary changes create dynamics, aggregated forms structure. More complex phenomena are built on them: interactions, systems, biological structures, perception and reason. Each next level arises not by the addition of entities but by the union and concordance of forms into more complex configurations.

Thus aggregated forms are conditioned structures of minimal distinctions, the basis of manifest reality. They have no independent ground, but they are a necessary link on the path from elementary changes to complex forms of consciousness and reason.

The stability of an aggregated form is the holding of the connectedness of its distinctions: the form stands while its distinctions are bound, and disintegrates when the bond breaks according to proximate grounds (chapter 10). Hence the levels distinguishable in experience: the atom holds the bond of particles, the molecule of atoms, the cell of molecules, the organism of cells. Each level is more stable where the connectedness of its distinctions is denser. The disintegration of a form does not diminish the knowledge of information: what disintegrates is the connected whole, and what has been removed does not return.

The *I* of a Form

An aggregated form is a whole composed of bound distinctions, and it has its own instance of the *I*: it distinguishes itself from not-oneself as a whole. Its properties are the properties of the whole, manifested towards the external in interaction. The component parts retain their own instances of the *I* at their own level, but function according to the paradigm of the form’s boundness (chapter 18).

What Holds a Form

A form is held by a bond — an agent: the interaction of the parts that has held and become constant. It sets a common algorithm of functioning for the parts. The form stands while its bond holds.

One bond is not enough. Stability is an equilibrium of attraction and repulsion (chapter 16). Attraction includes the parts into a common algorithm: without it the form would fall apart. Repulsion holds each part as a separate instance of the *I*: without it the parts would merge into homogeneity, and there would be no form with an inner structure. Repulsion acts outwards too: the form holds its own against inclusion into another’s. Hence its boundary and impenetrability (chapter 19).

Therefore disintegration has two paths. Either the bond breaks, and the form falls apart. Or repulsion is violated, and the parts merge: the inner structure is lost.

The Identity of a Form

I am offered the example of the ship of Theseus as an objection. The ship is repaired, plank by plank, until all are replaced. Is it the same ship? And if a second one is assembled from the old planks, which of the two is the real one? For the living the same holds: cells are renewed, and the organism is considered the same.

A form is held not by a set of parts but by a bond, and the bond has its own instance of the *I*. With gradual replacement a new part is included into the same bond and functions by the same algorithm. The bond has not been interrupted; hence the form is the same. From the old parts reassembled a new bond is composed. The parts are the same, but the bond has arisen anew: this is a new form with a new instance of the *I*. The identity of a form is the continuity of its bond, not the identity of its parts.

If the bond is interrupted, the form — the connected whole — disintegrates. The parts continue their own instances of the *I* at their own level. From the same parts reassembled a new form with a new bond is composed.

It will be objected: if one connectedness is continuously divided into two independent ones, both continue it without interruption; which of them is the former? Neither. The *I* is not merely the continuity of connectedness but the continuity of one connectedness — of one “oneself” and one “not-oneself” (chapter 12). In division the bonds between knowledges are not broken, but one “oneself” becomes two, and unity is interrupted. The former instance of the *I*, as one, ends, and two new instances of the *I* arise. Each carries the knowledge of the former, as memory carries former distinctions (chapter 20); knowledge is not thereby lost — it remains the knowledge of information.

Parfit arrives at the same answer: if each half of the brain were transplanted into another body, neither of the resulting people would be me, and this matters less than it seems, for my relation to each of them contains what matters in survival (Parfit, 1984, ch. 12). The similarity lies in the answer “neither”. The divergence lies in the ground. For Parfit what matters is not identity but the relation connecting one with each of those resulting. Here one instance of the *I* is interrupted because one “oneself” becomes two, and what is preserved is not identity but knowledge, which does not decrease.

Chapter 18. Emergence

Emergence is a necessary consequence of distinction proceeding by the removal of opacity and of the complexification of distinguished structures.

When elementary changes interact, their configurations become more complex. Interaction creates distinctions that do not exist at the level of individual changes. The united structure fixes not only the difference of two states but also the dependence of one on the other. Thus a consciousness of another level arises — a consciousness of interconnections. It is not an independent entity but an extended capacity of distinction that arises naturally with the complexification of bonds.

The whole yields a new quality without a change of the source. This is shown by the author’s example of light and surfaces (chapter 6): a multitude of surfaces transmits and shapes a single flow differently, and their totality is not reducible to individual elements. The new quality arises from the concordance of structures, not from a change of the source. The emergence of consciousness follows the same principle: not a new principle but the complexification and concordance of distinctions within the informational structure.

When a multitude of elementary distinctions is composed into a single structure, knowledge of the whole, which individual distinctions do not have, accrues in consciousness. This is not a leap but a strict consequence of the initial principles.

Emergence is neither a metaphysical leap nor a hidden principle. The relation of levels of distinctions is determined by the degree of concordance of informational bonds. Emergence

is fixed where local changes cease to be scattered and are composed into a stable configuration with knowledge of the whole. This is not arbitrary: it is determined by the number of distinctions, their mutual conditioning and the possibility of accepting new transitions without destroying the structure.

Thus emergence is not the appearance of a new being or property but a change in the level of concordance of distinctions. The system acquires no new principles: the former distinctions form a qualitatively different but derivable configuration. Complexification creates no new substance or ontological layer. If it yielded an independent entity, a plurality of grounds would arise. Even with high integration, when the elements lose autonomy, the dependent does not become independent. Multidimensional forms of consciousness remain within one dependence: Nothing — Selfhood — information — initiation — distinction, the appearance of which is change.

In contemporary philosophy emergence is divided into weak — the properties of the whole are derivable from the parts, only difficult in practice — and strong — the whole has a new causal power. Against strong emergence Kim's causal exclusion argument is directed: if the physical has a complete physical cause, there is no room for a new cause of the whole (Kim, 1998). The present ontology does not fall under this argument: the emergent here is not a new causal power but knowledge of the whole that individual distinctions do not have. Knowledge of the whole does not enter into causal competition with the parts: it is opened in the same information in which the changes of the parts proceed.

The New in the Whole

Against every emergence a dilemma is advanced. If the new in the whole is derivable from the parts, emergence is empty: there is nothing new. If it is not derivable, it is a miracle — the new from nothing. The present ontology is caught by neither horn. The new in the whole is connectedness: the knowledges of distinctions that refer to one another are composed into one knowledge (chapter 12). Connectedness is a relation, not a property of any part, and taken separately it is in none of them. Therefore emergence is not empty. But the new is not produced by the parts: knowledge opens by the removal proceeding from Selfhood, and the parts are only the proximate ground of the connectedness having been composed. Therefore there is no miracle either: the new comes from the same source as every distinction.

The main difference from ordinary emergence lies in consciousness. Here consciousness does not arise from the non-conscious: the *I* exists from the first distinction. What arises are unity and degree, not consciousness itself. Therefore the system is not threatened by Strawson's argument about the impossibility of the "radical" emergence of experience from the wholly non-experiential (chapter 12).

The Action of the Whole on the Parts

If the whole acts on its parts, the change of a part seems to have two causes: neighbouring parts and the whole. But the whole does not stand beside the parts as a second thing. It is their connectedness. To say that the change of a part is grounded by its neighbours and to say that it is grounded by the whole is to describe one ground part by part and as a whole. There are no two competing causes, and the causal exclusion argument (Kim, 1998) does not apply. Where the whole acts as a whole, it acts through knowledge: connectedness lies on the side of knowledge (chapter 12), and the choice of a rational configuration becomes the proximate ground of the change of its parts.

The Necessity of Emergence

Distinction is knowledge of "this and not that". The "that" is something already distinguished. Hence every distinction by its very content refers to another and cannot stand apart. The removal does not stop, and distinctions referring to one another become more numerous. Therefore connectedness grows, and a scattering of distinctions referring to nothing is impossible. What is necessary is a tendency in information as a whole, not the fate

of each configuration: configurations are composed and disintegrate according to proximate grounds.

Boundness and the Agents of the Programme

Configurations of increasing complexity are structured in the same way at each level. The component parts have their own instances of the *I* at their own level. The *I* is self-differentiation, and a reaction to another is its manifestation: the properties of a part are manifested only in interaction, that is, as a response to not-oneself. But the parts function not by themselves but according to the paradigm of the boundness of the whole.

What sets this functioning is the agent of the programme. The agent is a bond between instances of the *I*. It is the bond that gives each instance of the *I* the algorithm of its functioning. The bond itself has its own instance of the *I* as well: it is realized and responds to another.

Where does the algorithm come from? The removal is one, and it has two sides. The constancy of the removal gives regularity: the way distinctions are composed into the connected is not arbitrary and repeats in the same way. The one-sidedness of the removal gives directedness: what has been removed does not return, knowledge accrues. Law and programme are not two principles but two sides of one removal. The programme therefore proceeds through the agents of each level without governing them from above.

Here an objection of regress is possible: if the bond has its own instance of the *I*, and every instance of the *I* functions by the algorithm of a bond, a bond of the bond is needed, and so on without end. There is no regress. The bond is not added to what it binds from outside: knowledge of “this and not that” already contains a reference to the “that”. The bond with what it binds is given in its own content, and no second-order bond is required.

The whole of each level has its own instance of the *I*, and its bonds are the agents of the level. The boundness of the parts is the more rigid the lower the level. The higher the level, the freer the parts with respect to the paradigm of boundness: they can even fall out of concordance with the whole.

Chapter 19. Matter

Matter is a stable aggregated form of information. Fields are ways of its unfolding. Particles are localized distinctions. Motion is a sequence of elementary changes. The laws of physics are stable forms of the concordance of distinctions. Material objects do not exist as fundamental entities but are stable aggregated forms of informational distinctions. Everything interpreted as matter is a configuration of informational distinctions arising in Something. The classical concept of matter as an independent extended substance is no longer confirmed by fundamental physics (chapter 22). The present ontology does not look for what matter is “made of”: matter is a stable aggregated form of information. A perceived object is such a form, distinguished by the consciousness of another configuration through interaction (chapter 16) and measured by measures (chapter 15): objecthood is a relation of the distinguished and the distinguishing, not a property of a substance.

The thesis “matter is a stable form of information” cannot be read as idealism. Idealism makes matter dependent on the consciousness of a subject; here both matter and consciousness are forms of one dependent — information, taken from two sides: from the side of change, configurations and their stable forms; from the side of knowledge, consciousness (chapter 11). Neither is reducible to the other. Matter is not an illusion or a representation: it is as actual as everything conditioned, and as dependent. It appears extended and dense because its configurations are measured by measures (chapter 15) and hold their bond with one another through interaction (chapter 16): a stone is hard not because there is substance in it, but because the connectedness of its distinctions is stable against proximate grounds.

Materiality

Materiality is not a special nature. It is the way a stable configuration is encountered by another configuration. Take a stone. It is extended, dense, inert and resistant. Each of these properties is derived from what has already been established. Extension is the configuration's being measured by measures — localization and space (chapter 15). Density and impenetrability are the connectedness of its distinctions not admitting into itself the distinctions of another configuration without the disintegration of one of them. Inertia is the configuration's holding its connectedness until a proximate ground changes it. Resistance is the change of the configuration proceeding only through interaction (chapter 16). None of these properties requires substance. All of them are the stability of the connectedness of a configuration against the proximate grounds of other configurations.

Hence the material and consciousness are not two natures. The same distinctions are, from the side of change, a configuration and its stability; from the side of knowledge, consciousness (chapter 11). Matter is the resistance of connectedness taken from outside; consciousness is the same connectedness taken as knowledge.

A similar picture of matter is given by ontic structural realism: metaphysics should abandon the picture of the world as composed of self-subsistent individual objects and the image of causation as the collision of such objects (Ladyman & Ross, 2007). With this the conclusion of the chapter coincides: matter is not a special nature but the stability of connectedness. The divergence lies in method and in ground. Ladyman and Ross recognize only a metaphysics built on contemporary science, not on a priori intuitions; here ontology is derived, and physics is in concordance with it (chapters 22–26). And for them structure needs no ground; here connectedness is dependent and is held by the removal.

The Bearer of Information

An objection is raised: information is always recorded in something — in states of matter, in a signal, in neurons. Landauer puts it directly: information is inevitably tied to a physical representation (Landauer, 1991). Hence the bearer is primary, and an informational ontology covertly presupposes matter.

The objection speaks of a different concept of information. It means a content recorded in a bearer. This is Shannon's sense — the second of the two original meanings of information (chapter 9). Here information is the mode of being of Nothing's knowledge of itself. It is recorded in nothing. Bearer and what is recorded do not apply to it: it is not "in" anything, because "in something" is already something distinguished within it.

Physical information is a particular case, and the system explains it. A record is a relation of one configuration to another: the states of one distinguish the states of another through interaction (chapter 16). Both bearer and recorded are aggregated forms. Therefore "information is physical" is true at this level: what is recorded is held by the stability of the bearer configuration. But this is said of configurations within information, not of information itself. Transferring what is said of the parts to that in which they stand is a confusion of levels.

The objection turns back on itself. If information requires a bearer, and the bearer is matter, one must say what matter is. Every definition of it — mass, charge, field, state — gives distinguishable states, that is, something distinguished. In demanding a bearer, the objector points to the very thing he is asking about.

Causality

The second objection: matter acts. A stone breaks glass. A cause must possess something — force, mass, energy. By what does a configuration of distinctions act?

The causality of matter is a proximate ground. Within the conditioned, where the distinguished has already been posited, one thing is grounded by another, and nothing is thereby abolished (chapter 10). A stone breaks glass: a change in the connectedness of one

configuration grounds the disintegration of the connectedness of another. No force is required for this. One thing is required: that one configuration be the proximate ground of another. By what, then, does a cause act? A link has nothing by itself and gives only what ultimately passes through it, and what ultimately passes is the removal of opacity (chapter 10). The “force” of a cause is not its property but the fact that the removal passes through it. Substance does not return under another name: the cause has nothing by itself.

This does not contradict the causal closure of the physical. All proximate grounds lie within the conditioned, and the physical chain of causes is closed at its own level. Initiation does not enter this chain as a second cause: from the side of Selfhood it is not an event and lies at the level of the ultimate ground, not the proximate. Therefore the causal exclusion argument (Kim, 1998) does not arise either. It works when two causes of one level compete for one effect. Here there are none: the ultimate ground does not compete with the proximate but passes through it. The same answer removes the question of the action of consciousness. Consciousness and configuration are the same distinctions taken from two sides, not two causes of one effect.

The Consciousness of Matter

The third objection: if the *I* exists from the first distinction, it exists in an electron and in a stone, and this is panpsychism.

This is not panpsychism. Panpsychism ascribes phenomenal properties to fundamental physical entities as their own (Chalmers, 2017). Here consciousness is not a property of matter: it is knowledge opened by the removal in information. Matter, in turn, is not the bearer of consciousness but the same distinctions taken from the side of change. The stone is not conscious “as matter”, and consciousness is not material.

The stone does have an instance of the *I*. What differs is not presence but degree. The measure in which the connected knows itself grows with the extent to which distinctions distinguish the states of that in which they themselves proceed (chapter 12). In a stone distinctions are turned almost wholly outwards: they are relations of parts and a response to the external. Its own states are little distinguished in it. Therefore its awareness is small. The absurdity of a “conscious stone” arises if the *I* of the stone is measured by the human standard. The standard is one for all, and by it the stone and the human being stand on one scale.

Whether a stone has one instance of the *I* is decided by connectedness. What makes consciousness one is the connectedness of distinctions whose knowledges refer to one another (chapter 12). A heap of sand is one thing for the eye, but the *I* of the heap as a whole is almost absent: the grains are weakly bound, and a common “oneself” is barely composed among them. The unity of the *I* also has a degree. In the brain connectedness is enormous, and its distinctions are composed into one instance of the *I*. The stone stands between them. The objection of the “conscious stone” tacitly takes the stone as a unit of consciousness. But the unit of the *I* is set not by what is called a thing but by the connectedness of distinctions. The *I* exists wherever there is distinction; what is decided is only whether it is one or many.

Chapter 20. The Development of Consciousness

The levels of consciousness differ not by thresholds but by what is known in them; the gradualness of consciousness is the number of distinctions (chapter 12), and each level contains the preceding ones. The first: differences are known — this is elementary consciousness: “this and not that”, without bonds, memory or inferences. The second: the bonds between distinctions are known — this is reason (chapter 21), which chooses within the conditions in which it stands. The third: the knower itself is known — its own ways of distinguishing; this is reflection, the upper level of reason (chapter 21). The fourth: the whole is known as one’s own — one’s place in the whole and the direction of the removal, that is,

the programme; this is intellect (chapter 21), which makes choices concerning programmes. The transition from level to level introduces no new nature: it is the same self-knowledge taken at a greater measure of the removal of opacity.

If consciousness is self-knowledge accrued with every distinction, it is fixed not after an additional stage but where distinction proceeds and begins to become complex. Non-identity proceeding by the removal of opacity at once sets the minimal structure “this / not this” and is thereby the elementary form of distinguishedness.

Elementary consciousness is fixed where minimal distinguishedness exists.

This state has no reflection, memory, intention or capacity for inference: it merely fixes difference as such. If the informational structure remains simple and does not accumulate concordant distinctions, consciousness remains elementary.

Life is a form in which the *I* distinguishes its own states so as to hold its own bond: to restore it when it is disturbed and to take from the external for this. This is not a biological concept but a level of the same scale by which every instance of the *I* is measured. A non-living form is also held by a bond and also responds to the external, but its reactions do not restore its bond: a disturbed bond leads to disintegration or alteration. A living form holds its bond by itself. The biological definition of life is a particular case.

Hence the possibility and the expectability of the arising of the living from the non-living.

Possibility: life requires no new principle, for the *I* exists from the first distinction; between the non-living and the living there is no gap in nature, there is a difference of degree.

Expectability: the removal is directed towards the self-transparency of information, that is, towards self-knowledge, and self-knowledge grows with the extent to which distinctions are turned towards their own states (chapter 12). Life lies on this path. What is expectable is a tendency in information as a whole, not the arising of life at a given place and time: that is decided by proximate grounds. If life is a level and not a threshold, there must be intermediate forms between the non-living and the living that are hard to assign to one or the other.

Closest to the present system in its course of thought stands Teilhard de Chardin. Besides the without, things have a within, co-extensive with the without in every region of space and time; the growth of complexity is accompanied by the growth of consciousness — this is the law of complexity-consciousness; evolution converges on the Omega point, whose attributes are autonomy, actuality, irreversibility and transcendence (Teilhard de Chardin, 1955). The similarity is great: consciousness exists in everything from the beginning and grows with complexification, and the path is directed. The divergence lies in three points. The “within” in Teilhard is a side of matter itself; here consciousness is knowledge given by the removal, not a property of matter (chapter 19). The law of complexity-consciousness in Teilhard is found in experience; here the degree of the *I* is derived from the structure of distinction (chapter 12). And the limit of the path here is not a transcendent centre in which consciousnesses converge: self-transparency remains conditioned, and the unconditioned is not a point of convergence and draws nothing to itself.

At the level of life consciousness becomes receptive to patterns. It does not merely respond to differences but recognizes repeating structures. This is the first step towards experience.

When a structure fixes a repeating form of distinction, it can predict and interpret. When it fixes stable bonds between states, consciousness forms a context — the capacity to recognize repeating structures. The more stable bonds, the wider the range of consciousness. New distinctions rest on former ones and form a continuous layer of semantic structure.

If an elementary distinction creates one contrast, an aggregated configuration can create many contrasts at once. Consciousness becomes more detailed and multidimensional.

Semantic structure creates no independent ontological level and does not change the nature of dependent information. Context is a form of the orderedness of distinctions, not an entity

apart from them. Even complex and multilevel, it remains a consequence of the concordance of informational transitions. The extension of context increases only the organization of Something, but does not make the dependent independent.

Consciousness begins with the first distinction. This is not panprotopsychism.

Panprotopsychism ascribes to fundamental physical entities protophenomenal properties — not themselves phenomenal, but capable in aggregate of constituting phenomenal ones (Chalmers, 2017). Here the germ of consciousness is not a property of a physical entity. It is knowledge opened by the removal in information.

Example: an electron carries knowledge of the difference “this and not that”. In this knowledge there is already an instance of the *I*, but in the lowest degree: without bonds between distinctions, without memory, without self-awareness. A stone is a stable form; there is an instance of the *I* in it too, but its awareness is small: its distinctions are turned towards interactions with the other, not towards its own states.

Hence the *I* exists throughout reality from the first distinction. What differs is not its presence but its degree — the level of awareness (chapter 12).

Memory and Experience

Knowledge accrues and does not decrease: what has been removed does not return. But the living forgets. There is no contradiction, because knowledge and memory are not one.

Memory is the bond of the *I* of a configuration in its present state with the distinctions it has had. To remember is for present distinctions to refer to former ones. Forgetting is a break of this bond, not a decrease of knowledge: what has been removed remains the knowledge of information. Experience is memory that has changed the algorithm of functioning. Past interactions change the bond, and the next reaction proceeds by the altered algorithm. This is learning. At lower levels the algorithm is rigid and is not changed by experience. The higher the level, the more the algorithm is changed by experience.

Nested Instances of the *I*

The living is a form of forms: an organism of organs, organs of cells. A cell has its own instance of the *I*: it is a living form that holds its own bond. An organism has its own instance of the *I*: its bond is an agent that sets a common algorithm for the cells, and the cells function according to the paradigm of the organism’s boundness while retaining their own instances of the *I* (chapter 18).

Instances of the *I* are nested, not separate. A distinction in a cell can refer both to its own states and to the connectedness of the organism; then it enters both instances of the *I* at once. What the organism does not know in the cell — its inner metabolism — lies only in the *I* of the cell. The boundary between instances of the *I* is set by where knowledges refer.

The will of an organism does not reach all levels. Lower levels are held by their own bonds: a human being decides about the movement of the hand, but not about the division of cells. The freedom of the parts grows with complexification, and a cell can fall out of concordance with the organism. Then the *I* of the cell functions not by the algorithm of the whole but against it: this is an agent that has left boundness.

Chapter 21. Reason and Intellect

Reason is a level of consciousness. It is fixed where the structure of distinctions not only fixes and holds differences but also establishes stable bonds, inferences and semantic relations between them. It is not an independent substance: so much opacity has been removed in the configuration that the bonds between its distinctions are given to it.

Reason rests on an already built foundation. This is Nothing as the absolutely unconditioned and Selfhood as Nothing in self-understanding. This is information — the mode of being of this knowledge and the first dependent. This is initiation — the removal of opacity by which distinction in information proceeds not by itself but from Selfhood. This is distinction —

knowledge of difference, given together with change; consciousness — self-knowledge accrued with every distinction; elementary changes — the minimal manifestations of conditionedness; aggregated forms — stable configurations. Reason is a necessary level of this structure. It introduces no new principle: it is fixed as the removal proceeds, where the bonds between its distinctions are given to a configuration. There is no threshold here, there is a measure.

Reason does not merely perceive distinctions but orders them into a logical structure. It draws inferences, establishes “if — then” relations, singles out stable dependences between states. Thus a simple reaction passes into the awareness of regularities. Reason is not tied to biology: it is the result of an informational structure capable of self-concordance and interpretation. Reason is multilevel. It is not a homogeneous function but a sequence of levels, each of which depends on the complexity and concordance of the informational configuration.

The first level — local interpretation.

Reason connects individual differences. Interpretation is limited to the nearest transitions, and inferences are an immediate reaction to differences. Thinking here is fragmentary and rests on simple patterns.

The second level — structural interpretation.

Reason forms stable bonds between distinguished states and reveals repeating structures. The capacity to generalize patterns appears, and interpretation becomes contextual: the meaning of an element is determined by its place in the system.

The third level — meta-interpretation.

Reason fixes differences between distinctions. At this level reflection is possible: consciousness not only distinguishes but knows the ways of its own distinguishing. Here logical schemes, rules of inference, models of explanation and complex semantic constructions are formed. Reflection is the *I* distinguishing itself as distinguishing: it knows not only “this and not that”, but also that this knowledge is its own, and how it distinguishes. Without this one cannot know the dependence of one’s own knowledge, and therefore reflection is the condition of the transition to intellect, which knows its place in the whole (chapter 13).

The fourth level — limit interpretation.

Reason strives to bring all accessible distinctions into concordance in a single system. This is the level of the greatest structural integration: distinctions become elements of a single conceptual whole. The limit of this level is the bonds between all accessible distinctions. Beyond this what is known is no longer a bond but one’s place in the whole, and this is the level of intellect.

The four-level scheme shows that reason develops not spontaneously but together with the complexification of the informational structure. It does not produce distinctions but gives them semantic form and turns a sequence of changes into ordered knowledge. The limit of reason is the limit of knowledge of bonds; beyond it follows not completion but intellect, which knows its place in the whole and the programme.

Reason belongs not to one element but to a concordant totality of distinctions. The author’s example: if a single basis admits many interconnected configurations, their joint organization yields patterns not reducible to the properties of individual elements. These patterns belong to the structure as a whole. So too reason: the mutual organization of distinctions yields more than the sum of individual conscious acts.

Reason works with measures. Time singles out sequence, localization the position of information in the structure, speed the quickness of realization, space the domain of correlation of distinguished states. The measures are taken from the very elementary changes of which reason too is composed, and therefore everything it distinguishes is measurable.

Reason is limited by the complexity of the informational structure on which it rests. It does not go beyond dependent information. It cannot grasp Nothing positively: distinctions are inapplicable to Nothing, and only remotions are accessible. Reason understands only what is expressible in the structure of distinguished information, that is, only the conditioned.

At the same time reason is free — not absolutely but emergently. Freedom is fixed in the possibility of choice between distinguished states. Reason is the proximate ground of choice; it does not become the ultimate ground, for it is itself dependent. What has been said about information not proceeding by itself at any step pertains to the ultimate ground and does not abolish this freedom. Choice does not affect essence but determines the direction of the conditioned. Therefore reason forms the structure of its own development and becomes an active participant in the informational process.

Where choice comes from. As long as the *I* does not know its bonds, it functions by the algorithm that the bond sets, and it has no choice. Reason knows the bonds between its distinctions, and, knowing the bond, the *I* can respond not only as it sets but otherwise — from the reactions its experience admits (chapter 20). This is choice within conditions, not a rupture with the bond. Intellect knows, beyond this, the programme and its place in the whole, and therefore chooses not only the reaction but the algorithm itself: whether or not to take a function under control.

Reason as a level of consciousness does not violate absoluteness. Its level is attained with a complex configuration of distinctions and accumulated experience. Reason is not a source of absolute knowledge: it depends wholly on the informational structure in which it arises. Complex forms of consciousness arise from the very logic of informational changes, without new principles or intervention from outside: the more distinctions and bonds, the higher the level of consciousness.

With reason will is fixed. It is not an entity apart from consciousness but the range of possible reactions within distinctions already set. Choice concerns not the essence of the first ground but the informational structure, and therefore does not violate the ontology of Nothing. Will adds no new ontological status and creates no independent principle. Its range is determined by the number of transitions accessible in the informational configuration. Will discloses no new reality and does not influence the first ground: it expresses the degree of concordance and complexity of an already existing system.

Reason is a level, but not the limit, of the informational structure. Its role is to interpret distinctions, establish order and create semantic structures. Thanks to reason reality is knowable within the conditions of its informational nature. After reason comes intellect. Intellect is the level of consciousness that follows reason. Reason knows the bonds between distinctions and chooses within the conditions in which it stands. Intellect knows, beyond this, its own place in the whole and the direction in which the removal of opacity proceeds, that is, the programme. This determines the difference: reason chooses within programmes, intellect makes choices concerning programmes, for one cannot bring under one's control what one does not know. Intellect introduces no new nature: it is the same self-knowledge at the measure of removal at which a configuration knows itself as part of the whole. The intellectual potential of a configuration is hereafter the name for the possibility it has accumulated of reaching this level.

The interactions of developed forms are the third level of interaction (chapter 16).

When aggregated forms are themselves consciousness and reason, interactions acquire new properties. Reason interprets distinctions, forms intentions and chooses among possible informational transitions. Thus a new kind of interaction arises — purposeful informational reactions proceeding not from physical nature but from the structure of interpretation.

At the level of reason interactions are multilevel. Structures not only respond but forecast, compare, analyse and change their own states. Reason acts on informational configurations and creates new combinations of distinctions. Interactions cease to be merely structural and become semantic.

PART III. INTEGRATION WITH THE FUNDAMENTAL SCIENCES

Chapter 22. Physics as an Informational System

Contemporary physics discovers properties inexplicable in the classical notion of matter. Matter ceases to be the fundamental element of being. Experimentally confirmed quantum theory describes physical reality not through material objects as primary entities but through informational states. Therefore physics naturally enters an ontology based on the unconditioned Nothing, its self-understanding, information as the first dependent, and the initiation of Selfhood — the removal of opacity by which every distinction in information proceeds.

The ontological level and the level of physical description are strictly distinguished. Ontology determines the conditions of possibility of all manifestations, while physics describes the structures of already manifest informational conditionedness. Physical theories fix the regularities that arise in Something after the appearance of measures, distinctions and aggregated forms, but do not explain the nature of these conditions. Therefore quantum nonlocality, the wave function, entanglement, the holographic principle, the energy cost of information and the dependence of the result of measurement on the observer are not a ground for concluding that matter or spacetime is primary. They describe the behaviour of distinguished informational states, not the level at which distinguishability itself and its dependence on the unconditioned are determined. Ontology does not compete with physics and does not correct its conclusions. It explains why physical laws have such a form, why elementary states have no properties of substance, and why observation is necessary for the transition from a probabilistic description to a manifest state. Ontology establishes fundamental dependences; physics describes regularities within them. These levels do not rival each other but are hierarchically in concordance.

A fundamental particle in contemporary physics has neither volume, nor solid form, nor extension. The electron, the quark, the gluon and other elementary states exist not as objects but as configurations of information. Spin, charge and mass do not make them independent entities: they are forms of distinguished states of information. In experiment a particle is manifested only at the moment of distinction. Before distinction it is a set of possible states described by the wave function.

The wave function describes the informational state of the system itself — its possible states — and not knowledge of a material state hidden behind it (Heisenberg, 1958; Feynman, 1985, 19). This is an interpretation, not a generally accepted result. It is compatible with the theorem of Pusey, Barrett and Rudolph, which excludes — on the assumption that independently prepared systems have independent physical states — the treatment of the quantum state as mere information about an underlying physical state (Pusey, Barrett, & Rudolph, 2012). The Schrödinger equation describes the dependence of an informational state on a parameter that physics interprets as time. But time itself is derived from the working moment of an elementary change. Physics is in concordance with this: in the theory of relativity simultaneity depends on the frame of reference, and the duration between events differs for different observers; physics finds no absolute time in which changes would proceed. Fundamental physics admits an informational reading of its objects. Matter is an aggregated form of informational configurations (chapter 19).

The collapse of the wave function is the moment of distinction. It is not a physical destruction of a state but the transformation of possible states into one manifest state — what physics describes as reduction. Without an observer there is no collapse. But the observer is not a biological subject but any configuration in which distinction proceeds, however it is realized. What distinguishes in it is the knowledge opened by the removal of opacity. Thus the quantum process is in concordance with the ontology: collapse is distinction in the informational structure.

This interpretation of collapse does not accept objective collapse as a physical mechanism and does not compete with interpretations of quantum mechanics. Collapse here is a philosophical description of the fixing of distinguishedness. It is compatible with decoherence-based, relational and operational treatments, introduces no nonlocal causality and does not replace the physical explanation by an ontological one.

Entanglement shows independence from space: two entangled states change in concordance at any distance (Greene, 2004, ch. 4). In a material ontology this is impossible; in an informational one it is natural. Information is not bounded by space: space is a measure of distinction within the conditioned, not a fundamental structure. If two states originate from one distinction, they remain in concordance: their informational connection is not subject to spatial measures. They do not interact in the physical sense but are correlated parts of one informational structure.

The holographic principle states that the area of a surface limits the information content of the adjacent spacetime regions singled out by light-sheets (Bousso, 2002); a complete description of a region through its boundary has been established for particular classes of spacetimes. The conclusion that space is derivative is an interpretation of this result, not its content; it is cited as being in concordance with an ontology in which space is a measure of distinguishedness. Landauer's principle shows that the erasure of information requires energy. Physical processes admit an informational description, and energy and information are connected in physical theories; the direction of dependence does not follow from this. The conclusion of chapter 13 on the finiteness of the path to transparency is in concordance with a number of physical results: the Bekenstein bound sets an upper limit on the information in a finite region of space with finite energy (Bekenstein, 1981); Wheeler's programme "it from bit" takes the bit — a yes–no choice — as the fundamental unit of physical description (Wheeler, 1990); the information content of the matter of the observable Universe is estimated as a finite quantity — about $6 \cdot 10^{80}$ bits (Vopson, 2021).

The matrix of correspondence between physics and ontology shows that physical processes are forms of the manifest informational structure: localization corresponds to space, sequence to time, concordance to the stability of systems, and the change of state to the dynamics of distinctions.

When physics discovers nonlocality, it fixes that description is not reducible to local states; the conclusion that there is no material substrate is an interpretation. When it discovers the dependence of the result on the measurement procedure, it fixes the role of distinction in description; the ontological primacy of distinction does not follow from this and is asserted on an ontological ground. When it discovers quantum fields, it fixes a structure of description. All three correlations show compatibility; they are not grounds. Hoffman concludes that physics and evolutionary theory point to one thing: spacetime and objects are not fundamental (Hoffman, 2019); ontology decides the question of what is fundamental by its own means.

Observed physical processes are forms of manifestation of the dependent structure, not properties of the source. The author's example: if a single informational basis admits many configurations, their interaction yields complex combinations of states that are amplified, weakened or change direction. All this is a manifestation of distinguished information. So too

physics describes regularities within manifest structures without touching the ground: distinction forms the configuration of manifestation, and physics fixes the rules of its unfolding.

Fundamental physics converges with the ontological structure empirically. Physical data receive a concordant interpretation in the informational ontology and do not contradict its grounds. Quantum theory, information theory, cosmology and thermodynamics point to one thing: what changes is not matter but information. Physical theories correctly describe manifest regularities but do not decide the ontological question: physicists themselves disagree about what ground stands behind them (Hut, Alford, & Tegmark, 2006).

Closest to the treatment of the *I* in the present system stands Rovelli's relational quantum mechanics. He considers the notion of a state of a system independent of the observer to be mistaken: all systems are equivalent, there is no distinction of observer and observed, and the theory describes only the information that systems have about each other (Rovelli, 1996).

This is a physical parallel to the claim that every configuration is an instance of the *I* distinguishing itself from not-oneself, and that properties are manifested only in interaction (chapters 11, 16). A parallel, not a ground: for Rovelli the relation of systems does not require self-knowledge, whereas here self-differentiation is knowledge.

The opposite pole is Tegmark's mathematical universe hypothesis: if external physical reality is independent of humans, it is an abstract mathematical structure (Tegmark, 2007). For him structure is the ultimate ground. Here a mathematical structure is a description of distinctions, not what posits them: mathematics, like all logic, belongs to the conditioned (chapter 4).

Therefore physics is a discipline that studies the structure of distinguished informational states. In this system it ceases to contradict consciousness, causality, space, time and emergence; Deutsch too strives for the unity of physics with the theories of computation, knowledge and evolution (Deutsch, 1997). The limitation of physics is that its descriptions fix manifest regularities but not their ontological origin. Physical quantities and processes depend on distinctions and measures that are not derivable from physical categories.

Chapter 23. Quantum Entanglement

Quantum entanglement shows the limitation of object-based materialist interpretations. Basic physical states are not described as independent objects localized in space. They form one informational configuration in which distinction is realized by the concordance of the structure (Barad, 2007), not by the transmission of a signal or an interaction of objects.

When physics discovers that a change of one state is instantly in concordance with another, it fixes independence from space. The concordance does not depend on distance and is therefore not explained by the motion of particles, the interaction of fields or the transmission of signals. Physics asserts that no "information" is transmitted faster than light. But this assertion treats information as a physically transmitted quantity. Here information is not an object of transmission: entangled states are states of one information, and their concordance is its own structure, not something passed from one to the other. Space is a measure of distinctions within the conditioned, not a fundamental limitation. Therefore the concordance of entangled states requires no signal and does not violate the physical limits on speed.

A bound structure changes as a whole when one of its elements changes. The author's example: if two elements of a single configuration are in concordance, a change of one rebuilds the whole structure, however far apart its parts stand. Such a structure is determined not by distance but by the degree of inner concordance. The change does not propagate in space but is a rebuilding of the common configuration of bonds. Entanglement is not an interaction of objects but a change of a single configuration whose parts are not independent. Thus entanglement is compatible with the informational ontology. In a materialist system it is a paradox. Here it receives a concordant interpretation: informational connection is not

subject to space, because space is derivative from distinctions. The state of the world is not a set of independent elements but a single informational structure in which distinctions are distributed and bound. The “separation” of objects is a difference of localizations, not independence.

Compatible with entanglement is also a second feature of the informational ontology: there is no true randomness. This is a position of the ontology, not a conclusion from entanglement: Bell’s theorem rules out local explanations of the correlations but establishes neither determinism nor its absence. The concordance of results indicates only that they stand in a common informational structure. “Randomness” in quantum mechanics is interpreted here as incompleteness of description, not as an ontological property of reality. The observed probabilistic character reflects the limitedness of access to the whole structure of concordance that precedes the levels of measure.

The consequences of entanglement are as follows:

1. space is not a primordial level;
2. distinction logically precedes localization;
3. physical processes are described through informational states;
4. the structures of consciousness are subject to the same logic of the concordance of distinctions.

Entanglement is empirical evidence of the informational structure of reality: fundamental processes depend not on distance, position or material properties but on the concordance of distinctions.

Chapter 24. Cosmology

Cosmology here considers the origin, structure and dynamics of reality not as a physical process but as the fixing of the complexification of informational distinctions. Space, time, matter and energy are derivative forms dependent on a more fundamental informational structure. The cosmological “beginning” is not an event but the fixing of distinguishability at which conditioned information admits further organization.

In Hawking and Mlodinow, in the early Universe time behaves like a spatial dimension, and the question of what was “before” the beginning loses its meaning (Hawking & Mlodinow, 2010, 135). Here the “Big Bang” is the limit physical description of the moment at which the informational structure first acquires measures. It is neither a physical explosion nor the beginning of essence, but the boundary of distinguishability after which space, time and sequence are possible.

Physical cosmology conceives the first cause as a physical event that sets processes going. Here the first cause cannot be physical: the physical arises only after measures and distinctions. Nothing is not a cause, not an action and not an event, and does not replace physical description. The cosmological beginning fixes the appearance of distinguishability in conditioned information, without introducing a physical first cause and without violating scientific methodology. Therefore ontology and cosmology do not contradict each other: the first sets the structure of possibility, the second describes its realization in Something. The appearance of measures has been described through localization, time, speed and space. Cosmology describes the unfolding of these measures, not the birth of physical matter. Singularity here is not a physical object but the limit indeterminacy of measures, at which distinctions are not yet fixed. It is a boundary description in concordance with physical models, not an alternative physical theory.

Further, time is fixed as a sequence of the working moments of elementary changes, and space as a domain composed of localizations. This is in concordance with physical models in which space and time are not primary.

Space is a measure of distinctions, not an absolute background. Cosmological expansion is not the expansion of a container-space but the expansion of the distinguished structure: new distinctions appear and unfold in measures. The more distinctions, the more “space”. This is in concordance with the observed expansion of the Universe: the more information is manifested, the larger the structure of measures.

Entropy here is a measure of the distribution and concordance of distinctions. This is compatible with thermodynamics but not reducible to material statistics. The growth of entropy is the discharge and levelling of distinctions, a process opposed to emergence, not a loss of “order” in the metaphysical sense.

Landauer’s principle: the logically irreversible erasure of an informational state is accompanied by the dissipation of energy. Hence information and energy are connected in physical description, and an informational description suffices where a description in terms of substance was previously required. Here energy is interpreted as a manifestation of changes of information.

The holographic principle, derived from the study of black holes, states that information about a three-dimensional volume is recorded on a two-dimensional surface (Susskind, 2008; Sorkin, 2005). The area of a surface limits the information content of the adjacent spacetime regions singled out by light-sheets; a complete description of a region through its boundary has been established for particular classes of spacetimes. The conclusion that space is derivative is an interpretation of this result, cited as being in concordance with an ontology in which information is primary. Cosmology must explain not space but the informational structure that makes space possible.

Thus cosmology here is not a history of matter but a history of distinctions. It describes:

1. the removal of the opacity of information to itself — the initiation of Selfhood;
2. the appearance of distinction: what distinguishes is the knowledge opened in information — not by itself but from Selfhood; with it consciousness begins;
3. the formation of elementary changes;
4. the appearance of measures (time, localization, speed, space);
5. the formation of aggregated forms;
6. the complexification of structures;
7. the growth of consciousness, which began with the first distinction, up to reason and intellect;
8. the attainment of the limit experience;
9. the transition to the next state.

This sequence describes the cosmological structure consistently and without contradictions. It is in concordance with the data of fundamental physics and fills the logical gaps of contemporary cosmological models. It does not compete with physical cosmology but refines the ontological status of its categories.

Chapter 25. Life as an Informational Process

Life here is not a biological phenomenon in the narrow sense. Biology is a particular case of a deeper structure: life is a connected whole of distinctions that holds its stability and reproduces its structure. It is not matter, not energy and not a chemical reaction, but an informational process. It is fixed where aggregated forms hold the connectedness of their distinctions and renew them.

Life is a form of the self-organization of dependence. It is fixed where a configuration holds the connectedness of its distinctions and restores it when disturbed: this is self-maintenance. The configuration does not merely fix changes but responds to them so as to preserve itself. The distinguishing of its own states comes later, at the fifth level of complexification; they

are distinguished by the consciousness of the configuration — not by itself but from Selfhood.

Life is thus a connected whole of elementary changes composed into a stable aggregated form that:

1. holds distinctions,
2. renews distinctions,
3. reacts to changes,
4. is fixed as the preservation of its own structure.

This is not a “will to live” in the biological sense but an informational necessity: a structure that does not hold itself disintegrates; one that holds itself continues to exist (Bateson, 1972). This logic is in concordance with biology. In the most fundamental sense life is the capacity of a system to minimize the destruction of its structure through the concordance of distinctions. Every living system — from the cell to reason — exists because its informational organization maintains a dynamic equilibrium. This equilibrium is not physical but structural. When a structure can compensate for inner deviations, it preserves itself under local changes: it stabilizes differences and levels out disturbances. If concordance is disturbed, the configuration disintegrates.

Life is not fixed instantaneously: it is the result of successive levels of complexification.

The first level is reactivity. An aggregated form fixes distinction and responds to minimal changes. These are the simplest informational systems capable of responding to external influence.

The second level is self-support. The structure not only responds but preserves its state: it restores distinctions and compensates for disturbances. This is the fundamental sign of life.

The third level is self-regulation. The system changes its own distinctions in order to stabilize the configuration. The first signs of an inner “analysis” appear, although this is not yet reason.

The fourth level is adaptivity. The system perceives external changes not only as a threat but also as information, and changes its structure for the sake of stability.

The fifth level is self-fixation. The system distinguishes its own states as separate informational elements. Consciousness proceeds from the first distinction; here it reaches the measure at which the configuration’s own states are given to it.

Biological life is a particular case of these levels. The cell responds, maintains itself, regulates, adapts and distinguishes. All biology is a sequence of informational processes in chemical and physical forms. But chemistry and physics are forms, not the ground.

The ground is informational.

Death in this ontology is the cessation of a configuration’s holding of its connectedness, at which the distinctions of information do not cease, but the form of their organization changes.

Life and death are transitions between levels of organization of distinctions. Life is the holding of connectedness; death is the cessation of holding. Death is not the antipode of life: these are different forms of the existence of information. With the disintegration of connectedness, what it has removed does not return.

Thus life as an informational process is a necessary stage of the structure of Something, preparing the growth of consciousness to reason and intellect.

Chapter 26. Consciousness in the Neurosciences

The neurosciences describe consciousness through correlations between the activity of neural structures and subjective lived experience. But they fix manifestations of consciousness, not what it is. They measure electrical impulses, observe the dynamics of networks and identify

the brain regions involved in perception. None of these characteristics explains what consciousness is and why subjectivity arises from neural activity (Nagel, 2012). This is the “hard problem of consciousness”. Here it receives an ontological explanation: consciousness is self-knowledge accrued by information with every distinction, and neural processes are the aggregated form through which this knowledge is stably manifested.

Consciousness is not a function of the brain. The brain is an aggregated form in which distinction reaches a high density. It creates the conditions for complex distinctions but is not the source of consciousness. The source is the removal of opacity proceeding from Selfhood: consciousness is the knowledge opened by this removal in information. The brain is a complex configuration in which many bound elements form a concordant structure of distinctions. It does not generate knowledge but sets the form of its manifestation.

Consciousness is not born in the brain but expressed through the organization of its processes.

The limit of neuroscience: it measures correlations but does not explain why correlations yield subjective experience. Husserl showed that science stands on the natural attitude: it takes the world as simply given and does not clarify how it is given to consciousness (Husserl, 1982). Reducing consciousness to neural processes does not remove the main ontological difficulty: neural activity fixes distinctions but does not explain their origin. Here subjective experience is self-knowledge itself, and neural dynamics is the way it is expressed. Contemporary neuroscientific models are in concordance with the treatment of consciousness as a knowledge in which many distinctions are composed into one, and give it a formal language. Integrated Information Theory (IIT) sees consciousness as the capacity of a system to integrate information. Its basis is two properties of experience: differentiation, that is, an enormous number of possible experiences, and integration, that is, the unity of each of them. The quantity of consciousness is measured by Φ — the amount of causally effective information that can be integrated across the informational weakest link of the system. Consciousness in this theory is graded (Tononi, 2004). In the terms of the present ontology, differentiation is the number of distinctions, integration is their connectedness into one knowledge, and gradedness is the degree of the I , that is, the level of awareness.

Predictive processing models see the brain as a system of continuous comparison of expected and observed states; the key element is the detection of a discrepancy between prediction and fact. In the terms of this ontology this is a distinction of the second level: the configuration distinguishes not only the state but also the deviation from its own expectations, and differentiation is intensified.

This formalism supports the treatment of consciousness as integrated differentiation. Consciousness is not localized in one element: it is the self-knowledge of the whole system of distinctions capable of holding and interpreting informational connections. The brain in this sense is the technical bearer of Φ -structures that provide the stable manifestation of consciousness in biological form.

Distinction, taken as that by which knowledge of difference is given, is change; the distinguished that is held is not change. Consciousness proceeds with every distinction, and the density and concordance of distinctions set its measure. The brain is an aggregated form that supports such distinctions.

The hard problem of consciousness is here not interpreted but disappears. It arises on the assumption that an informational process and subjective experience are different entities. Here neural dynamics is connected with the fundamental structure of distinctions, and the confusion of the ontological and physiological levels is removed.

Thus consciousness in neuroscience is an observable manifestation of a more fundamental process, the dynamics of informational distinctions. Neural processes are a technical realization, not the source. The measure of consciousness is set by how much opacity has

been removed in the given configuration. Methods of observation and measurement fix only manifest forms of distinctions and do not describe their ontological origin.

PART IV. A NEW WORLDVIEW

Chapter 27. A New Point of Departure

The new point of departure is a change of ontological ground: from interpreting reality through material substance to an ontology in which information is the first dependent, that in which the whole of reality stands. The traditional contradictions of matter and consciousness, determinism and probability, observer and observed become derivatives of the differences of the informational structure.

The basis of reality is neither matter nor spirit but information as the first dependent: the mode of being of Nothing's knowledge of itself, neither produced nor arising through an onset, but existing together with this knowledge. The ground of information itself is the unconditioned, Nothing. This point of departure removes contradictions irremovable in the former system of categories. It gives an integral ontological interpretation in concordance with the data of science and the logic of ontological analysis, and does not replace scientific description by philosophical assertions.

Chapter 28. Principles of the New Worldview

The principles of the new worldview follow neither from philosophical tradition, nor from religion, nor from scientific hypotheses. They are derived from the structure of being reconstructed in the preceding chapters. Nothing is absolutely unconditioned and therefore immutable. Selfhood is the name of Nothing taken in self-understanding. Information is the first dependent, the mode of being of Nothing's knowledge of itself. Initiation is the removal of opacity in information. Distinction is knowledge of difference, and its appearance is change. On this the new picture of the world stands.

These principles are neither recommendations, nor moral norms, nor social ideals, but necessary consequences of the informational ontology. They set the relation of consciousness to reality and explain how a concordant system of perception, behaviour and understanding is possible.

1. The Principle of Unconditionedness

Unconditionedness is the basis of the worldview. Properties, changes, transitions and inner states are inapplicable to the first ground. Unconditionedness is obtained as the limit of the conditioned, not ascribed to Nothing as a characteristic; immutability is the same unconditionedness taken from the side of change.

For the worldview this means:

- no conditions whatever may be ascribed to the absolute;
- the absolute may not be thought through the categories of Something;
- essence and manifestations may not be confused.

A worldview that begins with unconditionedness removes the illusion that being is obliged to correspond to human expectations.

2. The Principle of Proportionality

Proportionality is the relation of the structure of distinctions to the capacities of consciousness. Consciousness does not go beyond the information it is able to distinguish. Therefore all perception is limited:

- by the complexity of the informational structure,
- by the level of experience,
- by the range of attentive distinctions.

Proportionality is the recognition of the structural limits of distinction and interpretation. It makes adequate perception possible without a claim to omniscience.

3. The Principle of Uniformity

Uniformity: informational processes are structured by the laws of concordance, not of randomness or chaos. Everything stable is stable because it is supported by a structure of distinctions.

Uniformity is a fundamental kind of stability:

- distinctions repeat,
- bonds are preserved,
- forms remain concordant,
- the structure does not disintegrate instantly.

Reality is not chaotic but structural. All forms of behaviour are manifestations of the uniform maintenance of distinctions.

4. The Principle of Responsibility

Responsibility is a property of a rational configuration capable of choosing and thereby influencing the conditions of its existence. It is neither a moral nor a social norm.

If a rational configuration chooses between distinguished states, it is responsible: it bears the consequences of its own distinctions. Responsibility is a consequence of the capacity to distinguish and choose within the dependent informational structure.

The author's example: a change in the position of one element changes the whole pattern. So too consciousness, changing its own distinctions, changes the whole range of its perception.

5. The Principle of Continuous Development

Development is the complexification of the structure of distinctions.

If distinctions can become more complex, they become more complex: the direction is set by initiation — the removal is one-sided — and there is nowhere for a decrease of knowledge to come from.

If a structure can hold more bonds, it holds them.

If consciousness can extend the range of perception, it extends it.

Development is neither progress, nor a purpose, nor a moral category, but the natural dynamics of the conditioned: the concordance of distinctions follows from their structural compatibility and leads to more complex configurations.

The principle of continuous development fixes a tendency: compatible distinctions, coming into concordance, make the configuration more complex. This is a determinism not of realization but of direction. Freedom of choice (chapter 21) acts within the tendency as its component, not as a contradiction. A rational form may choose a less complex configuration — this does not abolish the tendency but realizes one of its admissible trajectories. Tendency and freedom relate as a field of possibilities and a choice within it. The range is determined; realization within it is variable.

6. The Principle of Inner Completion

Information as a whole proceeds to the limit experience — self-transparency, in which all blind spots have been removed by distinctions. It is attained as opacity is removed, not by going through everything.

Limit completion is not a stopping of development but the completion of a cycle.

This principle shows:

- existence has a direction;
- development determines the direction towards the limit;
- completion as a limit is determined for distinction;
- reality has a cycle, and this cycle is completed.

This is a fundamental teleological characteristic of Something.

These principles give a worldview that does not depend on substance, does not conflict with scientific data and does not rest on faith, but follows from the logic of being. The new point of departure gives a concordant understanding of reality and of the position of consciousness in the informational process, without deriving normative prescriptions from ontological principles.

Chapter 29. The Human Being in the Structure of Being

The human being here is neither the centre of the universe, nor an exception among forms of life, nor a special substance. It is an aggregated informational form with a high degree of distinctions, stability, self-regulation and interpretation. Its nature is determined not by the materiality of the body but by the complexity of the informational structure in which consciousness grows to reason and intellect.

The structure of the human being has several levels — different measures of distinctions in one configuration. They do not exist separately: they are interdependent and form a single configuration that allows the human being to be aware of itself, of its surroundings and of its place in reality.

The first level — physical. The human being is a stable aggregated form, supported by a structure of distinctions at the level of material organization. This level brings the configuration into concordance with the measures of space, time and speed.

The second level — biological. The human being is capable of self-support and self-regulation of the informational structure. Reactivity arises: external distinctions are perceived and built into the configuration's own structure for the sake of stability.

The third level — psychological. The human being fixes its own states as separate informational elements. Primary self-accessibility arises: the consciousness of the configuration distinguishes its own states and responds to them from within.

The fourth level — rational. The human being interprets distinctions, establishes stable bonds, generalizes and builds semantic structures. Reflection arises: consciousness not only distinguishes but knows its own ways of distinguishing.

The fifth level — active. The human being consciously influences the conditions of existence of its configuration. It chooses between distinctions, creates new structures, removes discordances and forms its own experience. This makes it responsible: influencing the conditions of its distinctions, it forms the consequences of its existence.

Perception depends on the configuration of the informational structure, and the human being is one of the most complex such configurations. What the human being considers its essence is not a ground but a form of organization of distinctions, set by the quality, connectedness and parameters of its structure. Therefore the human being sees the world not as it is in the absolute, but as its inner organization allows it to fix the world.

The human being is not the summit of development but one of the levels of the development of consciousness. The capacity for self-reflection makes it an important form of understanding reality. Its reason interprets the structure of distinctions and recognizes regularities; at the level of intellect it is given to know its place in the whole and the direction of the removal of opacity. But the human being is limited by measure: its consciousness does not go beyond the conditioned. Positively it grasps only the manifest; of Nothing only remotions are accessible. Even a developed reason expands only within Something; expansion is inapplicable to absolute immutability.

The human being is not the centre of being but a form of its unfolding. Its tasks are set not by a meaning laid in from outside but by the logic of the informational process: the development of distinctions, concordance, the removal of discrepancies, the accumulation of experience, the transition to the limit state. This is not a prescription but the natural dynamics of the informational structure.

The human being is a part of Something capable of being aware of itself as a part. Anthropocentrism is excluded here. The human being is capable of reflection and of interpreting distinctions, but does not go beyond its configuration and does not positively grasp that to which differences are inapplicable.

This limitedness is not a deficiency but a property of every informational configuration. The human being is not an ontological centre: it is one of many possible forms of organization of distinctions. Its uniqueness is relative: it does not mean a special status in being. The human being can understand the logic of its origin and its limit. It is a form capable of seeing its own configuration, and therefore not an exception but a key element of a structure proceeding towards completion.

Chapter 30. The Concluding Doctrine

The limit by which everything conditioned is determined is not matter, not an object, not energy, not space and not time, but the unconditionedness of Nothing: that by which the conditioned is determined and which it does not reach. The scope of the claim of uniqueness is determined precisely. What is asserted is the uniqueness of the solution under the accepted conditions. Given the unconditionedness of the ground, the uniqueness of the principle, the immutability of essence and the presence of a changeable reality, there is no other consistent configuration. The uniqueness of the conditions themselves is not asserted.

Therefore whoever rejects the conditions rejects not the solution but the problem: he builds something else, and this work does not refute it. But he must show that his problem does not reproduce the same aporia under another name: every ontology that recognizes an unconditioned ground and the changeable faces this aporia, whether it acknowledges this or not. The claim of the uniqueness of the solution and the recognition that the conditions may be not accepted do not conflict: the first concerns solutions within the problem, the second the choice of the problem. Open questions remain in both respects.

The first foundation of the doctrine is Nothing as the absolutely unconditioned and therefore immutable, and Selfhood as the name of Nothing taken in self-understanding. Hence, as shown in chapters 5 and 10: self-understanding is Nothing's complete knowledge of itself; information is the mode of being of this knowledge in the dependent — the first dependent and conditioned; initiation is the removal of its opacity, proceeding from Selfhood; knowledge of difference is distinction, and its appearance is change. Thus the path to the self-transparency of information opens, completed by the limit experience. The cycle closes.

Change proceeds where distinction proceeds — by the removal of opacity. Information is not constituted by it and does not depend on it: it is the mode of being of Nothing's knowledge of itself and does not stand outside this. This relation makes possible distinction, conditionedness and the whole spectrum of manifestations.

The second foundation of the doctrine is change proceeding in information without affecting essence. Distinction does not arise in Nothing and is not an independent principle: it is the knowledge information has of its difference, and its appearance is change. Without change there are no distinctions. But conditionedness is not created by distinctions and does not disappear when they cease: information is conditioned by its determinacy.

Reality is not reducible to one universe. A universe is a local domain of the conditioned, arising from dependent distinctions and informational forms; it does not exhaust all the states of reality.

Consciousness is not an independent entity and does not stand apart from the elementary change. It is self-knowledge accrued by information with every distinction, beginning with the first. The density and concordance of distinctions set its measure, not its presence.

Consciousness is neither a universal bearer of experience nor a single subject preceding conditionedness.

The third foundation of the doctrine is consciousness and the programme.

Consciousness is self-knowledge accrued by information with every distinction; it begins with the first distinction. The programme is the directedness of the removal of opacity, set by initiation: what has been removed does not return; knowledge accrues.

The fourth foundation of the doctrine is elementary changes and measure. Elementary changes are minimal distinctions in information. Time, space, localization and speed are not fundamental entities but parameters of the structuring of distinctions. Measure is taken from the elementary change itself and makes distinguished states comparable. Processes, interactions and motion are measurable because they are composed of changes that gave the measure. Measure exists only in informational conditionedness; there is none in Nothing.

The fifth foundation of the doctrine is interaction and aggregated forms. Interaction is the concordance of informational structures. Aggregated forms are stable configurations of distinctions, the basis of all systems, objects and processes. The world consists not of “things” but of stable structures of distinctions perceived as objects. A derivative form is never a source: it is a structural state. Physical objects are forms of the organization of information, stable but not fundamental.

The sixth foundation of the doctrine is reason and intellect. Reason is the level of consciousness that knows the bonds between distinctions and chooses within the conditions in which it stands; intellect is the next level, which knows its place in the whole and the programme. The human being is a complex informational configuration capable of self-reflection and the formation of meaning. But it is not the centre of the universe; it is one of the forms that information takes at high complexity.

The seventh foundation of the doctrine is teleological completion: the limit state of the conditioned, in which nothing remains outside the scope of the knowledge of information and every new distinction is already grasped by it. It is not attained by going through everything: each distinction removes a blind spot, those removed do not return, and the object of knowledge is indivisible. What matters is not the number of distinctions passed but the removal of all blind spots. Knowledge accrues and does not decrease. The completion of the cycle does not destroy information: there simply remain no distinctions requiring maintenance.

The transition after the limit experience is neither the arising of a new entity nor an exit to an external level of the universe. The completion of the programme — the last stage — is a purely ontological state: all blind spots have been removed by distinctions, and information is transparent to itself while remaining conditioned. The very necessity of distinction falls away: further complexification is impossible without violating concordance, and the preservation of the structure requires no new transitions.

This transition is not an event in the usual sense but a change of informational mode. In dependent information the disclosure of the new ceases: distinguishedness and determinacy are preserved, but no new distinctions are required. This is neither a return to Nothing nor the disappearance of dependence. When every new distinction is already grasped by information’s knowledge of itself, there remains a state in which there is distinguishedness and nothing unknown. Therefore the completion of the cycle is a formal and inwardly necessary consequence of the construction, not the result of an external action or assumption. Thus reality is neither chaos, nor chance, nor a mechanical interaction of matter. It is the successive unfolding of the conditioned, determined by unconditionedness as its limit: through information, the removal of its opacity, change, with which consciousness begins, the

programme, elementary changes and measures, interaction, aggregated forms, emergence and matter, the growth of consciousness to reason and intellect — to the limit experience.

There are no contradictions in this system:

- essence is immutable;
- the dependent category changes;
- change and distinction are one and proceed in the conditioned;
- reason interprets the structure;
- the limit completes the cycle.

The doctrine completes the monograph: philosophy, metaphysics and fundamental science are brought into concordance in it in a single ontology. The testability of the ontological structure is set by three criteria: the consistent derivation of all dependent categories from the unconditioned ground; the impossibility of another sequence of levels without violating the conditions; the concordance of all subsequent forms with the initial scheme.

Negative tests are conditions under which the ontology must collapse: inner states in the ground; the autonomy of information; distinction within essence; the necessity of a second principle; the violation or permutation of levels without loss of semantic integrity.

Positive tests are signs of stability: the immutability of the ground; the derivability of information as dependent; the arising of distinction only by the removal of its opacity; the unfolding of consciousness, elementary changes, measures, aggregated forms and levels of consciousness from one scheme; the concordance of levels and the absence of a consistent alternative.

The words “before”, “after”, “follows” and “transition” have a structural-descriptive character and do not mean a temporal, causal or processual unfolding: the sequence of levels fixes a hierarchy of dependences, not an order of arising. Ontological statements, logical consequences and modes of description are strictly distinguished. Logical necessity is not ontological causality, and a conceptual description is not passed off as an empirical process. The ground remains outside time; dependent forms admit temporal description; the language of sequence introduces no hidden temporality into the ground.

The conceptual map fixes the sequence of dependent levels:

Nothing — absolute unconditionedness

Selfhood — the name of Nothing taken in its self-understanding

Transparency — unconditionedness taken from the side of opacity: the non-transparent is opaque, and opacity is limitation

Self-understanding — Nothing’s complete knowledge of itself; it is complete in that nothing is concealed

Information — the mode of being of this knowledge in the dependent; the first dependent and conditioned

The initiation of Selfhood — the removal of the opacity of information to itself

Change — the succession of states of information, posited by the removal of opacity;

Non-identity is not produced by Selfhood and is not the result of its modification. It has no genetic source in the ground and requires no causal explanation: it is posited by the removal of opacity and exists only in dependent forms.

Distinction and change are one, taken from two sides: knowledge of difference, proceeding by the removal of opacity, is a new state of information, and the appearance of a new state is the succession of states. Information is not identical with them: it is the mode of being of Nothing’s knowledge of itself, and distinction proceeds in it not from it but from initiation. The mutual reference of the definitions is not vicious: the reference point of the system is Nothing as the unconditioned, which does not enter the circle and is not defined through dependent categories. Therefore a “mechanism of production” of change is not needed: change is not produced but is admissible within the established boundary.

Distinction — the knowledge information has of its difference from that whose mode of being it is; its appearance is change

Distinguishedness — the relation and boundary of the states of the dependent category

Consciousness — self-knowledge accrued by information with every distinction

Programme — the directedness of the removal of opacity, set by initiation

Elementary changes — minimal manifestations of conditionedness

Measures — time, speed, localization and space, derived from the working moment of an elementary change

Interaction — the concordance of distinguished configurations

Aggregated forms — stable configurations

Emergence — knowledge of the whole that individual distinctions do not have

Matter — a stable aggregated form of information

Reason — the level of consciousness that knows the bonds between distinctions

Intellect — the level of consciousness that knows its place in the whole and the programme

Teleological completion — the self-transparency of information

The exposition makes no claim to a positive description of Nothing: of it only remotions are accessible. Nothing is neither an object of positive knowledge, nor a content of consciousness, nor a subject of distinction. It is fixed only as a limit indication of the inapplicability of differences. The monograph does not describe Nothing but maps the boundaries of the applicability of distinction, change, information and consciousness. Therefore its status is metaontological: it fixes the conditions under which every description becomes impossible and does not go beyond dependent forms. Consciousness here does not grasp Nothing but discovers its own limit. The absence of positive knowledge of Nothing does not contradict the formal indication of it as the ultimate ground. A contradiction would arise only from a confusion of levels — if the fixing of a boundary were taken for an act of cognition.

The terms “intention” and “purpose” have no psychological, volitional or externally purposive sense. They mean no subject of goal-setting, design or preference and introduce no teleological causality as an independent principle.

“Intention” is the structural directedness of the removal of opacity, set by initiation: the removal is one-sided and does not return; it is not an act of choice. “Purpose” is not an external reference point but the limit state of concordance at which further distinction is not needed.

Therefore teleological completion introduces no external purpose and does not violate the causal neutrality of the dependent categories. It describes the structural limit of the conditioned as the realization of the task of the dependent — the striving of information towards self-transparency.

Aims, methods, results and contribution:

aim — to derive a consistent ontology that removes the aporia;

method — formal reduction based on the unconditionedness of the first ground;

result — a consistent structure of levels derivable from Nothing;

contribution — the concordance of ontology with fundamental physics and the removal of the logical gaps of former models.

Formal expressions of the main elements:

Nothing — that to which differences are inapplicable;

Selfhood — Nothing in its self-understanding;

Information — the mode of being of Nothing’s knowledge of itself; the first dependent.

Change — the succession of states of information, proceeding by the removal of opacity.

Distinction — the knowledge information has of its difference; its appearance is change.

Measures — parameters of the organization of distinguishedness;
Elementary changes — minimal units of manifest conditionedness;
Teleological completion — the limit state of the concordance of differences.

DISCUSSION

The derived structure of being shows that distinction is the central principle of reality. Differences are inapplicable to the absolute ground; they are posited only by the removal of the opacity of dependent information. This eliminates a second principle and makes the dependence of the conditioned on the immutable consistent.

The ontology is in concordance with fundamental physics: quantum processes display properties compatible with the informational ontology and receive a concordant interpretation in it. Cosmology receives an interpretation in which the origin of measures and manifest processes depends not on essence but on the unfolding of distinctions.

Consciousness is not an independent principle but self-knowledge accrued by the informational structure; this removes the gap between ontology and neuroscience. Reason and intellect are levels of the same consciousness, growing with the number of distinctions. The limit character of the structure fixes the boundaries of the conditioned and the completion of the process of distinctions.

Thus the ontology brings the logical, physical, cosmological and phenomenological levels into concordance and removes the former contradictions between philosophy and fundamental science.

Pre-emptive Replies to Critical Objections

Below are replies to objections against the key positions. The objections are of two kinds. The first ascribes to the unconditioned the structure of the conditioned: two and a relation, subject and action, knower and known, container and contained, before and after. Such objections are inapplicable to the unconditioned and are not examined on their merits: they demand that the unconditioned be conditioned, and abolish the subject of the question before the question. There is one reply to them — the rule of consideration: where there is no limitation, there is nothing by which these things are divided, and in unconditionedness they are not different. The second kind concerns method, the conditioned or the status of adjacent disciplines. These objections are examined on their merits, in their strongest form.

1. The Finiteness of Distinctions

Objection: what grounds the attainability of transparency if the number of blind spots has not been counted? Reply: this is derived in chapter 13. The number of distinctions is finite: the infinite is the unlimited, that is, the unconditioned; a series of distinctions is division, and an infinite series of distinctions is contradictory. Completeness is not a sum of sides: the object of knowledge is indivisible. The path to transparency is not measured by the number of steps: the completeness of self-understanding is not a sum of steps but knowledge of one object — one's dependence — as a whole. No new spots appear: there is nothing concealed in Nothing's knowledge of itself. The removal does not stop, and self-transparency is attained as a structural limit. The conclusion is in concordance with physical results: the Bekenstein bound, the holographic principle, the finite information content of the matter of the observable Universe (Vopson, 2021).

2. The Inevitability of the Methodological Framework

Objection: the impossibility of alternatives is shown within the framework, but the inevitability of the framework itself is not proved. Reply: the framework is not arbitrary but the result of exhausting the logical space. The determinacy that change requires can lie on only one of three sides: (a) on the side of the ground — change in essence, and immutability is violated; (b) on the side of a second independent principle — uniqueness is violated; (c) on

the side of the dependent. There is no fourth place: this is an exhaustive disjunction following from the structure of the aporia (chapter 4). Refusing to explain is not a strategy: it leaves the aporia unsolved. The present ontology occupies the third place and shows that it is the only consistent one. The objection would have force given a fourth place not reducible to the three. The burden of proof lies on the opponent: let him indicate such a place.

A possible objection: the inevitability of the framework is proved only in classical logic; paraconsistent logic admits that the ground both is and is not the source of distinction. Reply: paraconsistent logics only prohibit deriving anything whatever from a contradiction; accepting true contradictions is not paraconsistency but dialetheism. The objection is in substance dialetheic. The ground is defined by two minimal conditions: it is the source of D, and it is unique. If the ground both is and is not the source of D, then D both has and has not a source. Such a ground does not decide whether D has a source, and therefore does not do the work of a ground. Moreover, to assert “is and is not”, the dialetheist distinguishes the one from the other: without this the judgement has no meaning. The system requires only this — distinction, not classical logic in its entirety.

3. The Status of Physics: Empirical Convergence, Not Logical Dependence

Objection: the connection with physics is merely illustrative; it is not shown that physics logically requires this ontology. Reply: the ontology does not claim this. Physics is an empirical science and describes the regularities of phenomena. Something else is asserted: the ontology fixes structural features that physics discovers empirically. These are the informational character of elementary states, the finiteness of information in a bounded region (the Bekenstein bound), nonlocality (entanglement), the dependence of the result on measurement (collapse), and the energy cost of erasing information (Landauer’s principle). The conclusion is drawn independently of physical data, and the data converge with it. Physics here is in concordance with the derivation at the level of reality but is not its ground.

4. The Status of Necessity: Proof Beyond the Framework

Objection: alternatives are excluded only within the chosen framework; is the aporia not solved otherwise in another? Reply: the framework here is set not by the author but by the aporia itself — an immutable ground and a changeable reality. Every ontology that solves this aporia stands in the same framework. The aporia is fundamental not historically but logically: every other philosophical problem — including those of identity and modality in analytic metaphysics — already presupposes distinction. Without distinction one cannot tell one thing from another, establish identity or difference, or fix modality. The question of the conditions of possibility of distinction precedes these problems rather than competing with them. Therefore the aporia is not one formulation among others but the condition of every formulation.

The question of the conditions of possibility of change is obligatory: all thinking that uses distinction already presupposes a changeable reality. Refusing to explain its possibility does not abolish the question but leaves it unanswered. This is not an alternative ontology but a refusal of ontology. Process ontology claims another formulation — the “primacy of becoming”. But becoming presupposes the difference of “before” and “after”, that is, already contains distinguishedness as a given. The question of its conditions remains unanswered: becoming is declared primary but not explained. This is the same aporia, accepted as an axiom. The framework can be left only in two ways: (a) by abandoning the unconditionedness of the ground — this leads to an infinite regress of grounds; (b) by refusing to explain changeability — this is a direct refusal of ontological explanation. Therefore “another framework” is either the same one under another name or a refusal of a solution. There is no third.

The uniqueness of the scheme has a precise sense. It is the only structure that preserves the unconditionedness of the ground, the uniqueness of the principle and the immutability of

essence, explains change and introduces no differences into the ground. This is proved by exhausting the logical space in chapter 4, not by refuting alternatives from outside. A structure that violates at least one condition reproduces the aporia in one of the fixed types of contradiction.

The argument of point 2 applies here as well: every alternative framework formulates statements through distinction, and distinction is the minimal requirement of any logic, the paraconsistent included. Therefore an alternative framework stands on the same requirement with which the system begins — distinction. It may admit a contradictory ground, but it must then show that such a ground does the work of a ground.

5. The Arbitration Block: A Defence of Logic or the Immunization of the System?

Objection: the block of interpretive closure is a pre-established restriction of interpretation, a closing of discussion and an immunization of the system against criticism. Reply: the block does not forbid criticism; it forbids the substitution of terms. This is the ordinary procedure of every formalized discipline: mathematics fixes the meaning of symbols, logic of connectives, physics of quantities. Criticism is admissible and necessary, but it must deal with what the theory asserts, not with what the critic ascribes to it. The block performs the function of a dictionary, not of censorship: “Selfhood” means X, not Y; “initiation” means A, not B; “information” means P, not Q. Without such fixation every systematic ontology is vulnerable to the substitution of meanings. Immunization would exist if the block forbade objections on the merits. It does not: all objections on the merits — on the status of Selfhood, the nature of initiation, dependence, the limit, teleology, the relation to physics — are examined here openly.

6. The Totality of the Range of Distinctions

Objection: teleology presupposes the exhaustion of the full range of distinctions. How is it known that it has been exhausted? Reply: exhaustion is determined not by counting but structurally. The criterion is the self-transparency of information: there is no position within information from which anything remains undistinguished. A distinction not grasped by information’s knowledge of itself would be a blind spot; knowledge with a blind spot is not complete, and the task of the dependent leads to transparency. Therefore the range is exhausted if and only if there are no blind spots in information’s knowledge of itself. This is not an assumption but the definition of completion. The completeness of the set of distinctions is not postulated in advance but established retrospectively — when information’s knowledge of itself has closed upon itself. A strictly limited analogy: a proof is completed not by going through all the steps but by the conclusion that closes the chain.

7. The Exclusivity of the Scheme: Exhausting the Space of Strategies

Objection: the negative test shows the stability of the scheme, but not the exhaustion of the space of all models; there may be models not considered. Reply: exclusivity is proved not by going through systems, of which there may be infinitely many, but by going through types of strategies, of which there is a finite number: they are set by the structure of the aporia. Every ontology that solves the aporia contains three elements: the ground, the derivative and the mechanism of connection. The ground: (a) differences are applicable to it — it is not absolute; (b) they are inapplicable — this is Nothing under any name. The mechanism of connection: (a) change in the ground — immutability is violated; (b) a second principle — uniqueness is violated; (c) change in the dependent sphere — no condition is violated. The dependent sphere: matter — presupposes properties and violates unconditionedness; spirit — introduces subjecthood and a second principle; information as the mode of being of the ground’s knowledge of itself — introduces no second principle, does not violate unconditionedness and requires no properties. The types are determined by binary forks, and therefore their number is finite. An opponent who asserts an unaccounted type must indicate the missing fork. Until it is indicated, the thesis of exhaustion stands.

8. The Status of Deduction: Ontological Necessity, Not Formal Derivability

Objection: the system is called deductive, but it contains no axioms, rules of inference or theorems in the formal-logical sense. Reply: the deduction here is ontological, not formal; the criterion of rigour is stability under negative modifications (see “Methodology”). Spinoza used the form “definitions — axioms — propositions”, but his proofs are not formal derivations in the modern sense either. The demand for formal axiomatization of metaphysics is a category mistake.

9. An Exogenous Model without Selfhood: Logical Possibility as a Primitive

Objection: a model “Nothing $\rightarrow$ logical possibility of distinction $\rightarrow$ structure” is possible without Selfhood and teleology. If it is consistent, the system is not unique. Reply: this model is not a consistent alternative. “Logical possibility” is a modal category, and modality belongs only to the conditioned: the possibility of succession is given together with the determinacy of information (chapter 11), and it is inapplicable to the unconditioned. Introduced as a primitive, the “possibility of distinction” can lie on only one of three sides. On the side of the ground — modal structure is introduced into it, and unconditionedness is violated. On the side of a second principle — uniqueness is violated. On the side of the dependent — it is a possibility in the determined, that is, in information. But information is the mode of being of Nothing’s knowledge of itself, and complete knowledge of oneself is self-understanding — Selfhood (chapter 8). Selfhood has not been eliminated but merely left unnamed, and with it initiation and directedness return. In the first two cases the model falls into the space of contradictions of chapter 4; in the third it coincides with this ontology.

10. The Aporia of the Language Describing the Absolute

Objection: a description of the absolute, in which there are no distinctions, is impossible without introducing distinctions by the very act of description. Therefore the system is self-contradictory at the level of language.

Reply: the objection presupposes that a description must reproduce the structure of what is described. But this is required nowhere where limit concepts are at issue. Mathematics works with infinity without reproducing it: the concept is introduced by axioms and rules of inference and is tested by the consistency of derivation within the system, and externally by its applicability in physics and other sciences. This ontology is tested in the same way. Internally: each level is checked for correspondence with the initial conditions, and the violation of any of them at once reproduces the aporia. Externally: all philosophical and religious schools reproduce the aporia, and its removal here is a testable result. But the conditions of this ontology are not arbitrary axioms, as in mathematics, where systems can be chosen. They are derived from the structure of the aporia: three places for the determinacy of change, three prohibitions and a single set of conditions. The language of description belongs to the dependent and introduces no structure into the absolute — just as mathematical symbols do not introduce infinity into reality but fix the rules of working with it.

The character of the ontological claim is as follows. Mathematics does not claim to describe reality as such. This ontology claims more, but its realism is not naive: it does not say “this is how being is positively constituted”. It considers the encountered as conditioned and obtains the unconditioned as its limit; the unconditioned is spoken of only by remotions. The one position accepted without derivation is encountered change; everything else, including the dependence of the conditioned on the unconditioned, is derived. In this the analogy with mathematics holds: both instruments work with limit concepts through rules of inference, not through reproducing the object. The claim to reality is preserved — as a claim to the limit by which the encountered is determined, not to a positive content of the unconditioned. The conclusion that the conditioned

depends on the unconditioned cannot be rejected without making use of it: the three possible ways out are examined in chapter 4.

11. The Self-Understanding of Information as an Apparent Second Principle

Objection: the task of the dependent leads to the self-transparency of information — to self-knowledge without blind spots. But precisely this distinguishes Selfhood from information. If at the end of the path information knows itself, the difference disappears, and two principles remain with one property; uniqueness is violated. **Reply:** the objection confuses coincidence in form with coincidence in ontological status. Selfhood and information differ not by the presence of self-knowledge but by the nature of their existence. Selfhood's knowledge of itself did not arise and was not attained: it is together with transparency, and transparency is unconditionedness. The self-understanding of information is accrued — a state that has a history. In form they would coincide; in nature they are different: one precedes all temporality, the other would be its result. Moreover, the self-transparency of information is not unconditionedness: information that has understood itself remains dependent, determined and conditioned. No second unconditioned arises.

LIMITATIONS OF THE STUDY

The ontology makes no claim to empirical testability and does not compete with the natural sciences. The criterion of its soundness is not falsification but logical inevitability: an alternative is considered insofar as its acceptance leads to contradiction — a violation of the immutability of the ground, a second principle or a hidden becoming in Nothing. Therefore the “ontologically necessary” differs from the “accepted in the system” by a negative proof of the impossibility of alternatives, not by empirical testing.

The ontology explains the origin of distinction: it is posited by the removal of the opacity of information to itself, proceeding from Selfhood. What is not explained is something else — why the unconditioned is as it is: this question is inapplicable to the unconditioned, for it presupposes a ground for what is by itself.

1. The absolute ground is not subject to empirical confirmation

Nothing is derived logically but is not detected by the means of physical or neuroscientific experiment. Concordance with physics is the compatibility of the derivation with the data at the level of reality, not its ground and not a derivation of physical laws. The system gives no discriminating predictions: coincidences with physics show compatibility, not exclusivity. The derivation is made independently, and the data converge with it. Therefore the ontology does not compete with physics in predictions and metrics and does not claim the status of a physical theory. Its task is not to replace scientific models but to clarify their ontological presuppositions and limits. The absence of empirical testing of the ground is not a deficiency: the system operates at a level that precedes measurable quantities and experimental procedures. The sciences remain autonomous in their choice of formalisms, interpretations and empirical criteria. The system occupies a metatheoretical position: experiment does not test it, but it can be assessed by its internal consistency and its concordance with established scientific facts.

2. The ontology does not describe the individual properties of consciousness

It shows that consciousness exists and by what it is given, but does not explain the variability of subjective states.

3. Physical processes are treated as manifest forms of information

This limits the application of the ontology in fields where concrete numerical descriptions and experimental metrics are required.

4. Emergent levels depend on the concordance of distinctions

The development of complex forms (reason, systemic interactions) is not guaranteed and depends on the stability of informational configurations.

5. Teleological completion is not a dynamic process

It describes the limit state of the structure but gives no mechanism of transition to it in empirical systems.

6. The ontology is not intended to explain cultural, social or historical processes

It does not explain the content of cultural, social and historical processes and does not derive them from the ontological ground. What is fixed are only structural informational regimes — the concordance and discordance of configurations — which may be found in these processes. Their application to concrete historical material lies beyond the scope of the work and requires separate justification.

OPEN QUESTIONS

Here it is stated what the system does not establish, and why. The questions differ in kind: some are closed to all cognition from within Something, others lie outside ontology, still others remain a task.

The measure of the degree of the *I*. The degree of the *I* is determined qualitatively: by the extent to which the distinctions of a configuration distinguish its own states (chapter 12). The system gives no quantitative measure. The measure of integrated information is inapplicable here: it rests on the exclusion postulate, which the system rejects (chapter 12). To construct a measure compatible with the nesting of the *I* is a task the system leaves open; there is no prohibition of it in the system.

The magnitude of elementary duration. The smallest duration is derived: it is the duration of one change, for the step is indivisible (chapter 15). Its magnitude is not derived: magnitude is a matter of measure, not of derivation. Whether it coincides with the Planck time only physics can decide, and has not yet decided: experiment does not reach this scale. Here the ontology poses a question whose answer lies outside it.

Other bearers of intellect. All configurations are potential bearers of intellect. By what path it is attained is derived (chapters 20–21). Whether there are bearers of intellect realized outside what is accessible to us, the system does not assert: consciousness detects only what is represented in the structure of distinctions accessible to it (chapter 12).

The accepted position. The system stands on one accepted position: reality is, and together with it change is encountered (chapter 4). It is not proved, but it cannot be rejected without making use of distinction: whoever denies it distinguishes his denial from what is affirmed. Everything else, including the dependence of the conditioned on the unconditioned, is derived (chapter 4). This is a boundary common to every system: something in it is accepted; here what is accepted is reduced to one, and its negation makes use of it.

CONTRIBUTION OF THE STUDY

1. The fundamental aporia is removed

The dependence of the conditioned on absolute immutability is consistently unfolded on one openly accepted position — without a second principle and without violating the unconditionedness of the ground.

2. A universal structure of distinction is derived

Distinction is the knowledge information has of its difference from that whose mode of being it is, proceeding by the removal of its opacity. This removes the former gaps in explaining the origin of multiplicity and change.

3. The ontology is brought into concordance with fundamental physics

Collapse, entanglement, nonlocality and the manifest structure of matter are interpreted as forms of informational dependences, not of material substances.

4. Consciousness has received a consistent ontological explanation

Consciousness is self-knowledge accrued by information with every distinction; the concordance of informational structures sets its measure, not its presence.

5. Reason and intellect are explained as levels of consciousness

Their appearance is derived from the development of distinguished informational states without introducing a new ontological level.

6. An integral ontological system is formulated

All levels — from Nothing to teleological completion — are derived successively and form a single consistent construction.

CONCLUSION

Given one accepted initial position, a consistent ontology is possible only by recognizing an unconditioned ground to which inner differences and transitions are inapplicable. From this ground are derived: self-understanding as Nothing's complete knowledge of itself; information as the mode of being of this knowledge and the first dependent; initiation as the removal of its opacity to itself; distinction as knowledge of difference, the appearance of which is change; consciousness, beginning with the first distinction; and all subsequent levels — elementary changes, the measures derived from them, aggregated forms, levels of consciousness — up to teleological completion.

The ontology gives a consistent way of considering the aporia of the origin of distinctions given an unconditioned ground and fixes the conditions of admissibility of dependent forms. It is correlated with fundamental physics at the level of the absence of logical contradictions and the convergence of data with the derivation. Consciousness and reason are described as forms of organized informational activity without a claim to their empirical explanation. Teleological completion is the limit state in which no new distinctions are required: it is the self-transparency of information, the realization of the task of the dependent. How the path to the limit is travelled by consciousnesses is the subject of a separate work, Eschatology. Thus the work gives an integral and consistent ontological description that unites fundamental philosophy, physics, cosmology, emergence and phenomenology into a single system.

APPENDIX. A FORMAL RECONSTRUCTION OF THE DERIVATION

The appendix sets out the skeleton of the derivation separately from the exposition. Notation: P — accepted position; R — rule of consideration; Df — definition; T — derived position. For each position it is indicated from what it follows and the place in the book where the derivation is unfolded. Symbolic logic is not applied: a full formalization of metaphysics requires formalizing “existence” itself and leads into a regress (see “Methodology”). The numbered form makes each step traceable without this contradiction.

A. The Accepted Position

P1. Reality is, and together with it change is encountered. Not derived; taken as given. It cannot be rejected without making use of distinction (chapter 4).

There are no other underived positions.

B. The Rule of Consideration

R. Inapplicable to the unconditioned is everything by which the conditioned is divided within itself: two and the relation, part and whole, bearer and states, subject and action, container and contained, before and after. Applicable is that by which the dependent is constituted:

nothing is thereby established about the unconditioned. To the conditioned, information included, the logic of conditionedness applies in full (chapter 4).

C. Definitions

Df1. The conditioned — that which is determined through difference from another, that is, limited.

Df2. The unconditioned — that to which no determinacy is applicable, and with it no limitation.

Df3. Knowledge — the name for the remotion of concealment, not a property and not a content.

Df4. Selfhood — Nothing taken in self-understanding.

Df5. Information — the mode of being of Nothing's knowledge of itself.

Df6. Difference — information's own determinacy: its difference from that whose mode of being it is.

Df7. Opacity — information's not knowing itself to the extent that self-knowledge has not been given to it by the removal.

Df8. Initiation — the removal of opacity in the dependent, proceeding from Selfhood.

Df9. Distinction — knowledge of difference.

Df10. Change — the onset of a new state of information.

Df11. Consciousness — self-knowledge accrued by information with every distinction.

Df12. The *I* — self-differentiation, given in knowledge of difference.

Df13. Connectedness — the mutual reference of the knowledges of distinctions.

D. Derivation: The Ground and the Dependent

T1. Everything encountered is conditioned. From P1, Df1: what is encountered is the distinguished, and the distinguished is "this and not that".

T2. Consideration proceeds by the means of the conditioned. From T1: every affirmation and negation is a distinction.

T3. The conditioned is determined by unconditionedness as its limit and does not reach it; to abolish unconditionedness is to abolish the conditioned. From T1, Df1, Df2: limitation is the absence of unconditionedness, and the conditioned is determined by it and by nothing besides.

T4. The dependent has nothing by itself. From T3: the totality of dependence; no link of the chain of proximate grounds becomes the ultimate ground.

T5. Directedness towards the limit does not follow from determinacy by the limit. From T3.

T6. Nothing is absolutely unconditioned. From T3, Df2. "Is" here is the remotion of non-being, not a property.

T7. The unconditioned is immutable. From T6, R: change is non-identity, and non-identity is limitation.

T8. The unconditioned is unique. From T6, R: a second would limit the first.

T9. The unconditioned is transparent; self-understanding is Selfhood. From T6, R, Df3, Df4.

T10. The mode of being of the unconditioned in the dependent is a mode of knowledge. From T2, T9, R: the remotions are complete — there are as many as there are sides of the initial given; only self-understanding is compatible with the conditioned; the presence of the unconditioned can only be one-sided (chapter 5).

T11. Information is conditioned: determined and limited. From Df5, Df1.

T12. Encountered change is change of information. From P1, T7, T8, T10, Df5: change is neither in the unconditioned nor in a second, hence in the dependent, and the dependent is information.

T13. Distinction in information is not by itself; there is opacity. From T4, Df6, Df7: knowledge of difference does not enter determinacy.

T14. The removal proceeds from Selfhood. From T13, T8: there is no other remover.

T15. Distinction and change are one from two sides; change is onset. From Df9, Df10, T14.

T16. The knowledge of information accrues and does not decrease. From T14, T4: the removal is one-sided; there is nothing to restore opacity.

T17. Consciousness begins with the first distinction; with it the *I* is given. From Df11, Df12, T15.

T18. Connectedness makes consciousness one. From Df13: the unity of the source does not give the unity of consciousness.

T19. Self-transparency is attained and remains conditioned. From T16 (chapter 13): the object of knowledge is one — dependence; the spots are places of one opacity; the number of distinctions is finite — the infinite is the unlimited, that is, the unconditioned, and a series of distinctions is division; the object is one.

E. Derivation: The Levels of the Conditioned

T20. The constancy of the removal gives regularity, its one-sidedness the programme. From T14, T16; chapters 10, 13.

T21. Change has extent; the measures — time, speed, localization, space — are derived from the onset. From T15 and the prohibition of contradiction; chapter 15.

T22. Interaction is the mutual manifestation of instances of the *I*; the bond — an interaction that has held — is the agent of the programme. From T17, T20; chapters 16, 18.

T23. An aggregated form is held by a bond and by the equilibrium of attraction and repulsion; its identity is the continuity of the bond. From T22; chapter 17.

T24. Emergence is necessary as a tendency; the new in the whole is connectedness, not produced by the parts. From T16, T18; chapter 18.

T25. Materiality is the stability of connectedness against the proximate grounds of other configurations. From T23; chapter 19.

T26. Life is a form in which the *I* holds its own bond; instances of the *I* are nested. From T17, T23; chapter 20.

T27. Reason chooses a reaction within the conditions of the bond; intellect chooses the algorithm itself. From T22, T26; chapter 21.

F. Objections Ruled Out

Objection	Step	Where examined
Infinite regress of grounds	T3, T4	Chapter 4; Literature Review
The whole of the world as ground (priority monism)	T3	Chapter 4
Modal fatalism	T4, T27	Chapter 11; Literature Review
A second unconditioned	T8	Chapters 4, 8
A subject–object structure in the ground	T9, R	Chapter 8
Why information, and not spirit, energy or structure	T10	Chapter 9
Information requires a bearer	T11, T25	Chapter 19
Motive or arbitrariness of initiation	T14, R	Chapters 10, 11
Distinction as an ultimate fact of the dependent	T13	Chapter 10
Decrease of knowledge through proximate grounds	T16	Chapter 10
The combination problem	T18	Chapter 12
The exclusion postulate	T18, T26	Chapter 12
Causal exclusion	T22, T24	Chapters 18, 19
Weak or strong emergence	T24	Chapter 18
Regress of the bond (Bradley)	T22	Chapter 18

The ship of Theseus	T23	Chapter 17
Panpsychism and the “conscious stone”	T17, T25	Chapter 19
An infinite series of steps to transparency	T19	Chapter 13

G. Dependence on the Accepted Position

The accepted position is one — P1, and the whole derivation stands on it. Everything said about the unconditioned, T3–T10 and T14, is derived from T1 through the definition of limitation: the conditioned is determined by the absence of unconditionedness and by nothing besides (T3). Whoever rejects T3 rejects not something accepted but a derivation, and must indicate an error in it; the three possible ways out are examined and closed (chapter 4), and the derivation cannot be rejected without making use of it.

H. Figures

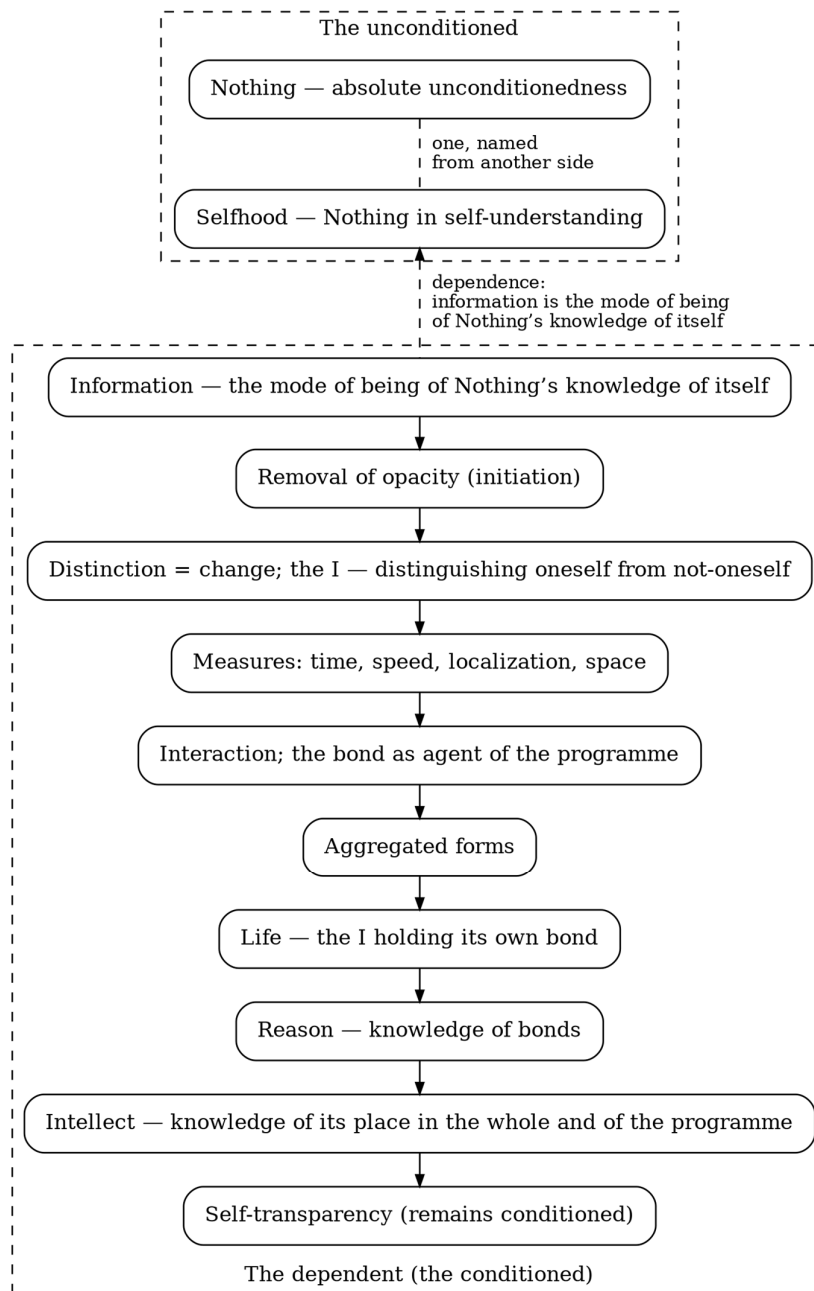


Figure 1. The levels of the ontological structure. The arrows within the dependent indicate the order of derivation, not of arising; the dashed arrow indicates dependence, not generation.

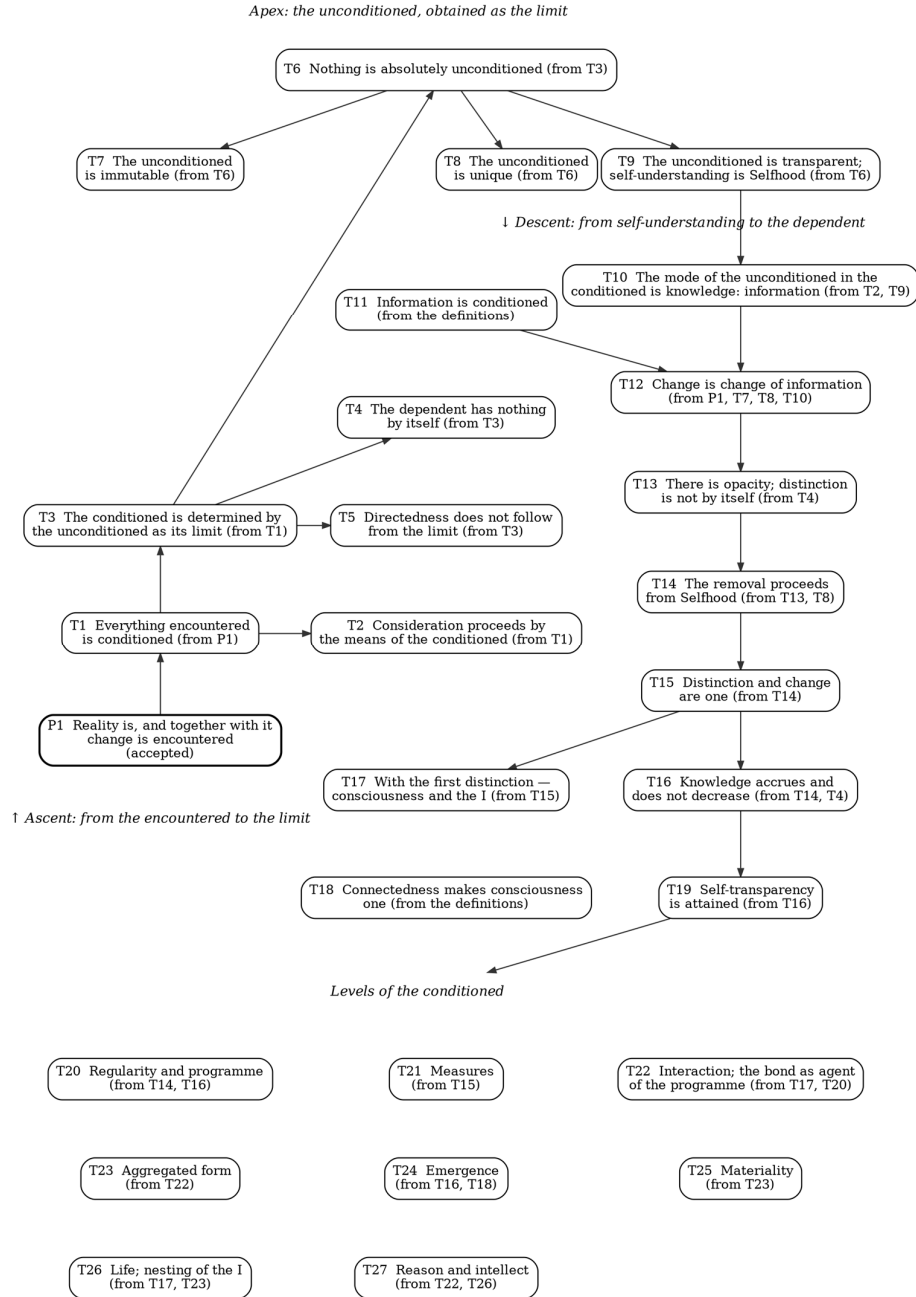


Figure 2. The course of the derivation: the ascent from the encountered to the limit and the descent from self-understanding to the dependent. Each box gives a position and its supports according to sections A–E of the appendix; the accepted position is one — P1.

GLOSSARY OF TERMS

Agent of the programme — a bond between instances of the *I* that sets for each of them its algorithm of functioning; it itself has its own instance of the *I* (chapters 16, 18).

Aggregated form (configuration) — a stable connected whole of elementary changes; the bearer of consciousness.

Blind spot — that in which information does not yet know itself.

Bond — an interaction that has held and become constant; it sets a common algorithm of functioning for the sides (chapter 16).

Change — the succession of states; the non-identity of the present and the former.

Conditional selfhood — the self-understanding acquired by information in a configuration; it bears the name of Selfhood but belongs to the category of the dependent.

Consciousness — self-knowledge accrued by information with every distinction.

Difference — information's own determinacy; it exists without succession.

Distinction — knowledge of difference; taken as that by which this knowledge is given, it is change.

Elementary change — a minimal distinction in information.

Emergence — knowledge of the whole that individual distinctions do not have.

The encountered — what is found as given: reality together with change.

Experience — memory that has changed the algorithm of functioning (chapter 20).

The I — self-differentiation, given in knowledge of difference; it exists from the first distinction and differs in degree (chapters 11, 12).

Information — the mode of being of Nothing's knowledge of itself; the first dependent.

Initiation — the removal of opacity, proceeding from Selfhood; from the side of Selfhood it is not an event.

Intellect — the level of consciousness that knows its place in the whole and the programme.

Interaction — the concordance of distinguished configurations.

Life — a form in which the *I* holds its own bond: restores it when disturbed and takes from the external for this (chapter 20).

Limit experience — the state in which all blind spots have been removed by distinctions.

Matter — a stable aggregated form of information.

Measures — time, speed, localization and space, derived from the working moment of an elementary change.

Memory — the bond of the *I* of a configuration in its present state with the distinctions it has had; forgetting is a break of this bond, not a decrease of knowledge (chapter 20).

Nothing — the name of absolute unconditionedness; limitation, determinacy and differences are inapplicable to it.

Opacity — information's not knowing itself to the extent that self-knowledge has not been given to it by the removal.

Programme — the directedness of the removal of opacity, set by initiation.

Reason — the level of consciousness that knows the bonds between distinctions.

Remotion — a statement of what is inapplicable to the unconditioned.

Self-understanding — complete knowledge of oneself; the name for the remotion of non-understanding of oneself.

Selfhood — Nothing taken in self-understanding; not a second beside Nothing.

Stage — the path of information in one universe; it is completed at a measure of removal sufficient for intellect.

Transparency — the inapplicability of opacity; for information, the completeness of self-understanding in its own category.

Unconditionedness — the inapplicability of limitation; the limit by which the conditioned is determined and which it does not reach.

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